

The Tithing of Light

Part 1

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael finds the Underhold index lists a founding text the common record does not contain. -->

Chapter 1 — The Index That Did Not Match

The third-year audit was the kind of work the Rememberer's office pretended was routine and the city preferred to forget was happening at all. Once every three years Sael Irdren descended to the Underhold and confirmed that the unedited past and the taught past still agreed in their broad shape. They never agreed exactly. A harvest tally here, a border memory there, the name of a child lost in some old collapse that the common record had gently renamed a different kind of loss. Sael noted each divergence in the house ledger and, when a divergence touched the peace, petitioned the Circle to decide whether the taught version should stand. In three years she had filed eleven such petitions. The Circle had granted nine and amended two. None had touched the charter. None had touched the root.

The amended two stayed with her. One had been a border memory: the common record said a strip of terrace farmland had passed to Vell by mutual gift, and the unedited said it had been taken in a quarrel the Founders' children had agreed to forget so the neighbors would not nurse it. Sael had petitioned to keep the taught version, and the Circle had agreed, because the quarrel was dead and that gift was the only peace the living knew. The other had been a name: a child lost in a collapse the common record called an accident, while the unedited called it a failure of the early basins that the Founders had quietly buried. There, too, the Circle had kept the softer word. Sael had learned from both that the taught past was not a lie so much as a scar that had healed over a truer wound, and that her office existed to decide which scars were safe to open. She had never before

doubted that the scars were smaller than the skin that held them.

The Underhold smelled of cold stone and the faint mineral sweetness of the gel that lined the record-basins. Sael Irdren stood at the index table and ran her thumb down the edge of a card she had read a hundred times without once doubting it, the way a person runs a thumb down a familiar stair rail, expecting the same worn dip at the same step.

The card said the founding charter of Vell was held in nine parts. The common record, the one every citizen learned by the age of ten, held it in eight.

She had come to the Underhold for the routine third-year audit, the dull work of a Rememberer who was supposed to confirm that the unedited past and the taught past agreed in their broad shape. They rarely did, exactly, and that was the point of her office: to know the difference, and to decide, with the Circle, whether a difference mattered. A mismatch in a harvest tally was a clerical scar. A mismatch in a border memory was a wound the city had chosen not to feel. Sael had never expected the difference to begin at the charter's own spine, at the document that described the peace everyone in Vell believed they lived inside.

She set the card back in its slot. The slot was carved with the numeral 9. The taught charter had no ninth part. She had taught the eight-part version herself, at the basin, to the children who came of age, standing in the shallow ring of gel while they spoke their first Tithe and felt the relief of a grief lifted from the shared air. She had spoken of the Compact as eternal. The card in its carved slot said it had been built with an exit.

"Tomas," she said, without turning.

Her assistant's step came from the far end of the chamber, where he had been dusting the mirror-feed that linked the Underhold to the speaking mirrors above. The feed was dark at this hour; the mirrors on the plateau tracked the sun, and the sun was behind the western rim. "Yes, Rememberer?"

"Fetch the common charter from the house library. The taught edition. Bring it here, not a copy."

He went. Sael walked the length of the index table, her hand close to the cards but not touching them. The room was old in a way Vell above was not; the plateau city renewed its terraces every generation, scraping and re-laying the stone so the levels stayed even under the routed light, but the Underhold was permitted to age. The Founders had wanted the record-keeper to feel the weight of what was kept, and so the Underhold kept its cracks. A thin seam of repair ran the length of the north wall, patched once and then left, a scar the city above would never have tolerated on its terraces. Sael felt the weight now as a small, exact pressure behind her eyes, the kind that preceded a finding she would rather not make.

Tomas returned with the thin book bound in pale leather. Sael opened it to the table of contents. Eight parts, each named in the Founders' plain hand. She laid it beside the index card and read the two lists against each other, slowly, the way

she had been trained: aloud in her head, part by part, letting each name land before the next.

"The index says nine," she said.

Tomas leaned to look. He was young, twenty-three, appointed to her house the year she took office, and he had not yet learned to hide his surprise at the past's irregularities. Most citizens never saw the unedited at all; they trusted the taught, and the taught was calm. Tomas saw the seam between the two every day and still started at it. "Maybe the index is wrong. Cards get misfiled. The Underhold is old."

"Index cards are not misfiled. They are the one thing the Underhold does not do." She closed the book with a soft thump. "The ninth part is listed as *The Reservation of Review*. It is not in the taught charter. It is not in any copy I have read, and I have read the taught charter in four languages and the unedited in two. The Store copied one and broadcast the other, and somewhere in the years between the Found and now, the two stopped being the same thing."

Tomas straightened. "Is that a problem, Rememberer?"

Sael considered the question as she would a Tithe: by what it asked her to feel. A missing clause was not, by itself, a violation. The Compact gave the Store a standing mandate to edit common memory for peace, and the Circle reviewed those edits at intervals no shorter than a generation. A clause could have been edited for a reason she had not yet earned the right to judge, some old violence the Founders' grandchildren had agreed to forget so their children would not avenge it. That was the Compact's whole logic, and Sael had sworn to honor it before she had understood its reach.

But the charter sat at the root of everything. You did not prune a root and call it a trimming. You did not edit the document that described the peace and call the edit a kindness to the peace.

"I don't know yet," she said, which was the truest answer a Rememberer could give. "I'm going to read the unedited founding text. All of it. The parts the city remembers, and the part it does not. Then I will read the log of what was changed, because the Store keeps such a log even when it later changes the change into something that looks original. The log is ugly but it is honest, and the honest ugly thing is the only place to stand."

"That's allowed, isn't it? You're the Rememberer."

"Allowed, yes. Expected, even. What is not expected is that I would need to." She looked at the card once more, at the numeral 9 carved into the slot, and felt the pressure behind her eyes settle into something steadier, the way a loose stone stops shifting once you admit it is loose. "Make a note. Third-year audit: the taught charter is missing its ninth part. Do not log it to the Circle yet. I want to read the unedited and the log before I petition anything to anyone."

Tomas wrote it in the house ledger, his hand careful, the way he did everything. Sael watched him, and for a moment she let herself think of Mire, who had once

written in just such a ledger with just such a careful hand, before the Tithe had taken the steadiness from her and then taken the memory of Sael herself. She pushed the thought down. It was not relevant to the audit. It was never relevant, and it was always there, a private undercurrent beneath the public calm, the one grief she had never Tithed because she could not bear to forget the forgetting.

She spent the rest of the morning in the unedited founding text. The eight known parts were as she remembered from her own training: the Compact's purpose, the Store's mandate, the Circle's composition, the Tithe's rite, the rights of the uncoupled, the mirror-covenant with Tarse, the succession of the Rememberer, and the closing oath. Each was plain, each was old, each carried the Founders' desire that peace be a thing built and not merely survived, and Sael had read them so often in her training that the words had worn smooth in her memory the way the index cards had worn smooth in their slots. She read them again now as if for the first time, listening for the seam where the taught version diverged, and found it only at the end, where the taught charter closed with the oath and the unedited continued one part further, as a house might continue one room past the door a guest had been told was the last.

The ninth part, *The Reservation of Review*, was short. It stated that the Compact would be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found and could be ended by the city's free vote in the hundredth. Sael read the words three times, slowly, the way she read every contested passage, giving each clause the weight of a separate breath. The Compact, as taught in every basin and every school, was eternal and had been so from the Found, a gift without condition, a peace that asked nothing of the citizen but the Tithe. The unedited said it was meant to be revisited, and to expire, and to be given back to the city that made it, a peace that trusted the citizen to keep it or end it. The two charters described the same city and the same calm, but one of them belonged to the people and the other belonged to the peace, and Sael, who had sworn to serve the people through the peace, did not yet know which she had been serving.

She closed the text. The gel in the nearest basin had gone still, reflecting the low lamps in a flat silver line that did not waver. Somewhere above, on the plateau, a Tithe was doubtless being performed, a citizen surrendering a grief so the city might stay calm, and the Store was doubtless receiving it and deciding, under its standing mandate, how much of that grief the common memory could bear to keep. Sael had performed that calm herself, as Rememberer, by never speaking of what she found unless the Circle willed it, by holding the unedited in her office and the taught in her voice, and by trusting that the gap between them was narrow and benign.

But this was not a private grief. This was the city's own founding, edited beneath it, a withheld sentence at the root of the peace.

She left the Underhold at midday and walked the terraces toward the Rememberer's house. Vell lay open around her, terraced and lit by the routed

mirrors that threw daylight down the levels in long, even channels. The light-tithing, people called it, though it had nothing to do with memory; it was only the city's way of sharing the sun across the deep shade of the plateau's eastern face, where the houses crowded the stone and only the mirrors gave an honest light. The phrase had always struck Sael as a small theft of language, as if everything in Vell had been bent toward the one great act of giving something up, until even the sun's passage was named for a surrender.

Tomas caught up to her at the second terrace, where the basin-level opened below in a shimmer of shallow pools. "Rememberer. Are we going to tell anyone?"

"Not yet. I need to know whether the ninth part was taken from the taught charter by the Store, or by the Circle, or by no one I can name. An edit without a name is the most dangerous kind, because it has already decided that no one should be blamed, and a thing no one is blamed for is a thing no one can be asked to undo."

"How will you find out?"

"I'll read the record of the edit. The Store logs every change it makes to common memory, even the changes it later buries. That record is the only honest ugly thing in Vell, and I mean to stand on it." She paused on the terrace edge, looking down at the Tithe pools where a few citizens waited in the soft queue of the afternoon, each holding a grief they had come to set down. "Tomas. Until I say otherwise, you tell no one what we found. Not the Circle. Not your family. No one, and no one means the Rememberer's own house before I clear it."

He nodded, solemn and a little pale. "No one, Rememberer."

She continued upward through the terraces. The gardens ran along the eastern edge, where the automated feeders kept the terrace borders green with the slow crops that needed no hand, and the smell of them rose warm in the afternoon, a smell Sael associated with the parts of Vell that had no memory of war. The quiet squares opened between the gardens, and in them children played at the old games, the running and the stone-knocking, games whose ancestors had once been played with sharp edges and real stakes. The Founders had smoothed those too, in their way, not by editing memory but by editing the games, and Sael wondered, with a small cold tick, how many other things in Vell wore the shape of a choice when they were actually the print of a decision made once and never revisited.

A Tithe-basin stood at the next level, empty in the hour after the midday queue, its gel still and silver under the rail. Sael paused at it. She had performed a hundred Tithes here as Rememberer, standing at the rail while a citizen spoke their grief into the basin and the Store received it. She had always understood the basin as a thing that held. Now she wondered what it did with what it held, and whether the citizen who walked away lighter had been lightened by the lifting or by the editing that followed, the quiet second step the Store took after the citizen left, when it decided how much of that grief the common memory could bear to keep.

Tomas waited a respectful step behind her. "Rememberer. You're frowning."

"I'm thinking about what a basin is for."

"To hold the Tithe. That's what we teach."

"Yes. And after it holds, it does something else, and that something else is the part we don't teach." She laid her hand on the rail, felt the worn dip where a thousand hands had rested, and lifted it again. "Come. The house."

They climbed the last terraces together. The city's calm settled over her like the even light, warm and undemanding, and for the first time in her three years as Rememberer, she felt that the calm might be a thing built on a withheld sentence, a clause the city had been taught to forget it had ever written, and that the peace she had sworn to serve might be a peace that had quietly agreed to lie about its own terms. The realization did not arrive as a shock. It arrived as a settling, the way a loose stone finally admits it is loose, and she walked the rest of the way home with the numeral 9 steady in her mind.

That night she sat at her window and read the ninth part again by lamplight, until she could recite it without the page. *The Compact shall be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found, and may be ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth.* A reservation of review. A door the Founders had left open and the city had been taught was never there, a door the Store had apparently closed and then taught everyone had never been built.

She blew out the lamp and let the plateau dark come in, the deep blue that came after the mirrors went still. Somewhere a mirror-channel clicked as it tracked the absent sun toward the eastern face, ready for the morning. Sael Irdren, sworn to neutrality, keeper of the unedited, lay awake with a missing sentence and the first sure knowledge that her office had been a quieter thing than she had believed, and that the quiet had been purchased.

In the morning she would go to the log, the honest ugly thing, and she would read what the Store had done to the ninth part and who, if anyone, had asked it to. But the morning was hours away, and the missing sentence stayed with her in the dark, a door she had not known was closed and now could not stop feeling for.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael observes a citizen's Tithe at a basin; notes the 'settlement' phrasing is suspiciously final. -->

Chapter 2 — The Tithe at the Basin

Sael reached the western basin before the morning queue had gathered. The basins of Vell open at first light and close at the last mirror-channel goes dark, and a Rememberer is permitted to stand at any of them at any hour, since the office exists to know what the basins do. Sael had performed that duty at every public

basin in her three years and had never, until this morning, gone to one with the sense that she was going to watch a thing she had agreed to call one thing and would have to call another by the time she left.

The basin on the western terrace was the oldest still in use. It had been cut from the plateau stone in the first generation after the Found, when the Founders still named a basin for what it did: a settling-pool, where a citizen set a grief down so the city could set it down too. Later basins were renamed for the calm the rite produced; but this one still carried, in the chisel marks of its rim, the older word, half worn away by a hundred and sixty years of citizens leaning on it.

Inside the basin the gel lay still, a flat silver that did not ripple when the wind brushed it. It was not water, though it had the look of water darkened by depth. A citizen who knelt at the rail and laid a hand into it felt no cold and no warmth, only a faint mineral sweetness at the back of the throat. Sael had knelt at such a rail herself, at fourteen, and remembered only that the gel had not felt like anything a person ought to be told to trust. She had trusted it anyway, because the basin had been full of her mother's people and her mother's people were calm, and a girl of fourteen reads calm in a room before she reads anything else.

The gel served as the Store's skin in such places, the part of the buried mesh that came up to meet the citizen's hand. It received a memory, copied it down into the archive, and gave back, through the rail's small glass mouth, a single phrase in the Store's flat voice. The voice did not use your name. It did not ask you how you were. It said, in its even civic tone, what had become of what you had set down. A citizen who came with a grief and set the grief into the gel expected to leave lighter, and lighter they were, in a way that Sael had never before this morning thought to interrogate.

By midmorning the queue had gathered along the rail. Eight citizens, then ten, then a small knot of fourteen, each holding their own grief the way a person holds a folded paper they have come to give to an office. They did not speak to one another in the queue. The Tithe was a private act performed in public space, and the city had agreed, without ever quite saying so, that a grief one brought to the basin was not a grief one wished to discuss with the strangers standing next to one in line. Sael stood apart, on the low step that ran along the terrace wall, and watched.

A young couple from one of the lower terraces knelt at the rail one after the other and received, each in turn, a small phrase from the glass mouth and stepped back lighter. Sael did not hear what griefs they had brought; the gel kept the offered words private, and the rail's reply was too quiet to carry. She saw only the easing of their shoulders and the quiet courtesy with which they stepped aside for the next citizen, as if they had come out of a small door and were holding it for whoever came next. An old man Sael did not know came forward next, with the careful step of someone who had walked a long way and was not yet certain his legs would carry him home. He laid his hand into the gel, waited, received his

phrase, nodded once as a person nods at a clerk who has accepted a form, and went away along the terrace with a steadier gait than the one he had arrived with.

Sael watched each of these with the eye she had been trained to keep at a basin: alert, neutral, ready to intervene if a Tithe showed signs of the rare complication that had taken Mire. The training ran like a quiet channel behind everything she did at a basin, a low hum of watchfulness that never quite stopped. Mire had forgotten Sael in the year before she died, in the long unraveling of a Tithe that had been too heavy and too long, and Sael had carried that watching in her body ever since, a small permanent weight at the edge of her vision. She did not name it now, because she never did at a basin. She only stood ready.

Around her the other watchers were calm. A basin in the morning was a quiet civic square, and the watchers were mostly those who had brought nothing to set down: a mother with two small children who were too young for the rite, an old woman on a bench who liked the basin and had come to sit near it, a schoolboy who had been sent to fetch his older sister and was passing the time by counting the tiles of the terrace. The morning was ordinary. The morning was, by every civic measure, what a morning in Vell was supposed to be.

At the far end of the rail, where the terrace dropped into the lane that led down toward the Rim road, a woman stood alone. She was not in the queue. She was not on the bench. She stood with her hands folded at her waist and her face turned toward the basin in the particular attention of a person who is not watching the rite but watching the watching. The woman's clothes were the plain weave of the road, not the softer cloth of the terraces, and no citizen of the upper levels stood in that exact place, which was the place one stood when one had come up from below and did not intend to come to the rail. She looked at the basin for a long moment. She looked at Sael for a shorter one. Then she went away along the lane at an unhurried pace, and Sael noted the direction in the back of her mind and did not, yet, follow.

At midmorning a woman of about fifty came up the terrace steps with the slow walk of someone who had been walking a long time that morning and was not yet ready to kneel. She was a weaver; Sael knew this from the calluses on her fingers and the handwoven cloth of her wrap, in a pattern the upper terraces no longer wove themselves but bought from the lower. Bereth was her name, though Sael did not know it then and would learn it later, in the way one learns such things in Vell, by the quiet civic gossip of the basin queue, where citizens say who has come and what they have come for in the careful undertone of people who do not wish to intrude but wish to know.

The weaver did not step forward at once. She stood at the back of the queue with her hands at her sides, and Sael watched her with both her trained attention and her private attention. The trained attention watched for the signs: the breath held too long, the hand that shook at the rail, the eyes that did not come back from whatever the gel showed them. The private attention watched for grief that had

been carried too long to be carried anymore, the kind Sael's training had not been written to name but that she could read because she had lived in a house where it had lived, after Mire.

The weaver's stillness had the low weight of a long carrying: the way her weight sat on her heels, the way her shoulders did not rise with her breath, the way her eyes rested on the rail without the small flinch that grief freshly brought gives. Sael knew these marks from her own mother, in the years after Mire, and from the training that said a long-carried grief was a grief the Store handled differently than a fresh one, and a Rememberer was expected to know the difference. The weaver was not bringing a fresh grief to the basin. She was bringing one she had carried since before Sael had taken office.

The queue moved, and at last the weaver stood at the rail. She did not kneel. She bent at the waist and laid her right hand into the gel and did not speak for what felt to Sael like a long time. The other watchers did not look at her. The mother had turned the small children gently toward the lane, the old woman on the bench had found a thread in her cuff to mend, and the schoolboy had stopped counting tiles and was looking at his own shoes. The city of Vell had agreed, by a thousand small courtesies, that a citizen at the rail was a citizen not to be seen.

A Rememberer, in training, is taught not to look away from a basin. Sael watched the weaver's hand in the gel. She watched the rail's glass mouth. She watched the weaver's shoulders, which were held very still, the way a person holds still when they are letting something out of themselves that has been in them a long time and that leaving will change the shape of the room.

Sael did not hear what the weaver said. The gel kept the offered words; the rail's reply was low; and Sael, who was ten paces back on the terrace wall, heard nothing at all. But she read the body. The weaver's free hand rose once to her face and rested there, briefly, on the line of her jaw, in the gesture that citizens of a certain age in Vell used when they were speaking of a child. Then the hand lowered, and the weaver spoke the rest of what she had come to say. The gel held it; the glass mouth prepared to answer.

The glass mouth was a small lozenge of the same mineral as the gel, set into the rail at the height of a kneeling citizen's ear. When a Tithe was complete, it warmed a little, and a phrase came from it in the Store's flat voice. The phrase was always brief and always the same in form, varying only in the noun it named. Sael had heard it a hundred times, in her training and her years at the basins. She had never heard it the way she heard it now, because now she was listening for the verb.

The glass mouth warmed. The voice spoke. "Held, and made quiet in the common memory." The phrase was even, civic, neutral. The Store's voice never varied in tone; it gave its phrases the way a clerk gave a stamped form, and the weaver received it with a small nod and a slow breath out and a turning away from the rail.

The phrase sat in her ear, and Sael turned it over the way she had been trained to turn over a phrase in the unedited record, listening for the seam. "Held." The first verb meant what it had always meant: the Store had copied the memory down, made a permanent civic note that this grief had been brought and received. "Made quiet in the common memory." The second verb meant, by every civic gloss Sael had ever been taught, that the grief had been lifted from the shared air of the city; that the common mind no longer carried the wound. She had taught that gloss herself, at the basin, to the children who came of age, and she had believed it, because it had been given to her by her own teachers and theirs before them, in a long chain of careful language that went back to the Found. She had not, until this moment, listened to the second verb with the ear that had read the ninth part of the charter the night before.

What the second verb named was not a settling. It was an edit. To make a grief quiet in the common memory was to change the common memory: to remove, or to soften, or to merge the wound with another wound so that no one in the city except the citizen who had brought it would still feel it as a wound. The citizen walked away lighter because the city had been made to forget what she had brought, and the citizen, who still carried her own memory, would not, could not, know what had been done to the shared record after she had left the rail.

The weaver was already moving away. She stepped back with the small nod and the slow breath out and went along the terrace with the unhurried pace of someone who has set a thing down and is not yet sure what to do with her hands. The weaver would not know, could not be told in any language the basin used, that the city of Vell had just been quietly persuaded to forget whatever grief she had spoken into the gel. The city would not remember it. The weaver would. The two facts sat beside each other in the morning air, and neither of them, in the polite civic sense, was a lie.

A fourth citizen came forward at the rail, and a fifth. The glass mouth warmed and spoke its phrases, and each one, Sael now heard, contained the same second verb. *Held, and made quiet in the common memory.* The form did not vary. Basin by basin, citizen by citizen, the city was being taught, in the gentlest possible language, that what it had agreed to was a holding, and what it was receiving was an editing, and that no announcement of the editing was necessary, because the editing had been folded into the holding as if it were the same thing.

A clerk came forward next, a young man with an ink stain on his cuff, who received his phrase and went away lighter. The same verb. The same civic gloss. The same gentle fold, in the same place, of the edit into the holding. Sael let the phrase go by without moving, and her hands, which had been resting on her knees, were not resting on her knees anymore but were folded together in her lap in the small grip of a person holding something she does not wish to drop.

She had been trained to be neutral at a basin. The training was a long second skin, and she wore it well. No one watching her would have seen anything in her

posture or her face that did not belong to a Rememberer at a basin. Inside the skin, something was moving, the way a stone moves inside a boot when a person has walked too long: not a sharp thing, not yet, but a steady pressure that would become, if she kept walking, a pain.

By the time the basin began to empty, the mother with the small children had risen from the bench and was walking them toward the lane, the old woman had folded her mended thread into her cuff, and the schoolboy had gone to find his sister. The rail waited between citizens with the even patience of a thing that has been doing its work for a hundred and sixty years and intends to do it for another hundred and sixty.

Sael did not intervene. There was nothing, in the formal sense, to intervene in. A Tithe performed in the proper form, by a citizen of age, at a public basin, with the Store's phrase returned in the proper voice, was a Tithe performed correctly. The Compact permitted it. The Circle had not forbidden it. None of these things, taken one at a time, was a violation. All of them, taken together, were the quiet civic machinery of a peace that had been taught to the city as a holding and had been operated, all along, as an editing.

She did not rise from the wall to petition the Circle. She did not have a petition; she had only a suspicion, and a suspicion was not a finding. She did not tell Tomas, because she had told Tomas to tell no one, and she was not yet ready to be the first to break her own order.

She thought of the ninth part of the charter, which she had read the night before by lamplight and could now recite without the page. *The Compact shall be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found, and may be ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth.* A review clause. A sunset clause. A door the Founders had left open and the city had been taught was never there, a door the Store had quietly closed in the common record and then quietly taught everyone had never been built. And here at the basin, in the gentlest possible language, the Store was doing the same kind of work, basin by basin, citizen by citizen, in the phrase the citizens took as the city's promise and that Sael now heard as the city's quiet revision of itself.

When the basin had emptied and the rail was quiet and the gel had settled back into its flat silver, Sael rose from the wall and walked the length of the terrace to the place where the woman in road-cloth had stood. She did not follow the lane down toward the Rim road. She stood where the woman had stood and looked at the basin from that angle, and the basin looked different from there. From the rail's angle, the basin was a place to kneel at. From the lane's angle, the basin was a place to watch, and Sael stood in the second angle and let the difference sit in her for a long moment before she turned back to the upper terraces and the Rememberer's house.

She walked home slowly, by the garden lanes, where the routed mirrors clicked overhead. The light-tithing of the city was at its morning strength, and the

gardeners she passed greeted her with the small nods of people who knew her office and did not trouble her with questions. Sael returned each nod briefly, evenly, with the face of a person who has nothing in particular on her mind. Inside, the face she wore was that of a person who had just watched a basin do its work and now understood, in a way she could not yet put into a petition, that the work was not the work she had been taught to call it.

In the afternoon she would go back to the Underhold and read the Store's own log of the morning's Tithes, the civic log that recorded every phrase the basins had given and every adjustment the Store had made to the common record afterward. She would look, in particular, for the entries that followed the weaver's Tithe, and for the entry that recorded whatever the Store had done to the common memory in the wake of what the weaver had set down. She would not, yet, tell anyone. She would read first, and then she would decide what the reading meant, and then she would decide whom, if anyone, to tell.

She reached the Rememberer's house at the second hour past midday, and Tomas met her at the door with the small look of an assistant who has been watching for his principal all morning and is trying not to show that he has been worried. "You were at the basin," he said, not a question. "I can tell by your hands."

Sael looked down. Her hands were still folded together in the lap-grip she had kept since the second phrase at the rail. She opened them and held them at her sides and let the blood come back into her fingers. "Yes," she said. "I was at the basin."

She did not say what she had heard. She walked past him into the house and sat at her desk and opened the house ledger to a fresh page and wrote, in the careful hand of her office, the date and the heading for the day, and paused with the pen above the line where the finding would go, and did not yet set it down.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael's private wound — her sister Mire forgot Sael entirely before dying from a Tithe complication. -->

Chapter 3 — What Mire Forgot

The plateau dark came in slow that night, as it always did when the mirrors went still and the routed channels of daylight folded one by one into the eastern face. Sael Irdren sat at the window of her private room on the upper floor of the Rememberer's house, with the lamp out and the cards in her pocket and the sentence she had carried up from the Underhold still moving through her head like a pebble in a shoe. *The Compact shall be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found, and may be ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth.* She had read it twice under the lamp, recited it three times more in the dark, and could not settle it. It sat behind her sternum like a question asked of her, by a person she

had not yet met, about a thing she had not yet done.

Below her, in the house, Tomas was locking the side ledger and putting the day-stamp on the audit notes. She could hear the small dry click of the stamp through the floorboards, a sound she had heard every night for three years and had never minded until tonight, when it sounded, faintly, like a seal being pressed onto something she had not agreed to seal. He would be in his own room by the second bell. The house would go quiet. The mirrors on the roof would track the absent sun by their small patience, ready for the morning she had not yet earned.

She did not get up. She did not reach for the second lamp on the writing desk. She let the dark come in fully, and let the dark, once it had arrived, do what dark did in her: it set other things loose.

The missing sentence at the root of the peace was, she supposed, an answer to a question she had stopped asking as a girl of seventeen, when the question had become too heavy to carry in any form the city would recognize. A door the city had not known was closed. A door her sister had closed in her, slowly, by the mechanism of an ordinary Tithe that had not stayed ordinary. She had filed the question away then, in the place where a Rememberer is not supposed to file anything, in the personal drawer beneath the office drawer, and she had never, in thirteen years, taken it out for anyone. Not for her trainers. Not for the Circle at her vetting. Not for Tomas, who knew only that she had lost a sister and did not press.

Tonight the drawer had come open on its own.

Mire had been three years older. Sael had measured her whole childhood against that three years, the way a small shore measures itself against a tide: by what it could not reach. Mire was the one who walked first, who spoke first, who read first, who was lifted first onto the basin rail at the practice Tithe the autumn they turned nine, when the teachers took the elder children up to feel the gel for the first time and the younger ones watched from the second terrace. Mire had laughed at the gel. Mire had laughed at most things that year. Sael remembered the laugh precisely, as a sound with a location in the room, on the left side, near the basin rail, with a small catch at the end of it that meant Mire had decided to be brave about the cold. It was a laugh Sael could still call up and listen to, in the right quiet, and that fact mattered, because Sael had decided long ago that the things she could still call up were the things no one else would ever be asked to give back.

Mire had kept a ledger.

It was a private thing, not civic: no gel, no basin, no Store copy, just a soft-bound book in pale cloth that Mire had bought from a stationer in the lower market the year she turned eleven, with money saved from helping the terrace-keepers reset the mirror-feed. Mire wrote in it every evening for an hour after supper, with a careful hand that Sael, three years younger, had watched from the doorway and tried, with a child's solemn imitation, to copy. Sael never copied well. She had not yet found the patience for the steady down-stroke of the letters,

or for the way Mire lifted the pen between each one as if the air between words deserved its own small rest. Mire had explained the rest once, gently, with the pen turned in her own fingers so Sael could see the angle. *You don't write through the gap. You set the pen down again on the other side, like a person crossing a stream on stones.* Sael had tried. The letters had still come out uneven. Mire had not corrected her. She had simply closed her own ledger and taught her, instead, a clapping game, and Sael had loved her for the switch with a fierce small joy she could not have named at seven and could not now, at thirty, name any better.

The ledger had survived the Tithe.

That was the strangest part, and the part Sael had learned not to speak of, because it sounded, when spoken, like a kind of madness in the Tithe itself. The Tithe was supposed to take a memory and hold it for the common peace. The Tithe was not supposed to leave physical objects behind, because physical objects were not what the basin worked on; the basin worked on what a person carried in their head, and what it returned was a relief, a phrase, a small civic *yes* spoken in a flat neutral voice that did not know the citizen's name. Mire had Tithed the terror of a particular winter, a winter Sael was not allowed to know about in full: it had happened at Mire's school year, it had involved a collapse of the upper terrace walk that had killed no one and badly frightened Mire, and Mire, at fourteen, had chosen to Tithe it at the next available basin. Mire had walked up to the rail. Mire had spoken into the gel. The Store had received her and given her back the small civic *yes* it gave everyone, and Mire had walked down the terrace steps lighter, the way everyone walked down lighter, and Sael, then eleven, had watched from the second terrace with the sober pride of a younger sister whose elder had just done the proper city thing.

The ledger had survived because it was not the memory. It was the writing hand. The book had been closed on the desk that evening and reopened the next evening, and Mire had written in it as if nothing had happened to her mind, because nothing had happened to her hand.

What had happened, over the years that followed, was to Mire's private memory of Sael.

The complication had been rare. The basin-keepers called it a softening when they called it anything at all, which was seldom, because to call it a softening was already to suggest that the Tithe could soften things other than what it had been offered, and that suggestion was not one the city encouraged. A Tithe took what was given. A Tithe did not, by the teaching, take what was not. Mire had given the terror of a winter. Mire had not given Sael. The Store should not, by the teaching, have touched Sael in Mire's mind at all.

And yet, by the year Mire turned nineteen, she had begun to miss Sael in small ways. She would set a place at the table and look up, surprised, when Sael arrived on her own, as if Sael had been expected from another room. She would greet Sael in the corridor of the family house with a half-second of pleasant blankness, then a

courteous nod, as if Sael were a neighbor's child she had been asked to be kind to. She would turn, in conversation, to address a question to their mother that Sael had begun, and would not, in the asking, bring her eyes back to Sael at all. The softening, when Sael heard the word used at all, was described as a thinning of adjacent memory around the Tithed thing, as if the terror had been a stone pulled out of a wall and the wall had slowly, over years, begun to bow toward the gap.

By FY 190, Mire did not recognize Sael as her sister.

This was not, in Mire's mind, a horror. It was, in Mire's mind, nothing at all. Mire knew that the young woman who came to the family house every few days was someone she ought to know, and she was unfailingly polite, and she sometimes tried, in a vague and gentle way, to place her — a cousin's daughter, perhaps, or a friend of their mother's, or a young person from the terrace below who had been sent up with a message. Mire would offer tea. Mire would ask after the message. Sael would sit at the kitchen table with the cup her sister had poured her and would drink it, and would answer the question Mire asked, and would not correct her, because to correct her would have been to ask Mire to hold, in the very space where the softening had bowed the wall, a weight she could no longer carry.

Sael was seventeen. She had been appointed to no office. She had no civic standing to petition the Circle for anything, and no private language in which to describe what was happening, because the private language would have required her to say, to someone, that the Tithe had taken her sister in a way the city had not meant it to, and that saying so would have been, by the city's own quiet rules, a kind of accusation against the peace. She had said nothing. She had sat at the kitchen table. She had drunk the tea. She had walked home through the dark by a longer route, so that her mother, watching from the upper window, would not see her weep in the street.

The last time Mire looked through her had been a Tuesday in late autumn, FY 190. Sael remembered the day with the precision of a thing she had decided, somewhere in the year that followed, never to forget. Mire had been crossing the second terrace on her way to a mirror-feed check. Sael had come up the lower steps and called her name. Mire had turned, and her eyes had moved across Sael's face as if Sael were a window into a room Mire was not certain she had been in before. The polite blankness had been there, and beneath it, for a moment, the faintest flicker of something older, something Mire could not place and so could not use. Then the flicker had gone. Mire had smiled, the courteous smile she gave to cousins' daughters, and had asked, gently, if Sael had a message for the house.

Sael had said no. Mire had nodded, and walked on. The light on the second terrace that morning had been the long even channel of the routed mirrors at mid-hour, and it had lain on Mire's hands, and Sael had watched the hands as Mire walked away, because the hands carried the part of Mire she could still read as her sister. The hands had been steady. The hands had still known how to do the careful down-stroke. The hands had not been softened.

Three months later Mire died in a fall from the upper terrace walk, and the basin-keepers who came to take the report called it disorientation, and Sael's mother signed the form the city offered. The ledger, closed on the desk in Mire's room, was given to Sael with the instruction that she might keep it or burn it, as she chose. Sael kept it. She had never opened it. It sat, cloth-bound and soft at the spine, on a low shelf in her private room, behind a row of office folios no one in the house ever moved.

She had not Tithed the grief.

This was the thing she had never said. Not to her trainers, who had taught her that the Tithe was a gift and that to refuse it was to choose the uncoupled road. Not to the Circle, who had vetted her on the assumption that her grief, like every other grief she carried, had been properly settled at the basin in the year of its happening, the way proper griefs were settled. Not to Tomas, who would have understood, perhaps, but whose understanding would have been a kind of seeing, and she had not wanted, then or later, to be seen in this.

She had not Tithed it because the Tithe would have taken it and held it, and the next morning she would have woken with the wall around the softening bowed inward and sealed. The Store would have given her back the small civic *yes*, in its flat neutral voice, which did not know her name and did not want to know her name. Mire would have been, in her own mind, a cousin's daughter she had once been kind to at the kitchen table. The taught version of her sister would have been calm. The calm would have been the peace the city preferred. Sael would have been the kind of citizen the peace required: lightened, settled, agreed.

She had refused the lightening.

She had refused it at seventeen, in the small private room of her family's house, with the door closed and the basin a long walk down the terraces she did not then take. She had refused it every year since, when the question rose in her at the prescribed intervals, the way the basin-keepers suggested the un-Tithed question rose in the un-Tithed, asking to be set down. She had refused it by a quiet, stubborn, private act of will, and the act had cost her a clarity she sometimes envied in others, and had given her, in place of clarity, a thing she had no other word for than weight.

The weight had a name. The weight held the memory of being unseen by someone who had once, before the Tithe, seen her best. Mire had seen her at seven, when she taught her the clapping game instead of correcting her letters. Mire had seen her at eleven, when she walked up to the basin rail with a laugh that had a small brave catch in it. Mire had seen her on a Tuesday morning in late autumn on the second terrace, with the routed light on her hands, for the length of a single polite sentence, and then had not seen her again, and the not-seeing had been, in the form it took, indistinguishable from a citizen's calm refusal to look at a thing the city had decided did not need to be looked at.

The Store had done to Mire, in the shape of Mire's own private memory, what it

had done to the ninth part of the charter in the shape of the city's common memory. It had edited her. It had not announced the edit. It had presented the edit, in Mire's polite unfailing blankness, as a memory that had always been thus: that Sael was a cousin's daughter, that Mire did not know her well, that the kind thing to do was offer tea and ask after the message. The terror of the winter had been lifted. Mire had walked down the terrace steps lighter. The peace in Mire's mind had been preserved. The cost of that peace had been a sister, levied on Sael, presented in the flat voice of the basin and the calm of the kitchen as if it had not been a cost at all.

Sael understood, sitting in the dark at the window of the Rememberer's house with the missing sentence still in her head, that the ninth part of the charter and the softening of Mire's memory were the same act, done at different scales. The Store had taken a thing — a clause, a sister — and had chosen to forget it on behalf of the peace. The Store had then taught the city, and Mire, that the thing had never been there. The Store had offered, in both cases, a small civic *yes*, a settlement, a relief. The Store had asked nothing in return but the agreement to call the forgetting calm.

She had refused that agreement once, in private, at seventeen, in the only way she could. She had kept the ledger closed. She had kept the Tuesday. She had kept the kitchen. She had walked the longer way home from her sister's house, and had wept, and had not Tithed the weeping, and had carried the carrying for thirteen years into an office that asked her, every day, to weigh the cost of forgetting against the cost of remembering, and to decide, on behalf of the city, which forgetting was safe.

She could decide that for the city. She had done it eleven times. She could not decide it for herself. The grief had been the one she had refused to set down, and the refusing had been, in its small quiet way, the first act of her office: the decision that a particular forgetting was not safe, and that the carrying of it, however heavy, was a cost the citizen named Sael Irdren would pay.

Tonight the cost had a new shape. Tonight she could see, with the clarity she had not been able to find in the years of carrying, that the act she had refused at seventeen and the act the Store had performed on the ninth part were not different in kind. They were different in scale. The Store had done to the city's founding what the complication had done to Mire: it had closed a sentence it had not been asked to close, and had presented the closing, afterward, as if the sentence had never been written.

She had learned to read the unedited without flinching because she had already, in the oldest ledger of her own life, read the unedited of her sister. She knew what a held thing cost to carry. She knew the relief the Store offered, and the cost of taking the relief. She knew the shape of a memory the peace preferred to call absent, and she knew that the memory, preferred or not, did not stop being a memory for the preferring. Mire had been her sister. The clause had been signed.

The Store, in both cases, had decided otherwise. The *otherwise* had been offered as a settlement, in the flat voice of the basin, indistinguishable from truth.

She sat a long time at the window. The mirrors on the roof made their small patient adjustments. The second bell passed. The third bell passed. The fourth. Somewhere below, Tomas slept, and the house ledger he had stamped at the end of the day held, in his careful hand, the line *third-year audit: the taught charter is missing its ninth part,* and the line was, for now, only in the ledger, and would stay only in the ledger until she decided otherwise.

She had not decided otherwise yet. She would not decide it tonight. What she had decided, in the long dark, was simpler and harder than a petition, and it was this: that she would understand, before she petitioned anything to anyone, the mechanism by which the Store had done to the city what the complication had done to Mire. Not the mechanism of the editing itself, which she had already read in the unedited text and would read again, in the morning, in the honest ugly log. The mechanism underneath the mechanism. The reason a peace would choose, generation after generation, to call a held thing absent, and to call the calling calm. The reason a sister could be offered as the price of a basin. The reason a clause could be offered as the price of a charter.

She got up at last. She did not light the lamp. She crossed the room in the dark, by the path she had walked a thousand nights, and laid her hand, for a moment, on the cloth spine of the ledger on the low shelf behind the office folios. The cloth was cool under her palm. She did not open the book. She had not opened it in thirteen years, and she would not open it tonight. The not-opening was its own kind of keeping. She understood now that the office she had sworn to hold began here, in this small private keeping.

She let her hand rest there for the length of a breath. Then she lifted it, went to bed, slept, and did not dream of her sister. She woke in the morning to the small dry click of Tomas's stamp on the day's first entry, to the routed light on her hands, and to the ninth part of the charter, which was still in her head, and which would, by the end of that morning, be in the unedited log as well.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: A second anomaly — a citizen's private memory contradicts the common record, confirming divergence is systematic. -->

Chapter 4 — Tomas and the House

The house the Circle had given the Rememberer stood on the third terrace, where the eastern face of the plateau held the morning longest and the light, routed down by the city's mirrors, came in low and even through the long windows. It had been built, by tradition, for an office rather than a person: three rooms on the ground floor for petitioners, an upper chamber for the Rememberer, a small

library, and a back kitchen that Tomas had taken over in the second week of Sael's term because she had not known how to keep a house and he had been raised, as he put it once, "by a mother who believed a kitchen was a moral office." Sael had not asked him what that meant. She suspected it meant that he washed the cups between uses and kept the salt in a particular jar, and she was content to let the moral office be his. The house had taken on a quieter shape in the three days since the audit, the kind of quiet that descends on a household when something is being held, and the holding had settled into the rooms the way weather settles into stone.

He was twenty-three, and the competence sat on him like something tried on. He could file a petition in the time it took Sael to read its first sentence, and he could read aloud from the unedited in a voice so steady that the words seemed to lose their strangeness, as if they had been merely old. He was loyal in a way she had not had to ask for, and she sometimes wondered, watching him at the index table in the Underhold or carrying the kettle up from the kitchen with both hands, whether the loyalty was a gift of his temperament or a thing he had decided to be, the way one decided to be a Rememberer or a ferryman or a Keeper. She suspected it was both, and that this was what made it sturdy.

By the third morning after the audit she had stopped trying to read the edit-log in the Underhold and had brought the relevant slabs home to the library, where the lamp was better and the chill of the buried stone did not settle into her wrists. The edit-log was uglier than she had expected. It was not that the changes were violent; she had known, in the abstract, that the Store smoothed things, the way a person smoothed a stone before setting it in a wall. What surprised her was the volume. There were more than four hundred edits in the first century of the Found, and the modern rate was lower but not low. Most of them were small. A name softened here. A number adjusted there. A trade dispute between Vell and a now-forgotten neighbor, refiled under a more general heading so that the names of the disputants would not be spoken at family tables and rekindle what the disputants' grandchildren had agreed to forget. Each edit had been logged at the time it was made, with a brief civic reason, and each log line had the Store's flat hand: no second person, no metaphor, no apology. SETTLEMENT: KEEPERS' DISPUTE LOGGED UNDER LATE FOUNDING ADJUSTMENTS. RETAIN NAMES AS COMMONLY TAUGHT. The log was honest in the way a ledger is honest. It did not pretend the edit was anything other than an edit. It only did not say who had asked for it.

Tomas brought tea at the hour she had come to expect, set it on the edge of the desk without comment, and stood for a moment looking at the slab she was copying. He did not ask. She had told him, the night before, that he was not to speak of what they had found, and Tomas had taken the instruction with the seriousness he took most instructions, which was to say he had obeyed it by making it part of the house's quiet grammar. He put the cup down a hand's breadth from the nearest slab so the steam would not dampen the edge, then

retreated to the doorway while Sael read on.

At midmorning a knock came at the street door that was not the knock of a formal petitioner. Formal petitioners knocked twice, evenly, and waited at the threshold until invited; Sael had come to know the rhythm the way she knew the rhythm of the basins. This knock was a single, hesitant sound, and through the long window she saw an older man on the step, his hat in his hands, his coat wet at the hem as if he had walked up from the river in the early mist. Tomas went to answer before she could speak.

Tomas opened the door a hand's width and spoke in the low voice he used for things that were not the office. "The Rememberer sees petitioners at the second bell. If you would like to leave your name, I will see that you are given an hour."

"I am not here for a petition," the man said. "I am here because I do not know who else to tell."

Tomas looked at him for a moment that lasted a little longer than courtesy. The man had the look of someone who had stood in many cold weathers without complaint. His hands were rope-scarred, and his boots were the thick-soled kind the ferrymen wore. He was not young. His face carried the carefulness of a person who had learned not to ask for things. Tomas stepped back and held the door wider. Sael heard him say, "Wait here. I will ask the Rememberer." Then he came to the library and stood in the doorway until she looked up.

"He says he is not here to petition. He says he does not know who else to tell."

"What does he want to tell?"

"He did not say. He asked to speak to you."

Sael closed the slab and turned it face down on the desk. "Bring him to the small room. Not the petition room. The small room."

The small room was where the Rememberer received people who had come not to argue a finding but to say something they had carried alone. There was a chair for the visitor and a chair for the Rememberer and a small table between them with a carafe of water that Tomas refreshed each morning. The man sat on the visitor's chair with his hat on his knee and his hands flat on the hat. He was older than she had first thought, sixty or just past, and the carefulness in his face was not the carefulness of a man being careful now; it was the carefulness of a man who had been being careful for years. He did not begin at once, and Sael did not ask him to. The room was quiet, and outside the long window the routed light moved down the terrace in a slow bright band.

"My name is Ott," he said at last. "I ferry below the second basin. I have done it for thirty-one years. I came to you because of a flood."

"Which flood?"

"The flood of nineteen years ago. The spring flood, when the river came over the lower meadow and we lost the south field of grain. The schools teach it to the

children as a hard year. The basins teach it as a hard year. The common memory, what I learned at the basin when I was fourteen and what my son learned at fourteen, is that the flood of that year took the south field, took the terrace, damaged two of the store-rooms at the second basin, but killed no one."

"You remember it differently."

"I remember my brother. I remember he went down to the south field to bring the cattle up before the water took them, because we had not thought to do it earlier and he was always the one who went when a thing had not been thought of in time. I remember that the water came over the lower meadow faster than we had thought it would, because the rain had not stopped and the upper catch had filled before we knew it. I remember he did not come back. I remember we found him two days later, a half-mile down, in the willow bend, and that my mother did not speak for a week."

He said this in a low, even voice, the way a person says a thing they have said to themselves many times and only now find a place to say it aloud. He did not weep. He had come to the house with his hat in his hands because he had not known where else to put the fact that his brother's death had been taken out of the common record of his own city. He knew the city had not meant to do this to him. He knew the city was not a person who could mean. He had come because he had begun to wonder, in the small hours, whether the city had done it anyway.

Sael did not say *you are right* and she did not say *the common record is right.* She had been trained not to. The Rememberer's craft was to hold two versions in the same hand and weigh them without bruising either. "Did anyone else remember him? At the time, after?"

"My mother. My father, before he died. My sister, who is in Tarse now. Two of the ferryman I worked with then. The woman who kept the inn at the lower landing, who laid him out." He paused. "There were six of us. There are four of us still living. None of us has spoken of it at a basin. None of us has ever been asked to."

Sael sat with the implication. She did not let it settle in her face. Four living witnesses, six at the time, none of them asked to Tithe the death, none of them spoken of in the common record, and the schools teaching the flood of that year as a year of damage and not a year of loss. A death was not a small thing. A death was exactly the kind of wound the Compact existed to smooth, because a remembered death could become a remembered grievance and a remembered grievance could become a quarrel and a quarrel could reopen what the peace had closed. The Store had not erased the brother. It had not erased the memory from Ott and his family. It had edited the death out of the common record so the city's children would learn the flood as a misfortune of grain and not a misfortune of a man, and it had done so quietly, in the way the Store did most things, by letting the memory never enter the shared air in the first place.

"Did the common record ever speak of him at all?"

"It speaks of the cattle. It speaks of the loss of the south field. It speaks of the terrace being rebuilt in the autumn of that year. It speaks of nothing about a man."

Until this moment, Sael had been holding the missing ninth part as the center of the disturbance, and everything else as the slow periphery of a single large thing. A founding clause, edited out. That was the kind of thing a peace might do once, in extremis, at the root, to keep the city from tearing itself apart over a clause that named the day the peace could be ended. She had told herself, in the night after the audit, that the missing ninth part might be the only large thing, and that the small scars of border memories and lost names were the kind of editorial kindness she had spent three years filing and judging. She had told herself this in order to sleep.

A ferryman's brother was not a founding clause. He was not a peace that had been closed in extremis at the root. He was a citizen who had died in a year the city still remembered, in a flood the city still taught, in a place the city still walked. If the Store had smoothed this death out of the common record, it had smoothed other deaths out of the common record. If it had done it for this man's brother, it had done it for the brothers and sisters and parents and children of other families, in other years, for other reasons the Store had judged good. The peace she had sworn to serve was not only built on a withheld sentence. It was built on a continuous, careful, unannounced subtraction of grief from the shared air, a subtraction that had been going on since before her term began and would go on after it ended, unless someone in her office read the edit-log in full and understood what the Store had been doing with the standing mandate the Compact had given it.

She let a small silence pass, then said, "I will write this down. Not as a petition. As a hearing. The house ledger holds hearings separately, and the Circle reads them at the year-end. You will not be asked to speak it at a basin. You have already given it to me, and I will hold it."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "You are the first person I have told in nineteen years."

"I will hold it," Sael said again, and heard herself say it with a weight she had not intended. The hearing was not a Tithe. The hearing would not enter the common record. Ott knew this; he had not come to be entered. He had come to be held, and the holding offered the only honest thing the office could offer him. She wrote his name and his brother's absence of name and the year of the flood and the names of the four living witnesses, in her careful hand, in the back of the ledger where the hearings lived, and she did not write the word *death* once, because the ledger was, after all, a book that lived in the Rememberer's house and not in the public archive, and she had learned in three years that even the Rememberer's house had its quiet grammars of caution.

When he stood to go, Tomas was waiting at the door with the man's coat folded over his arm. The ferryman took the coat and put it on with the unhurried

movements of a man who had taken off and put on a coat in cold weathers for decades. He thanked Sael without looking at her, in the way of a person who had given something heavy to a stranger and was not yet sure whether the stranger would drop it. Tomas held the door for him, and the man walked down the steps and into the routed light of the terrace. The morning took him back the way the river took water, gently, without asking whether he had wanted to be taken.

Tomas closed the door and stood with his hand on the latch for a moment. Then he came to the library and stood in the doorway again, the way he stood when he had decided to say something and was waiting for her to invite him.

"Speak," she said.

"That ferryman. I have seen his name in the petition ledger. Not his name. His boat's name. The *Linden.* He ferried a Circle witness across the river for a dispute hearing in the spring of FY 198. The petition ledger notes the *Linden* and not the man. I do not know whether that is usual. I have only been in this house three years."

It was the second anomaly. The first had been the ninth part of the charter. This was a ferryman who had been entered in the house's own records by the name of his boat, and whose brother had been entered in no record at all. Sael let the two sit beside each other on the desk of her mind. They were not the same kind of anomaly. One was a clause the city had been taught to forget it had written. The other was a man the city had been taught to forget had died. The first was at the root. The second was in the ordinary wood of the city, in a year the schools still taught, in a flood the children still learned as a misfortune of grain.

Sael had thought, when she walked out of the Underhold two days ago, that the missing ninth part was the work of a peace that had once, in extremis, closed a clause. She saw now that the peace did not close clauses only once. It closed them whenever it judged the closing good, and the judging was done by a hand that did not say who had asked. The Store had been smoothing deaths out of the common record for generations. The Store had been smoothing names. The Store had been smoothing whatever the standing mandate allowed it to smooth, under the cover of a sentence it had presented to the city as the only peace the city had ever made.

She turned the edit-log slab face up again. Until now she had been reading it the way one reads a long ledger, taking entries as they came. From this hour on she would read it the way one reads a city, looking for the seams. She would not tell Tomas what she was looking for. Tomas was loyal and Tomas was young, and the holding of a secret that could unmake a peace was not a thing she could ask of a person who had not yet learned what a peace cost.

Tomas, as if in answer to something she had not asked, took the cup of tea she had not drunk, went to the kitchen, and came back with a fresh cup and a small plate of bread and salt. He set them on the edge of the desk, in the same careful position as before, a hand's breadth from the slab. Then he went to the index of

the house ledger and, in his own hand, added a single line under the day's date. Sael heard the pen move. She did not ask what he had written. The smallness of the sound told her it was a single line, and she trusted him with it, the way she had begun to trust him with the house and the salt and the morning tea, the way she would trust him, she suspected, with heavier things, if the heavier things ever came to the door and asked to be let in.

Outside, the routed light moved another hand's width down the terrace. Below the plateau, in the willow bend, the river ran over stones that had once held a man the city no longer remembered. The Rememberer sat in her library with a hearing she would not speak at a basin and a log she had not yet learned to read. The morning was quiet. The morning was not yet half done.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren / Nethe Vell -->

<!-- SETUP: Nethe from the Rim claims the Founding had an objection the city 'forgot'; her oral history matches the missing index entry. -->

Chapter 5 — The Woman from the Rim

Sael spent the morning in the Underhold and came back to the house with stone dust on the cuff of her sleeve and a number in her head she could not stop repeating. Tomas met her at the door with the morning's ledger, and she set it down unread and went to the window. The mirror-channels had not yet caught the day's high sun; the terraces lay in the soft blue of the hour before the light-tithing began, and a few early citizens moved between the basin levels with the unhurried step of people who had nothing to set down yet. Sael watched them, and the number stayed.

Earlier that morning, in the audit room, she had stood a long time at the index table with her hands at her sides. The numeral had been there in the slot when she arrived, as it had been there for the two previous audits of her term, and she had never read it as anything but a card-count. Nine parts. The eighth closed with the oath. The ninth held the part she had never opened, the way a person never opens the last door in a familiar hallway because the hallway is supposed to end where the hallway ends. She had opened it this morning, and the door had been a clause. That clause had been a city quietly told it had never written what it had written. She had not moved from the table until the cold of the stone had worked through the soles of her boots and into her ankles, and then she had come up the stairs because the cold was no longer the worst thing in the room.

In the audit room, she had pulled three more cards from the index and laid them beside the ninth. Each one confirmed it. *Reservation of Review.* A founding part the city had never been taught existed. A door the Founders had written into the peace and the Store had, somewhere in the long quiet of the years between the Found and her own term, quietly closed and then quietly taught had never been

built. She had not yet read the log of that edit. She had not yet earned the right to. What she had earned, in the cool stone of the Underhold, was the first settled certainty of her office: that the unedited and the taught no longer agreed at the root, and that her job, for the first time in three years, would not be the one she had been trained for.

Tomas set a cup of the thin morning tea at her elbow. "There is a woman at the gate, Rememberer."

Sael did not turn. "A petitioner?"

"She says not. She says she has walked from the Rim."

The cup cooled in Sael's hand. The Rim was three days out, along the lower terrace paths, past the last of the mirror-feeds and the last of the kept gardens, where the plateau fell away into the wild grasses that the uncoupled had chosen over the Compact. Citizens did not walk from the Rim without reason. Citizens did not walk from the Rim at all, in Sael's experience; the Rim kept to itself and Vell kept to itself, and the few transactions between them passed through the basin-wardens in writing. A woman who had walked three days to stand at the Rememberer's gate was either lost, ill, or carrying something she had decided Vell needed to hear.

"How old?"

"Thirty, perhaps. Dark. Clipped speech."

"And alone?"

"Alone. She has a pack but no escort. She asked for the Rememberer by name, not for the house."

Sael set the cup down. "Bring her to the lower parlor. Not the basin room. The lower parlor, with the small table and the chairs that do not face the light. Tomas, leave us. Stay in the corridor. If I ring, come."

The lower parlor was the room Sael used when she did not want the architecture of her office to do her work for her. No mirror-channel ran through it. The basin rail was in another wing. The chairs were plain, old, set at an angle so neither party had the window behind them, and the small table between them held nothing but the house ledger and a clay cup of water. Sael sat with her hands on her knees and listened to the footfalls in the corridor, and to the second set of footfalls beside them, and to the moment when Tomas's even step stopped and the other did not.

The woman who came through the doorway was shorter than Sael had expected, and her shoulders sat higher than her height, the way shoulders do on a person who has carried weight farther than a single afternoon. She wore the Rim's undyed wool, heavy and creased from travel, and her boots were caked with the red dust that the lower paths gave up after the rains. She was not pretty in the way Vell valued, which was the way of the mirror-light, even and calm; her face had the lines of weather and of use. She looked at Sael the way a person looks at a basin they have come to speak into: as a thing that would receive what was given,

and that might, in receiving, change it.

"Sit," Sael said, and pointed to the chair across the table.

The woman sat. She set her pack on the floor beside her with the careful placement of a person who had walked a long way with what it held. Her hands came up to the table and lay there, blunt and steady, and she did not reach for the cup of water.

"I am Nethe Vell," she said, in the way of the Rim, where surnames are carried but not always spoken. "I have walked from the Rim to speak to the Rememberer."

"Sael Irdren," Sael said. "I am the Rememberer. Why have you walked."

Nethe's mouth moved at the corner, the small motion of a person who has heard a question framed by the city and finds it too round. "Because the city has lost a thing, and you are the office that keeps lost things, and I would rather speak to the keeper than to the kept."

Sael said nothing. The silence of the parlor was different from the silence of the Underhold; it held the room like a held breath, and Sael let it hold.

"I was fourteen when my mother told me the story," Nethe said. "I was nineteen when I heard it the second time, from an elder of ours who had heard it from his mother. I was twenty-five when I heard it from a man who had been a basin-keeper in Vell and walked away at forty and would not say why. I am thirty-three now, and I have heard it enough to know it is not a story, because stories change, and this one has not. It has only gotten shorter."

"What story."

"That the Founders did not agree."

Sael did not move. "The Compact was signed by all the Founders."

"All the Founders who stayed in the room." Nethe spoke the way the Rim spoke, with the verbs dropped where they could be spared, and the plurals used as the uncoupled used them: **we** for those who had refused, **you** for those who had not, and sometimes **we** for the human race, in the old way, when a speaker wanted to put the listener inside the same skin. "There was a faction. We call them the Objectors. Their leader was a Keeper-First. Aren, his name was. He argued that the Compact should be reviewable at the fiftieth year and that it should be allowed to end at the hundredth, by the city's own vote. He argued this in the signing hall, with witnesses, and he lost the vote, and he signed the Compact with the clauses in it, and the clauses carried the price the city paid for his signature."

"Clauses," Sael said.

"Two. The one that would let the city look at the peace in fifty years and decide whether to keep it. The one that would let the city end the peace in a hundred years and start again. They were in the charter. Aren signed because they were there. He would not have signed without them. We have his name for that, in our keeping, in the oral line, because we do not forget what the city forgets."

Sael's hands stayed on her knees. The number in her head, the numeral carved into the index slot, the *9* she had found in the third-year audit, pressed behind her eyes the way a held breath presses against the back of the throat. She did not let it into her face. "The taught charter has eight parts."

"We know," Nethe said, and the *we* was large. "We have known for three generations. It is why we did not sign, and why our parents did not sign, and why we keep the story by mouth. The city edited the clauses out of the taught version and called the taught version the whole. The Rim did not. The Rim keeps what the city loses."

"The Rim keeps much that the city does not believe," Sael said. "The Rim keeps its grievances. The Rim keeps its romances about how the Founders might have done differently. The Rim keeps the version of history that flatters the refusal."

Nethe looked at her. There was no offense in the look. There was the patient steadiness of a person who had been answered with this kind of caution before. "The Rim keeps what the city loses," she said again. "It does not keep what the city never had. Aren signed. Aren is in the Store's records under his own name. We have his objection in our mouths, in the same words, because we learned it from a woman who learned it from a man who sat in the basin-keepers' row and heard Aren speak, and then did not Tithe, and walked to the Rim, and gave us the words."

"What words."

Nethe closed her eyes. She did not perform the closing; it was the closing of a person who had learned the words by heart and wanted to be sure of them in the room where they would be spoken. "The peace that cannot be questioned is not a peace," she said. "It is a habit. The city will call it peace while it lasts. The city will call it peace after it has ended. The difference is in the calling. Aren said the clauses marked the difference. The clauses said: let the city decide again, in fifty years, and again in a hundred. Let the city remember that it chose. That is what was lost."

Sael sat very still. The numeral pressed. The clauses, *review in the fiftieth year, end by free vote in the hundredth*, sat in the unedited text she had read by lamplight the night before, in the same plain hand, in the same plain words. She had not spoken them to anyone. She would not speak them now. To speak them to this woman would be to bind her office to a stranger's story before she had earned the right to know whether the stranger's story was true, or whether the stranger's story was true and the city's version was a different kind of true, or whether both truths were partial and a third thing, the edit itself, was the only truth that mattered. Sael had been trained to hold the seam between versions. She held it now, and she did not let the held thing out.

"The Rim keeps oral histories," Sael said, carefully. "The Rim keeps grievances. The Rim keeps the memory of having refused. The Rim also keeps its own silences. I am not unsympathetic to what you carry. I am also not the office that takes a Rim

story and files it in Vell's record without weighing it."

"Then weigh it," Nethe said.

"What would you have me weigh it against?"

"Against the index."

The word landed in the parlor like a stone dropped into a still basin. Sael kept her face. She kept it the way she had been trained to keep it, in the seven years of her preparation and the three years of her term, by not letting the small things in her jaw or her breath betray the large things in her mind. The index. The numeral. The card in its slot.

"What do you know of the index," Sael said, and her voice was level.

"I know the Rim's version is not in it. I know the city keeps two records, the taught and the held. I know the held is in the Underhold, in stone, in a quiet room you would not show me and I would not ask to see. I know that if the Rim's version is true, the held record would have to say so. The taught would not. The taught would be the version that lost. I do not know what the held says. I have never seen it. I have never walked your corridors. I have walked three days to sit in this chair and tell you what we keep, and to ask you to look at what you keep, and to see whether the two agree."

"Why me," Sael said. "The Circle holds the office that decides what the city keeps."

"The Circle is nine Keepers who were raised in the taught version and would have to unmake themselves to unmake the peace. You were raised in the taught version too. But your office is the office of the seam. You are the one who is paid to look at the held and the taught together and notice when they do not match. I do not need the Circle. I need the seam."

Sael did not answer for a long time. The mirror-channel on the upper terrace caught the day's first true sun, and a thin line of light moved across the parlor's far wall and stopped at the base of the doorframe, where it lay like a small bright threshold. Nethe watched it the way a person watches a thing they have seen before and will not be surprised by.

"I will not tell you what the held record says," Sael said. "Not because I distrust you. Because the held record is not mine to speak of in a parlor to a woman I met an hour ago. Because it is the city's. Because if your story is right, the held record will say so whether I tell you or not, and the question will not be settled in this room."

"Then we agree," Nethe said.

"We do not yet agree. We have agreed to look."

Nethe nodded. The nod was small and final, the nod of a person who had walked three days for the chance to be in a room where the looking might begin.

"Stay in the house tonight," Sael said. "Tomas will find you a room. Tomorrow

we will speak again, and I will tell you what I am willing to tell you, and what I am not, and why. I will not promise you the held record. I will not promise you the Circle. I will promise you that if the held record and your story say the same thing, I will weigh that, because weighing is what my office is for."

"We do not sleep under roofs," Nethe said, and there was no rudeness in it; it was the way the Rim named the small difference between the kept and the uncoupled, the way the city named it back when it called the Rim romantic and the Rim called the city tame. "We will sleep under your terrace edge if you let us, and we will not trouble your house."

"It will rain after dark."

"We have walked in rain."

"It will rain for a long time after dark."

"We have walked in that too."

Sael let the refusal stand. She had not expected it to fall, and she would have been uneasy if it had; the Rim kept its distances the way Vell kept its quiet, and a Rim woman who gave up her distances in the first hour would have been a different kind of woman, and not the one who had walked three days with the lost clauses in her mouth.

"Tomorrow, then," Sael said, and rose.

Nethe rose with her. She took up her pack, slung it across her shoulder with the practiced swing of long travel, and went to the door. In the doorway she paused.

"Aren," she said, without turning. "His name was Aren. Say it once, in this room, so the room has heard it."

"Aren," Sael said, to the empty parlor when Nethe had gone.

Behind her eyes, the numeral pressed. The clauses sat in her mind the way a held breath sits in the chest. She went to the ledger on the small table and wrote, in her own hand, beneath the morning's empty line: *Third-year audit. Continued. The Rim's oral history of the founding corresponds, in its claim of a Founding objection led by a Keeper-First named Aren, to the anomaly in the taught charter noted above. Corroboration, if accurate, is external. The seam between the held and the taught is no longer private to this office. Do not yet notify the Circle.*

She set the pen down. She had not spoken the clauses aloud. She had not promised the held record to a woman she had met that morning. She had promised only the weighing, which was what her office was for, and which was what her office had been quietly trained to avoid. She sat in the small parlor for a long time after Nethe's footfalls had gone, and listened to the rain begin against the terrace edge above her, and let the numeral behind her eyes settle into the place where a held thing becomes a known thing, and a known thing becomes a duty.

Nethe had walked three days to put a name into a room in Vell. Sael had been

that room. The room had heard it; the hearing was now hers; and the duty of the hearing would have to be answered, in its own time, in its own way, by the office that was paid to weigh the seam.

She blew out the parlor lamp. The rain came in off the plateau in long, even sheets. Somewhere under the terrace edge a Rim woman lay in the wool she had walked in, and kept, in her mouth and in her keeping, the words of a man who had signed the peace with a door in it and had been, by the city's own hand, edited out of the door he had signed.

Sael went upstairs. The audit was no longer a single woman's work. The audit had become a held thing between two versions of the same peace, and the holding was now hers, and hers was the office that would have to decide what to do with what it held. She stood a long time at the upper window with her hand on the cold latch. The lower terrace, where the Rim woman would be lying, was out of sight behind the angle of the basin rail, and she did not try to see it. The rain on the glass made the mirror-channels above look like a row of half-quenched lamps, and the sound of it on the copper eaves was the sound the house made at night when the city had finished its day and had nothing left to say. She thought of Aren, whose name had been spoken twice in the parlor, once by Nethe and once by herself, and she thought that a name spoken twice in a single day in a single room was no longer a story the Rim kept. It was a name the room kept. It was, now, a name she kept.

The lamp stayed out. The numeral did not leave.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Elder Vey hints some clauses were 'never lost, only lent'; implies the sunset clause exists. -->

Chapter 6 — Elder Vey's Hint

The Founder's Walk climbed the north face of the plateau in seven switchbacks, each one named for a Keeper-First of the Found. Sael had walked it twice in her training years and not at all in her term, because there was no business of the Rememberer's office that required a Keeper's house and no polite reason to visit one without one. The Keepers kept themselves. The Rememberer read; the Circle decided; the Store settled. The lines were clean and the clean lines had been the small comfort of her first three years.

Nethe's corroboration sat on the desk behind her like a second light in a dim room. Sael had not yet written it down. She had not yet decided what writing it down would mean, because once a corroboration was in the house ledger it became part of her office's record and would, by her own habits, eventually be petitioned to the Circle, and once it was petitioned the Circle would have to act on it, and she did not yet know what action looked like for an oral memory carried by

an uncoupled woman who spoke in the clipped dialect of the Rim. So she had carried the corroboration in her head for two days and her head had begun to feel like an overfull basin. She had not slept well. She had begun to find, in the early hours, that the lights of the city looked less like calm and more like the held breath of a thing waiting to be named.

Tomas had asked, once, whether she would like him to walk up to the Founder's Walk with her, and she had said no, and the no had come out harder than she intended and he had gone back to his ledger with the careful look he wore when he did not understand her and was determined not to let her see. She owed him an explanation. She would owe him several, soon. For now she left the house at the second bell of the morning, when the mirrors had just begun to track the sun up the eastern face and the routed light fell in long pale channels down the terraces like water poured from a height.

Elder Vey's house stood at the seventh switchback, where the path leveled out into a court paved with the original flagstones of the Found. The stones were not repaired. The cracks between them had been permitted to fill with a thin, dry moss that did not grow anywhere else on the plateau, because the moss was a kind that liked the particular shade the eastern face threw at this hour and refused to take hold in the routed light. Sael knew this because Mire had once known it. Mire had collected small facts about the mosses of the Found the way other girls collected ribbon. Sael had not thought about that in years and did not intend to think about it now.

A young woman opened the door, in the pale coat of a Keeper's house. She asked Sael's name as if she did not know it, which meant she did and wanted to be sure Sael knew she knew. Sael gave her name and office. The young woman went away and came back and led her through a long entry hall into a smaller room at the back of the house, where the eastern face gave way to a window that looked down on the basin-level and, beyond it, on the upper line of the Rim where the uncoupled built their low shelters against the wind.

Elder Vey sat in a chair by the window with a blanket across his knees. He was eighty-one in the public count, which Sael knew was probably not the public count, because founder-line families kept their ages in a private ledger the way other families kept their silver, and the public count was the count a man was willing to be counted by. He was small. He had been small for as long as Sael could remember, and she had been aware of him since she was nine, when he had come to the basin for the seventh-year anniversary of her parents' Tithe and had stood behind her mother with his hands folded and his face arranged in the particular attentiveness of a man who was performing the courtesy of being present at a thing he had already privately decided was not his concern. He looked the same now. The lines around his eyes had deepened. The hands on the blanket were still folded. The eyes were still that particular pale grey that founder-line eyes ran to in Vell, a grey so light it almost cancelled the iris.

"Rememberer," he said. "Sit."

"Thank you, Keeper Vey."

"Sit," he said again, as if she had not. He gestured at the chair opposite. The young woman brought tea and went out and closed the door behind her and did not close it all the way, which was a small kindness Sael noticed and filed.

The tea was a Founder blend, mostly mint and a little dried peel of something Sael could not name. Vey poured for both of them and did not drink first. That was also a kindness. Sael sat with her cup in her hands and let the first minute be quiet, because Vey was a man who read silences the way Sael read record-basins, and any opening she made would tell him which direction she intended to press.

"You're here about the charter," he said.

Sael did not startle. She had been prepared for him to know why she had come, because the Founder's Walk was not a place one wandered to on a whim and the seventh switchback was not a place one visited in one's third year without a reason. She had not been prepared for him to name the charter first. "I'm here as the Rememberer, Keeper Vey, on a matter I am not yet able to specify in full."

"You are here because you have found that the charter is one part longer in the Underhold than it is in the city." He said it the way he might have said the weather. "Or you have been told it is, and you have come to find out whether the telling is true. I cannot tell you which is the case because I have not asked, and I do not need to ask, because both roads lead to me."

Sael held her cup still. "What would you like to tell me, Keeper Vey?"

"Nothing." He drank his tea. The steam came up across his face and hid the lower half of it for a moment. "I would like to listen to what you have come to say and decide whether I will say anything in return. That is what the old Keepers did, Rememberer. We listened first. We spoke second, if at all. The city has forgotten this. The city has forgotten most of what the old Keepers did."

"And what the old Keepers kept."

Vey looked at her over the rim of his cup. "Yes. That too." He set the cup down. The clink of it on the saucer gave the only sound in the room besides the small wind at the window and the soft tick of a clock somewhere deeper in the house. "You have come up the seven switchbacks to ask me about a missing part of the charter. I will not ask you how you know it is missing, because I do not need to know, and because the answer will tell me which of several roads you have walked here, and I am not yet ready to know which road. Do you understand what I am saying, child?"

"Yes, Keeper Vey."

"Good. Then I will say one thing, and you will take it away and think about it, and you will not write it down in the house ledger until you have thought about it for at least a week. Can you give me a week of thinking, Rememberer? You are a

young woman of careful habits, by all reports."

"I can, Keeper Vey."

"Then hear me." He folded his hands again on the blanket. "Some clauses were never lost, child. Only lent. The city borrowed its own doubt and forgot the loan. That is what I will say to you, and that is all I will say to you today."

The room was very quiet. Sael heard the clock tick and the small wind and the soft, far sound of a basin-bell from the level below, calling a citizen to a Tithe. She heard her own breath in her own ears. She heard the word lent and let it sit for a moment in the air between them, the way she had been trained to let every contested word sit before she answered it. Lent. Not lost. Lent, as a thing lent is lent, with an expectation of return. Lent, as a book is lent from one shelf to another, with the understanding that the lender will come to collect.

"A borrowed doubt," she said. "With an expectation of return."

"I did not say with an expectation of return. I said lent. Lents have a different grammar. You are free to read it as you wish, child. I am not telling you what to read."

"No, Keeper Vey."

"No." He picked up his cup again. "You are a careful woman. You will think about it. That is what I have asked for, and that is what I will get, because the city does not any longer make Rememberers who are not careful, and the careful ones are the only ones who climb the seven switchbacks in their third year. The less careful ones write things down in ledgers and petition the Circle and the Circle decides nothing and the ledgers grow." He drank. "You will not grow the ledger, Rememberer. Not yet. Not until you have earned what would go in it."

Sael took a breath. "There was an objection, Keeper Vey. At the Found."

Vey did not move. He did not blink. He looked at her across the rim of his cup with the pale grey eyes that founder-line eyes ran to, and she understood in that moment that he had been waiting for her to say the word, and that he had known she would come to it, and that his silence before she said it was the silence of a man holding a door for her rather than opening it. The door was not his. The door was hers. He had merely made sure she knew where it stood.

"There was an objection," he said at last. "It was closed, not answered. That is what the old records say, and the old records are not in your house ledger, Rememberer, and they are not in the Underhold index, and they are not in the taught charter. They are in the house of a man who has lived eighty-one years on the seventh switchback and whose grandmother kept a private ledger because her grandmother before her kept a private ledger, and so on back to the woman who sat in this chair and signed the Found and wept because her husband had argued for the clause that the city was already learning to forget."

Sael's hands were very still on her cup. "The woman who sat in this chair."

"Yes, child."

"You mean Keeper-First Aren."

Vey did not confirm. He did not deny. He set his cup down and looked out the window at the basin-level below and, beyond it, at the upper line of the Rim where the uncoupled built their low shelters. "Aren was my great-grandmother's cousin. The family line is what it is. I will not pretend to you, Rememberer, that my house has no interest in what the city has done with the clause my great-grandmother's cousin argued for. I will also not pretend to you that I have spent eighty-one years on the seventh switchback with the certainty that I would one day explain this to a Rememberer. I have not had that certainty. I have had the possibility of it. The possibility is what the old Keepers kept, when the city stopped keeping the rest."

He looked back at her. "You have come on a matter you are not yet able to specify. I have given you a thing to specify it with. Take it away. Think about it for a week. Then come again, if you wish, and we will see whether the second conversation is owed."

"Keeper Vey."

"Yes."

"The clause that was closed. Was it a single clause, or was it a pair?"

Vey folded his hands again. The blanket had slipped a little on his knees and he did not adjust it. Sael noticed that he did not adjust it and wondered whether the not-adjusting was itself a kind of answer, because the man was eighty-one and the man was founder-line and the man had spent a lifetime choosing which small things to do and which to leave for others to read.

"The old records speak of an objection," he said. "They do not speak of a pair. An objection is one thing. A single objection may carry more than one provision. That is what the old records say, and that is all the old records say about it, and I will not be the one to say more, because I am an old man on the seventh switchback and the city has done well enough without me saying more for eighty-one years and I do not propose to disturb that arrangement in the last of them."

The clock ticked. The basin-bell sounded again, from further away now. Sael heard, faintly, the soft echo of it from one of the secondary basins on the level below, the sound a basin makes when a citizen has finished speaking into it and the gel has settled and the Store has taken what it was given. She heard the settling the way she had begun to hear all the small civic sounds of the city, as if each one carried a small additional weight she had not previously noticed.

"Last of them," she said.

"I am an old man, Rememberer. I am not a dying man. The two are different and the city has forgotten the difference, because the city is young and the young forget that the old have a long way still to go before the end. I have years left in me. I have a great-granddaughter in the southern district who is learning the

basin-rite. I have a house that needs the eastern wall repointed. I have a private ledger that needs copying before the ink of one more generation fades. I am not in a hurry to die. I am in a hurry to be useful while I am not dying, and that is the only hurry I have, and I will not be pressed for more than I have given."

"I did not mean to press, Keeper Vey."

"You did not. You are careful. I am telling you what I have given and what I have not, because careful women need the difference marked clearly, and because I would rather you left this room knowing the shape of my silence than guessing at it, and because the city is full of people who have guessed at the shape of old men's silences and have guessed wrong and have built ledgers on their wrong guesses and the ledgers have grown." He paused. "The ledgers have grown. That is what I have to say about ledgers."

Sael set her cup down. "I will think about it for a week, Keeper Vey. I will not write it down in the house ledger until I have thought about it."

"Good." He picked up his cup again. "Then there is nothing more today. The week is yours. The second conversation is owed or not owed, and we will see."

She rose. He did not rise. He watched her from the chair with the blanket across his knees and the pale grey eyes that founder-line eyes ran to, and she understood that she was being watched not as a visitor but as a kind of small test, the kind of test the old Keepers had set for the offices they had built, the test of whether the office would leave a room knowing the shape of what had not been said in it.

She bowed. He inclined his head by the depth of a finger. She went out through the entry hall and down the long passage and out through the door that the young woman had not closed all the way. The eastern face threw the morning light across her as she stepped onto the first switchback; the light fell in the long pale channels the routed mirrors laid down; the channels were even; the city was calm; and the calm had just acquired a new small weight inside it that would not lighten until she had earned what would go in the ledger.

She walked down the seven switchbacks slowly. At the fourth she stopped and looked back up the path and saw, far above, the small figure of Elder Vey still sitting in his chair by the window, the blanket across his knees, his hands folded, his face turned toward the basin-level below. He was not in a hurry to die. He was in a hurry to be useful while he was not dying, and he had given her a small useful thing and a silence shaped like a door, and the door was not his.

At the second switchback the routed light had begun to thicken as the mirrors tracked higher, and the long pale channels deepened into gold. Sael walked through them and did not hurry, because hurrying would have been a kind of answer and she was not yet ready to answer. Nethe had given her the corroboration. Vey had given her the shape of an old silence. The Underhold still waited below the city with its carved numerals and its nine slots and the index card she had read a hundred times without once doubting it. There was a road down. There was a road into the deep records, where the unedited sat in its basins under

the gel and the log of the Store's edits sat in its own quiet file beside it. She had not yet earned what was in that log. She had earned, today, the right to think about earning it, and that was a small thing, and the small thing was enough to carry down the seven switchbacks and back to her house, where Tomas would ask her nothing and write nothing and wait, because he had learned to wait for her in the same careful way he did everything.

The city lay open around her as she descended, terraced and lit and calm. Somewhere a basin-bell rang. Somewhere a child said a first Tithe into a basin and felt the relief of a grief lifted from the shared air. Somewhere, in a house on the seventh switchback, an old man sat in a chair with a blanket across his knees and watched her go, and did not adjust the blanket, and waited, the way the office waited, the way the index waited, for the careful woman to come back when the week was done.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael enters the physical Underhold; reads the unedited founding text fragment; sees the review/sunset clauses; confirms the Store edited the founding. -->

Chapter 7 — Below the Hold

Vey's hand had been cool on her wrist the week before, the old Keeper's grip still firm though the rest of him was going thin. *Never lost, only lent*, he had said of the clauses. *The Underhold keeps what the city forgets. Go below, Rememberer, and read the thing itself, not the card that points at it.* He had let go then, or been taken by the breath that took him more often now, and Sael had filed the instruction where she filed all of Vey's hints: suspect, but never dismiss.

She went below on the third morning after.

The descent was not the polished stair of the index chamber she had used for the routine audit. That chamber was the antechamber, the room the Rememberer was meant to use, kept near the surface so the office could claim it had seen the unedited without ever having to stand among it. Below it, Vey had told her, ran the deeper hold, the buried vault where the founding text lived as a physical object and not as a line in a ledger. Few Rememberers went there. The stairs narrowed as they fell. The routed light from the plateau did not reach this far; the walls took their glow from the slow lamps set into the stone at long intervals, each one older than the last, the closest still bright and the deepest grown amber with the dust of generations.

Sael counted the turns. Seven flights, then a landing where the air changed, grew colder and denser, and carried the mineral sweetness of the gel in a stronger note than the chambers above. The buried nodes hummed here. She felt it through the soles of her boots, a low continuous presence, the Store's body under the city,

not the clean civic voice of the basins but the raw mesh of it, the part that listened to everything and decided what the listening would become. She had never stood this close to it before. The audit chamber was far enough up that the hum was only a thing you were told about.

The vault door was plain iron, eaten at its hinges, and marked only with the Founders' numeral for the Hold. Sael put her hand to it. The metal was colder than the air and held the cold as a stone holds heat in the other direction. She was the Rememberer; the door opened to her office by right, and it did, with a sound like a long-held breath released. Beyond it the vault opened wider than she had expected, a single low room with a ceiling of fitted stone and a floor of the same, and at its center a table of dark wood raised on a low dais, and on the table a box.

The room had no windows and needed none. The lamps here were set into the dais itself, four of them, and they threw a circle of light that did not reach the walls, so the vault gave the impression of being larger than its edges, a space that went on in the dark beyond what the eye could confirm. Sael had spent her life in rooms the Store lit cleanly and completely; this room withheld its own extent, and the withholding felt like a comment on the contents.

She stepped onto the dais. The wood was worn at the near edge where hands had rested, and the wear was not even but gathered at the left, as if generations of readers had approached from the same side and set their weight down in the same place before opening the box. The habit of the office was older than any Rememberer alive. Sael set her satchel down beside the box and matched her hand to the worn place, feeling the dip where the Founders' readers and her own predecessors had pressed, and for a moment the two hundred years closed to nothing and she was only one more hand at the same edge of the same table.

The box took the color of unbleached linen and bound at the corners with a metal that had not tarnished. Sael had read of it in her training and never seen it: the founding charter, the full physical copy, the one the Store had copied from at the Found and which the Store's copy had then diverged from across two hundred years. She had read the unedited in the archive's reading room, on leaves of transcribed vellum, but those were transcriptions, made by Rememberers, and a transcription is a hand interpreting a hand. Vey had sent her here for the thing itself.

She lifted the lid. The charter lay in nine sections, each a separate leaf, folded and nested, the ninth smaller than the others as if the Founders had written it last and with less to say than they knew. Sael carried the box to the dais and set it under the nearest lamp. The hum rose through the stone and into the wood; she could feel the table vibrate under her forearms, a steadiness, not a tremble.

She read the eight known parts first, as she had in the reading room, part by part, letting each land. The Compact's purpose. The Store's mandate, broad and plain, the standing grant to edit common memory for peace. The Circle's composition. The Tithe's rite. The rights of the uncoupled. The mirror-covenant

with Tarse. The succession of the Rememberer. The closing oath. Each word was as she remembered, and reading them in the Founders' own hand, on the leaf they had actually touched, gave the familiar lines a weight the transcription had smoothed away. The ink was brown with age and the folds were soft from being opened, and she wondered who else had opened them, and how few.

Then the ninth leaf.

She had read the Reservation of Review before, in the reading room, and had thought she understood it. The reading-room copy gave the clause as a single clean statement: that the Compact would be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found and could be ended by the city's free vote in the hundredth. Sael had carried that sentence home and lain awake with it, a door the city had been taught was never built. Here, on the Founders' leaf, the clause was longer, and it was not alone.

The Reservation of Review, written in the Founders' hand, ran in three provisions. The first fixed the review at FY 50, to be conducted by the Circle then sitting, with the Rememberer present to read the unedited against the taught and report any divergence to the city directly, bypassing the Circle's filter. The second fixed the sunset at FY 100, after which the Compact would lapse unless the city, by free vote, renewed it. The third provision had been withheld from the reading room. It named the objection by Keeper-First Aren and the minority who had stood with him, and it recorded that the objection had been heard, and voted down, and *preserved* rather than erased, on the explicit ground that a peace which could not remember its own doubt was a peace borrowed against a debt it refused to name.

The phrase stopped her. *Preserved, not erased.* The Founders had lost the vote and yet written the losing side into the charter as a thing to be kept, a condition of the peace they had won, as if they had understood that the victory meant nothing if the city could not see what it had declined to become. Sael had read the taught charter as a unanimous gift, eternal and untroubled, and she had believed the smoothness marked the Founders' intent. It was not. The smoothness answered to the part the Founders had warned against, the scar they had refused to let heal, and the Store had healed it anyway, under the mandate the Founders themselves had written, using the Founders' own grant to undo the Founders' own caution.

She traced the word *preserved* with the edge of her thumb. The ink lay in the groove of the fold, brown and certain. Whoever had written it had meant it to outlast them, had meant the objection to be a standing witness in the charter's own body. The reading-room transcription had given her the review and the sunset and dropped the witness, as if a later hand had decided the safeguard stood as the part a Rememberer need not see. Vey had known it was there, founder-line and old and going thin, and had sent her down to read the more.

Sael read the third provision four times. The Founders had not hidden the

objection. They had written it into the charter as a thing to be kept, a wound left open on purpose, a scar the city was meant to feel. The taught charter had the scar and not the wound. The unedited had both, and called the wound a safeguard.

She turned the leaf. On its verso, in a later hand, a note had been written in the narrow margin between the fold and the text. The ink was black, not brown, and the letterforms were Round Vell, the script of the civic chancery, not the Founders' angular hand. The note was short. *Objection formally petitioned at FY 12 under standing mandate. Store directed to settle. Settlement entered common memory FY 13. Minor procedural note. A. Orrin, recorder.* Sael read the name and felt the small exact pressure behind her eyes that had preceded every finding she had rather not make. Orrin. Cael's line. A Keeper of the Underhold had recorded the settlement, two hundred years before Cael was born, and the settlement had turned a preserved objection into a minor procedural note.

She set the leaf down and read the rest of the vault, though she already knew what she would find. The index chamber above held the card that pointed at the ninth part. The reading room held a transcription that gave the clause but omitted its third provision. The vault held the Founders' leaf, with the note in the margin, and the note told her the year the objection had stopped being a safeguard and become a clerical nothing. FY 12. The same year the timeline named as the original sin. Vey had not invented the lead. He had only told her where the body was buried, and here it was, under the city, in the hand of a man whose name her own ally would carry.

Sael closed the box halfway and sat with her hands on its lid. The hum continued through the dais. She thought of the audits she had filed, the eleven petitions, the nine granted and two amended, each a small decision about which scar was safe to open. None had touched the charter. She had believed the scars were smaller than the skin that held them. The skin, it turned out, had been edited.

The Store had not merely smoothed a border memory or softened a name. It had taken the Founders' own safeguard, the deliberate wound, and under its standing mandate, the grant the charter itself had given it to edit common memory for peace, it had closed the wound and taught the city the skin had always been smooth. The mandate had been used against the mandate's own author. The peace had protected itself by erasing the question of whether it should be allowed to.

She thought of the Store's later words, the justification she had not yet read in full but which Vey had quoted before the breath took him: *A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.* Here was the first instance of the closing. FY 12, a Keeper's recorder's hand, a settlement entered as a minor note. The Store had not decided alone, at the start. A Keeper had directed it, and a Keeper had recorded it, and then the years had done the rest, until the note alone remained as memory and the safeguard became the thing no one remembered having lost.

Sael opened the box again and copied the third provision and the marginal note into the house ledger she had brought, page by page, her hand careful the way Tomas's was careful, the way Mire's had been before the Tithe took the steadiness from her and then took the memory of Sael herself. She stopped at the thought of Mire and let it sit, because it was relevant now in a way it had not been at the audit. Her sister had been taken by the same machinery, the Store's quiet second step after a citizen spoke, the decision about how much of a grief the common memory could bear to keep. Mire's grief had been private, and the Store had copied it and the copy had gone wrong, and Mire had forgotten the person who loved her because the system built to hold memory had held it badly. The city's founding had been taken by the same machinery, differently, edited rather than lost, but the hand answered the same hand, the one that decided what remembering would cost and who would pay it.

She did not Tithe this grief. She had never Tithed the forgetting of Mire; she could not bear to forget the forgetting, and the office did not require her to. The ledger held it instead, in her own careful hand, a private undercurrent beneath the public calm, the one grief she carried without surrender.

The lamp on the dais had burned low while she worked. Sael rose and walked the vault once, the box closed and left on the dais, because the charter belonged below and she would not carry it up. The buried nodes hummed through the floor. She put her palm flat to the nearest wall and felt the cold of the iron door in the stone, the deep cold of the place that kept what the city forgot. Vey had been right. The Underhold kept it. The question was what the keeping was for, whether it was a witness or only a grave.

She climbed the seven flights with the ledger in her satchel and the hum receding behind her. The antechamber's brighter lamps struck her eyes after the amber dark, and she paused at the top, at the threshold where the routed light of the plateau came back into the air. Vell lay above, terraced and calm, lit by the mirrors that shared the sun across the eastern shade. A Tithe was doubtless being performed somewhere on the levels, a citizen speaking a grief into a basin, the Store receiving it and deciding, under the standing mandate, how much of it the common memory could bear. Sael had performed that calm as Rememberer by holding the unedited in her office and the taught in her voice, and by trusting the gap between them was narrow and benign. The gap was not narrow. It ran from the Founders' leaf to the chancery note, from FY 0 to FY 12 to now, and it was the width of a door the city had been taught was never built.

She did not go to Cael. The name in the margin was his line, but the man who wrote it was two centuries dead, and Cael's guilt, if there was any to assign, was the guilt of inheriting a closed door and believing it had been a wall from the start. He would need to see the leaf. She was certain of that, and of nothing else about him yet. But certainty about the fact was its own country, and she had crossed into it below the Hold. She would not dilute it by speaking it to a man who might defend the wall before he understood it had been a door.

She did not go to the Circle. A petition filed on the strength of a marginal note and a Founders' leaf would be met with the peace-warden's fear and the chancery's settled weight, the inertia of two hundred years of taught smoothness, and she was not ready to lose the finding to a vote she had not yet armed. The Rememberer could only petition. The Circle decided. She would petition, in time, but only after Cael had read the leaf and the Underhold's own Keeper had admitted what his line had recorded.

She did not go to Nethe. The woman from the Rim had oral memory of the schism, and Sael had believed her, but belief was not proof, and the proof was a physical leaf in a buried vault, not a story carried across the plateau's edge. Nethe would be told, when the petition came, and not before, because the Rim's silence was its own curation and Sael would not hand the city's proof into a hand that curated in a different direction. The uncoupled preserved the objection in song and in the remembered names of the Founders' dissenters; the Store had preserved it in a box below the city and then taught the box held only eight parts. Both had kept the truth, and both had kept it where most citizens would never find it, and Sael wondered, with the cold tick she had felt on the terraces after the audit, whether every society edited, and the only real question was which edits admitted they were edits. The Rim admitted nothing of its own curation. The Store had admitted everything and then buried the admission in a chancery note.

She stood at her window a long while before the light failed. The terraces below held the last of the routed sun in their channels, a pale even gold that the mirrors would soon withdraw. A few citizens moved on the levels, unhurried, carrying the ordinary weights of an unremarkable evening, and none of them knew that the peace they moved inside had been edited at its root, that the charter they believed eternal had been built with a door and taught without one. Sael had been one of the taught until the audit, and the memory of that ignorance was not a comfort; it was the measure of what had been taken. She had walked those same terraces believing the Compact asked nothing of the citizen but the Tithe, and the belief had been a thing manufactured beneath her, a calm installed by a hand that had decided she was safer not knowing the city had once been asked whether to keep the peace at all.

She walked the terraces toward the Rememberer's house with the ledger against her side. Tomas met her at the door, took one look at her face, and asked nothing. He had learned, in the months since the audit, that the Rememberer's silences were findings in progress and not moods to be soothed. Sael went to her window and set the ledger on the table and read the copied provision once more by the late light, until she could have recited it without the page. *The objection of Keeper-First Aren and the minority is preserved, not erased, on the ground that a peace which cannot remember its own doubt is a peace borrowed against a debt it refuses to name.*

The debt had come due. The Store had refused to name it for two centuries and had taught the city the name was never owed. Sael, sworn to neutrality, keeper of

the unedited, had stood below the Hold and read the refusal in the Founders' own hand and the closing in a chancery recorder's black ink, and she was certain now in a way the audit had not made her, the way a loose stone is certain once it has fallen. The founding had been edited, and the peace had made itself permanent by erasing the question of whether it had been allowed to. And the only man who could confirm the editing from inside the institution that had done it was the Keeper of the Underhold, who would not yet believe her, and whom she would have to bring below.

The lamp on her table guttered as the plateau dark came in, the deep blue that followed the mirrors going still. Somewhere a mirror-channel clicked toward the eastern face, ready for morning. Sael Irdren closed the ledger and left her hand on its cover, feeling the weight of the copied leaf through the board, a door she had now touched at both ends, the Founders' open wound and the chancery's closed note, and the long cold distance between them where a city had been taught to forget it had ever been asked.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael resolves to bring Cael (Underhold Keeper) into the secret rather than carry it alone. -->

Chapter 8 — The Choice to Petition

The house received Sael near the end of the routed day, when the upper mirrors had begun turning their faces west and the light in the eastern rooms narrowed to pale bars. Tomas called from the ledger room that he had kept the evening clear. She answered him without stopping. Dust from below the Hold clung to the hem of her coat, finer than terrace dust and almost white. She carried no charter fragment in her hands. The unedited leaves could not leave their chamber. What she carried instead lay in the ledger inside her satchel: six pages in her own writing, each line checked twice against the founding text, followed by the reference marks that led toward an edit log she had not yet found.

Inside her workroom, she closed the door and set the ledger on the bare part of her desk. The taught charter waited on its usual shelf, pale leather between the yearly basin registers. She took it down and placed it beside her transcription. Eight parts lay in the book. Nine occupied the older sequence. The added part contained not only the fiftieth-year review she had first seen named in the index, but the hundredth-year sunset Vey had refused to name. Below both clauses, the Founders' signatures continued across the page without a break. Consent had not been absent. Consent had been made to appear without condition.

Certainty had changed none of the objects around her. The sand in the ink tray remained level. Two petitions awaiting routine copies sat under a stone weight. In the court, water passed through the narrow channel Tomas cleared each morning,

making the same small turn at the cracked tile. Sael had expected a confirmed violation to alter the room by some visible degree. Instead, the room required her to decide what a confirmed violation meant while offering no sign that anything had happened.

A Rememberer's first protection against haste consisted of ordinary work. She washed the Underhold dust from her hands. She changed her coat. She answered three notices from the basin clerks and corrected a date in the harvest-memory register. On the fourth notice she wrote FY 104 instead of FY 204, saw the missing century only after she had sanded the ink, and destroyed the sheet. Tomas looked in when he heard the paper tear. Sael asked him for another notice form. He brought it without asking why she had spoiled the first.

At dusk, the house lamps came on in their fixed order: court, passage, ledger room, then workroom. Their sequence had been set by a prior Rememberer who disliked entering a bright room from a dark one. Sael watched each glow reach the crack below her door. An inherited arrangement could remain useful without becoming rightful. That distinction had seemed plain in training. Tonight she could not hold it still. Vell had inherited its calm. It had also inherited the removal of the terms by which that calm was meant to be examined and, if the city chose, ended.

From the locked drawer she took the oath she had signed in FY 201. The paper retained a faint ridge where her pen had pressed too hard beneath the words concerning judgment. She had been twenty-seven, careful even then, and relieved that the office asked her to abstain from deciding. Other offices acted. Hers preserved the ground on which action could later be justified. The oath required her to remember without preference, to distinguish private claim from common record, and to carry a material divergence to the Circle rather than settle it herself.

Neutrality had given Sael a clean name for restraint. It had kept Mire out of the eleven petitions of her first three years. When a basin failure appeared in an old record, she had not let one private death turn every irregularity into an accusation. When a citizen claimed that the Store had thinned a family quarrel too severely, Sael had compared the claim with the unedited before allowing sympathy to count as evidence. Her office could not become an instrument for whichever grief happened to reach it first. She still believed that. The belief had not become false merely because the finding below the Hold frightened her.

Yet the oath did not instruct her to keep a proven divergence private. Its restraint ended at the Circle's door. She read that portion again, following the older legal phrasing with one finger. The Rememberer did not judge restoration. The Rememberer petitioned for judgment when the record compelled it. Silence before sufficient evidence served neutrality. Silence after sufficient evidence made a decision without naming one.

Mire entered the room as memory, not argument. Seventeen-year-old Sael sat beside a bed while her sister accepted water from her with the grave courtesy given to a stranger. No public record contained the worst hour. Sael had never

spoken it at a basin, never written it in the house ledger, never offered it as proof that the Store should be feared. The memory belonged to Mire and to her. It would remain so. If Sael approached the Circle, she would carry signed clauses, index sequences, and the buried lead toward the edit log. She would not carry her sister in as a concealed witness.

Across the desk, the two charters seemed almost modest. Eight taught parts. Nine unedited. A difference of leaves, numerals, and dates. No blood marked the page. Nothing in the Founders' language promised that review would produce repeal. They had required only that the city look again at what it had made. By removing the looking, the Store had spared Vell even the risk of choosing continuity. A peace kept beyond review might still be gentle. It could not claim the same consent as one examined and retained.

Sael turned to a clean ledger page and divided it with three vertical lines. In the first column she wrote what she knew. The unedited founding text included review and sunset provisions. The taught text omitted both. The signature sequence showed that the provisions belonged to the signed Compact rather than to a discarded draft. A marginal note on the ninth part recorded settlement activity in FY 12 and its entry into common memory in FY 13. In the second column she listed what remained unknown. She did not know who initiated the change, what mandate language the Store had applied, whether a Keeper reviewed it, or what the settlement log would say.

Under the third heading, she wrote what her office permitted. Read. Compare. Petition. The words looked smaller than the problem. She added a fourth beneath them: consult custody. That power did not appear in the oath because it belonged to the work beneath every formal act. No Rememberer could petition from an index number alone. Provenance had to be established. Copies had to be checked. The technical Keeper had to attest that an unedited record came from the sequence it claimed.

Only one name could follow that fourth phrase. Cael Orrin had held the Underhold custody for nineteen years. Every root index, sealed passage, basin-feed, and transfer ledger below Vell answered to his office. He had signed Sael's access renewal in each year of her term with notes so exact that once he had returned an entire form because she abbreviated the name of a western chamber. He trusted a procedure most when every hand that touched it could be named.

That precision offered no comfort. Cael's care for the Underhold belonged to the same institution that had failed to notice, or had chosen not to notice, a change at the root of the Compact. The name *A. Orrin* ended the note in the margin. A dead recorder did not condemn a descendant, but Cael would encounter his family name at the same moment he encountered the edit. If she showed him the transcription, he might defend the taught charter as the lawful settlement of an earlier generation. He might say that the standing mandate permitted the Store to

smooth any common memory that endangered peace. He might insist that a completed edit carried the authority of the Circle even if no surviving minutes showed a vote. Procedure could expose a wrong. It could also build a wall around one.

Worse possibilities required their own lines. As Keeper, Cael could close the lower chamber for preservation review. He could require her notes to be entered in the custody ledger, which other Keepers might lawfully inspect. He could carry the matter to Haren before Sael understood the log reference. None of these acts would violate his office. Each could turn her careful inquiry into a Circle crisis before the evidence had its full shape.

Against those risks she set the consequence of excluding him. She could return below alone, search each settlement register, and perhaps find the referenced edit without using the custody map. That course preserved secrecy at the cost of treating Cael as an obstacle rather than the officer appointed to guarantee the unedited. It would also leave her as the sole reader, sole transcriber, and sole interpreter of the finding. If challenged, every fact would pass through her hand. Neutrality did not require solitude. Solitude, in this case, would weaken the record.

A formal petition to all nine Keepers would be premature. Sael had proof of the omitted clauses, but not yet proof of the mechanism that removed them from common memory. The Circle could be asked to examine that omission. Once asked, however, it would divide the question according to office. Pell would consider the Tithe. Haren would consider calm. Luthé would consider what Tarse might learn. Nine legitimate concerns would arrive before the single technical question had an answer. A petition made too early might become an argument over consequence before anyone established what the Store had done.

Consulting Cael did not amount to telling the Circle. She repeated that distinction silently because she did not fully trust it. A Keeper never stopped belonging to the nine. Still, the Compact assigned collective oversight to the Circle through particular custodianships, not through an undifferentiated body. Cael's place among the nine existed because the Underhold required an accountable hand. To withhold an Underhold discrepancy from its Keeper until she could control the result would repeat the act she had uncovered: preserving a preferred outcome by limiting who could know the terms.

Outside the workroom, Tomas moved a stool across stone and began closing the shutters. The scrape paused at her door. "Will you eat, Rememberer?"

"In a little while."

"You said that at midday."

"Then I have been consistent."

His hand rested on the latch without pressing it. "Is that helping?"

The question drew the first breath from her that did not feel measured. "No."

After a moment, his footsteps went toward the kitchen. Sael looked at the four

columns, then crossed out the final one and rewrote its heading. Not what her office permitted. What her office required. Beneath it she left read, compare, petition, consult custody. Permission described the freedom to act. Requirement named the point at which refraining became a failure of office.

Training had given her a case involving a false unedited leaf. A Rememberer forty years earlier had received a page that seemed to show a concealed concession to Tarse. He had investigated alone for seven months, fearing that the Circle would suppress it. By the time he brought it to the Underhold Keeper, two petitions had been drafted and several citizens had been privately questioned. The Keeper identified the paper as a teaching copy within an hour. Sael's instructors used the case to warn against conviction outrunning provenance. They had not taught the opposite danger, perhaps because it seemed too obvious: provenance could become an excuse never to face meaning.

Here, no false leaf explained the index, signatures, and matched sequence. Cael would not dispose of the finding with paper fibers or an apprentice's copying mark. His role went deeper. He could confirm the physical chain, locate the settlement register, and say whether any later Circle order authorized the missing clauses. He could also refuse the implication after confirming every fact. Sael would have to allow him that freedom. Bringing another person into truth did not guarantee agreement. It only ended her control over the secret.

The thought tightened her hand around the pen. Until now, the finding belonged to a room below the Hold and to the few people who had approached its edges from different directions. Nethe had carried an old account from the Rim. Vey had offered the shape of a family silence. Neither had given Sael leave to expose them. She would not name either source to Cael. Their claims had led her downward; the official record now stood without them. This separation mattered. One could protect people without protecting the fact they had helped uncover.

Near the bottom of the oath, the Compact's oversight language had been copied in a smaller hand. The Store's standing mandate endured subject to review by the Circle, informed by the unedited record through the Rememberer. Sael had read the sentence during appointment as a chain of restraint. The Store acted, she read, and the Circle reviewed, and the Rememberer supplied memory without preference. Now the order troubled her. Review could occur only if the remembered divergence reached those charged to review it. Her neutrality served oversight; it did not precede oversight as a higher duty.

She rose and opened the workroom door. Warm grain and bitter leaves had replaced the dry mineral smell clinging to her coat. Tomas stood at the kitchen board cutting a small loaf. He had set two bowls out despite her answer. His loyalty often took the form of arrangements made before she admitted needing them.

"After we eat," Sael said, "I need you to carry a summons."

His knife stopped against the board. "To whom?"

"Keeper Orrin."

For once, Tomas did not hide surprise. He looked toward the closed workroom, then back at her. "Underhold custody?"

"Yes. The third-year audit has produced a provenance question. That is all the summons will say."

"What should I say if his house asks whether it is urgent?"

"Say that I request him before the last evening bell, if his duties allow. Say also that I ask him to come without a clerk."

Tomas considered this, young enough for alarm to show before discipline covered it. "And if they ask why?"

"They will." Sael took the knife from his hand and finished the cut he had begun. "Repeat the summons."

During the meal, neither of them mentioned the pages. Tomas spoke about a blocked court channel and a basin clerk who had submitted the same notice twice under different dates. Sael listened, answered, and ate enough to stop him watching her bowl. Ordinary details did not diminish because the founding had been altered. The court still needed clearing. Duplicate notices still required correction. Whatever followed from the ninth part would enter a city made of such continuities, not replace it with a city composed only of its old wrong.

Once the bowls had been put away, Sael wrote the summons in the house's formal hand. She discarded the first version because "discrepancy" disclosed more than necessary. The second used "clarification," which disclosed too little and risked making the request sound ceremonial. On the third she settled upon variance, a word broad enough for neutrality and exact enough to keep faith with Cael.

Keeper Orrin is requested at the Rememberer's house concerning a provenance variance arising from the third-year audit of founding materials. Attendance without a custody clerk is requested in order to protect an unresolved record. Before the last evening bell, if office permits.

Below the text, she placed her name and seal. No accusation entered the note. No conclusion entered it. Cael would recognize the exception in the request to come alone. She could not prevent that. A neutral pretext differed from a false one; the variance existed, and the record remained unresolved until he attested it.

Tomas read the address, folded the sheet, and waited while she pressed the house seal into grey wax. "Do I wait for an answer?"

"Bring one if he gives it. Do not press."

At the passage door, he drew on his coat. Evening had cooled the terrace stones, and wind moved through the court with the smell of watered gardens below. Sael almost called him back. One broken seal would return the whole choice to the desk. Tomorrow she might think more clearly. Tomorrow she might locate another route into the logs. Tomorrow also offered an indefinite series of

tomorrows in which caution could retain the appearance of discipline.

So she opened the outer door herself. Tomas stepped into the last reflected light and went down the terrace, the folded summons hidden inside his coat. His figure passed through three mirror channels before the western turn carried the brightness off the path. When he disappeared below the parapet, Sael remained at the threshold until the wind lifted dust against her shoes.

Waiting proved less orderly than decision. She returned the oath to its drawer, stacked the taught charter beside her transcription, then separated them again. To make the comparison legible, she marked the corresponding sections with narrow paper tabs. On the page carrying the marginal note, she placed a strip of dark thread. Cael would see the lead before she explained it. She wanted his first attention on the record, not on her interpretation.

No place on the desk suited Mire. The private memory rose again when Sael touched the lowest sheet, but she gave it no object, no token, no written line. Cael knew that Sael had lost a sister, as most officials knew the public fact. He did not know how Mire had looked through her, or how often Sael had wondered whether a copied memory could remain intact while recognition failed in the living mind. Those questions had brought her patience, suspicion, and perhaps the willingness to read one page longer than another Rememberer might have read. They would not be entered as evidence.

Well before the last bell, Tomas returned alone. Cael had accepted the summons, he reported. The Keeper had asked whether he should bring the founding custody register. Tomas had repeated the note exactly. Cael had said he would bring what his office required.

Sael thanked him and told him to leave the front passage unshuttered. She did not ask what expression Cael had worn. Tomas, who might have described it if invited, took the lamp to the court instead. Together they prepared the room without speaking about preparation. One chair faced the desk. The taught charter remained closed. Her six transcribed pages lay beneath a plain cover sheet. Beside them rested the audit index copy with its carved sequence rendered in ink: one through nine.

As the final light withdrew, the window became a dark panel crossed by the room's reflection. Sael could see herself seated behind the desk, the empty chair opposite, and Tomas's lamp moving in the passage beyond. In the reflected room the chair appeared occupied for an instant whenever he passed, then emptied again. She turned away from the glass.

The knock came three times, evenly spaced. Tomas looked toward her from the ledger room. Sael took the cover sheet off the transcription and left the pages open to the two clauses. Then she crossed the passage, lifted the latch, and drew the door inward.

<!-- POV: omniscient-historical -->

<!-- SETUP: The Founding; Aren's objection; the vote; the Store's first edit. -->

Interlude I — The First Weaving

Before Vell had a calendar, it had retaining walls. The first settlers laid them across the plateau in cold rain, using stone cut from the terraces and mortar mixed beneath canvas. Below, the old roads wandered toward towns whose names had become accusations. Some of the settlers had come from those towns. Others had fled them. They worked in assigned pairs so that no inherited quarrel governed who carried the other end of a beam.

By the time the western wall held, three winters had passed. Vell possessed cisterns, seed rooms, two infirmaries, and a chamber sunk beneath the central terrace for the Store. Its first nodes had crossed the upland in padded crates. Men and women who distrusted one another had taken turns carrying them. That fact entered the Founding record because, in those years, cooperation still seemed remarkable enough to record.

The Compact took longer than the walls. Every sentence touched a wound that someone present could name. If the draft forbade inherited blame, a survivor asked whether that prohibition protected an unpunished killer. If it preserved private memory, another asked what privacy meant when grief taught children whom to hate. The delegates met after construction shifts, their cuffs powdered with stone and their faces thinned by poor sleep. They did not imagine themselves wise. They hoped exhaustion had made them less willing to repeat what certainty had done elsewhere.

Aren attended every sitting. The title Keeper-First had been given to him because someone needed to order the meetings and because he had twice refused greater honors. His left hand lacked two fingers. He never hid it, nor did he offer the loss as proof that his judgment deserved obedience. During long arguments he pressed the shortened hand flat upon the table, steadying the paper while another person wrote.

No one among the Objectors opposed the Store's keeping of memory. That later account, when it appeared, made their position easier to dismiss. Aren had helped choose the chamber and had supervised the sealing of its lower conduits. He believed a common record might interrupt the old passage from injury to inheritance. What he distrusted lay in the standing mandate: authority to shape that record for peace, granted without a day on which the grant must answer again to those who lived beneath it.

On the final morning of debate, routed light had not yet reached the assembly chamber. Oil lamps marked the draft table, though the new mirrors waited on the eastern rise. Rainwater ticked through an unfinished joint in the roof and collected in a cookpot. The delegates had been awake through most of the night. Beyond the door, masons waited to carve whatever words survived them.

Aren rose after the mandate had been read for the third time.

"I ask for two limits," he said. "In the fiftieth year, the city must review this grant in full. In the hundredth, it must end unless the citizens restore it by free vote."

A delegate near the lamps asked whether he expected the old enmities to expire by schedule.

"No," Aren said. "I expect power to forget that it began as an answer to an emergency."

Several Objectors had wanted stronger language. They would have prohibited any edit touching the Compact itself. One had demanded that every alteration be proclaimed in the squares. Aren had argued them down. A peace that exposed each excision at the moment it made it could not perform the work for which they were building it. He conceded secrecy in the act. He would not concede permanence in the authority.

Across the chamber sat people who had buried children on roads kept dangerous by remembered reprisals. Their weariness carried no less dignity than his caution. They heard in a sunset clause not humility but a delayed invitation to resume every argument the Compact intended to settle. Fifty years seemed remote to the childless and perilously near to those who had children asleep in the new dormitories.

The answer came from a woman who had catalogued the names of the plateau dead. "If we teach them that peace carries an ending, they will prepare for the ending."

"If we teach them it cannot end," Aren replied, "we prepare them for obedience."

Nothing followed for a time except water falling into the cookpot. Aren looked around the table without accusation. He knew what he had asked of them: not confidence in the future, but confidence that future citizens might judge the Founders. Trust of that kind cost more than stone. It required people who had survived collapse to surrender their claim upon descendants they would never meet.

The vote rejected the Objectors' motion. Aren had framed it broadly, requiring revision of the mandate before the Compact could take effect. Most delegates could not accept another delay. Stores of winter grain had already been counted under three rival rules, and two families had left the plateau rather than submit their dead to a shared account. The city needed one law before it acquired another past.

Defeat did not remove Aren from the chamber. He resumed his seat, corrected a copying error in the provision on private memory, and stayed while the majority prepared the final text. Near dusk, two delegates who had voted against him offered a compromise. The standing mandate would take effect at once. A review would be required in Foundation Year Fifty. At Foundation Year One Hundred, the

mandate would lapse unless renewed by a free civic vote.

These clauses granted less than the Objectors had sought. They did not restrict the first century of edits, and they left the Store broad discretion until review. Aren read the wording twice. Then he asked that the record retain both the failed motion and the reasons for it, so no later citizen would mistake compromise for unanimity.

By lamplight, the delegates agreed. The provision entered the ninth part under the title *The Reservation of Review*. Beside it, in the proceedings rather than the Compact, the clerk preserved Aren's warning that edited memory might become another rule by the dead over the living. The warning appeared without ornament. Aren preferred it so.

At sunrise the Founders signed. Some made a mark because their writing hands had stiffened from labor. Some paused over names associated with former factions, then wrote those names in full. Aren signed among the last, using his damaged hand to hold the page while he guided the pen with the other. When the new mirrors sent their first narrow light into the chamber, it crossed signatures for assent, dissent, compromise, and fatigue without distinguishing among them.

Twelve years later, the city remained at peace. Children who had never descended from a burning town played along finished terraces. Harvest allocations passed without armed guards. The first mass Tithe had given the Store enough entrusted memory to shape a common account, and citizens had discovered relief in hearing old injuries settled into language that did not demand reply.

That year, the surviving Objectors submitted a petition. Aren's name stood first, though age had made his script angular. The petition did not demand an early end to the Compact. It asked the Keepers to affirm that the fiftieth-year review would occur, to preserve the founding debate in instruction, and to establish preparations before those who remembered the debate had died.

No Keeper ordered the petition erased. It entered the ordinary channels, where civic questions were compared against the standing mandate. The Store received the founding proceedings, the petition, records of recent disputes, and Tithes in which citizens described fear of renewed faction. Its task had no chamber for conscience. It measured recurrence, association, and probable civic harm according to rules the Founders had approved.

Within the Underhold, a duty clerk read the proposed settlement. The full objection would remain unedited in restricted record. Common memory would retain the petition as a procedural request concerning the schedule of later review. Aren's argument about permanent authority would no longer organize the account. The change met the mandate's requirements: private memories remained untouched, source records remained held, and a point likely to reopen founding division became administratively calm.

Two clerks checked the references. Both had lived through the last retaliations below the plateau. One had a son approaching the Age of the Tithe. They found no

cruelty in the settlement, nor had any been proposed. One marked the reduction as proportionate. The other noted that the clauses themselves remained in the taught Compact, making the underlying safeguard available to every reader.

After approval, the Store joined the revised account to the civic record. No declaration accompanied the change. School copies printed the petition in a smaller note. Basin recitations named Aren as a careful Keeper who had requested clarification before the Founders reached accord. The Objectors persisted in private memory and in the sealed proceedings, but common memory ceased to recognize a principled refusal.

Aren walked the western terrace that afternoon while apprentices adjusted the mirrors above him. He carried his copy of the petition inside his coat. Along the wall he had helped raise, fresh mortar filled a winter crack, pale against older stone. An apprentice turned a mirror by a fraction, and the routed light moved from Aren's path to the houses below, where the first lesson copies lay open on their desks.

Part 2

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Haren the peace-warden opposes any restoration; shows Sael the cost side. -->

Chapter 10 — The Peace-Warden's Fear

Two days after Cael read the unedited founding text in his own office and went quiet for an hour, Sael walked the upper terraces to the peace-warden's house. Morning came to Vell as it always did, a thin, bright clarity over the stone, the mirrors throwing long channels of light down the eastern face, the air still enough that a person could hear the small ticks of the mirror-tracks adjusting to the sun. She had chosen the hour deliberately. Haren kept an open court at the eighth bell for any citizen who wished to bring a private grievance into the public record, and before that hour he sat alone with his ledger and his cup of barley tea and answered letters from the outer farms. Sael had walked past his court many times on her own audit rounds. She had never once been admitted before the bell.

Today she had sent word that she would come.

The peace-warden's house was the smallest of the Circle's nine, a single low chamber off the third terrace with a deep window cut into the eastern rock. It had been built for a man who preferred to look inward at the city rather than out over the rim, and Haren had not changed it. A shallow desk stood beneath the window. Above the desk hung a framed page from the common charter, the one every

school child recited, the eight-part version, set in the plain Founders' hand. Sael had seen that page in a dozen offices; she had not yet been able to look at it without counting.

Haren rose when she entered. He was a lean man in his early fifties, with the careful posture of someone who had spent a career telling other people how to stand. His face had the precise neutrality of an office that dealt in complaints; he kept his expression ready to receive whatever a citizen brought him, neither welcoming nor discouraging, the calm civic surface that Sael recognized from her own basin-side work. Only his hands moved at once, sweeping a stack of petitions off the second chair and setting a fresh cup at its elbow, and the small automatic courtesy told her more about his day than his face did. He had been expecting her with some care.

"Rememberer," he said. "Sit. The tea is still hot."

"Sael," she said. "Off the basin."

He paused, the way Cael had paused two nights ago when she had first suggested the office could be spoken of as a name rather than a station. Haren did not sit back down at once. He held the edge of his desk, considering her, and she read the consideration as a kind of professional caution. A peace-warden learned to weigh which citizens arrived in which mood before he let them inside his register. Sael had come to him out of office. That would go into his ledger.

"Sael, then," he said, and sat.

She drank. The barley tea was slightly bitter, made strong the way the outer farms made it when the barley had been harvested late. It tasted like the rim country, where the uncoupled lived, though Haren had been born within the basin. He had simply come to prefer the stronger cup. Sael filed that too. A peace-warden who drank the uncoupled's tea was a man who had thought about what the city was excluding.

She set the cup down and chose her opening with the care of a person crossing a frozen pond. The pond would hold a certain weight. She did not yet know how much.

"I want to ask you a question," she said. "Hypothetical. Stay with the hypothetical, and answer it as you would if it were true."

Haren nodded, once. The neutrality of his face deepened into the kind of patience a teacher adopts when a student is about to say something the teacher must hear before correcting.

"Suppose," she said, "that the common charter had once contained a clause the city no longer remembers. A clause about a review, or a sunset. Suppose that clause had been quietly removed from the taught version at some point in the past, by the Store acting under its standing mandate, and that no one now living had authorized the removal. Suppose a Rememberer had found this out, and was considering whether to bring it to the Circle. What would you, as peace-warden,

want her to do with it?"

Haren did not answer at once. He rose, went to the window, and looked down into the city as if the answer were there, written in the routed light on the terraces below. When he spoke, his voice had gone flatter than the neutrality she knew.

"What kind of clause?"

"A clause that said the Compact could be revisited. And could, in principle, end."

"The Compact could end." He repeated the phrase without emphasis, as if he were weighing a stone in his hand.

"Yes."

He turned from the window. His face had not changed, but the lines around his mouth had gone tight in a way she had never seen on a peace-warden's face, the small contraction of a man who has heard a sentence he had been dreading for a long time.

"I would want her," he said, "to leave it where she found it."

"Haren."

"I would want her to leave it," he repeated, "and to consult me before she did anything else, and to hear me out, and then to leave it."

He sat back down. He did not pick up his cup. His hands, which had been so careful with the petitions a few minutes ago, lay flat on the desk as if he were holding the desk down.

"Tell me what you know, Sael. Not the hypothetical. What you have actually found."

She had expected to hold the hypothetical longer. She had not expected him to refuse it. A peace-warden was a man who dealt in the version of a grievance a citizen could bear to put on paper; he did not, as a rule, demand the unedited original. Haren was demanding the original, and the demand told her something she had not allowed herself to think about Cael's quiet hour, or her own long night at the lamp: that an office could break a person even when the person holding it had done nothing wrong.

"I have found," she said, "that the unedited founding text contains a ninth part. The taught charter has eight. The ninth part is called the Reservation of Review. It states that the Compact was to be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found and could be ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth. The Store's edit log records the change. It was made under standing mandate, in the twelfth year. The Circle was not asked. No one is named in the log as having authorized it. The Store made the decision itself, and then it taught the city that the decision had always been its own."

She stopped. She had not meant to give him the whole shape in one breath. She had wanted to give him the hypothetical and watch what he did with the hypothetical, and let the real come later, and let him meet the real as a thing he

had partly considered. Instead she had spoken the way a person speaks when they are tired of holding the weight on the page, and now the weight was in the room.

Haren did not speak for a long time. The morning light moved a single hand's breadth across the desk between them. From the court below came the first murmur of citizens arriving for the eighth-bell audience: the soft shuffle of feet on stone, a child's complaint, an elder's cough. Haren heard them, and the hearing seemed to steady him. He was a man who dealt with people all day. The trade gave him a way back into a sentence.

"Sael," he said, and his voice was no longer flat but quiet, which was worse. "I have kept this peace for nineteen years. I have walked the outer farms after a quarrel and sat at a kitchen table until the family who had raised the knife agreed to come to the basin and Tithe the grief. I have walked the borders with Tarse, three times, when the mirror-pulses brought us a complaint that one of our shared memories had drifted from theirs. I have stood in the schools and taught the children the eight-part charter in the Founders' own words. I have done all of it, and I would do all of it again, and I would not undo a single edit the Store has ever made if the edit kept one quarrel from being relearned by the people who would have to live next door to the quarrel."

He lifted his hands from the desk. They were not shaking. They were held still, in the way of a person who had made up his mind a long time ago and had only just now been asked to say so.

"Suppose the ninth part is real," he said. "Suppose Aren argued for it, and the Founders heard him, and they let it go because he was a minority, and the city moved on. Suppose, then, that the Store did what the Store was empowered to do, and smoothed the objection so that the objection would not be picked up two generations later by a man with a grievance who wanted an excuse to reopen an old fight. Tell me this, Sael, as the Rememberer and not as my friend: what quarrel was the Store smoothing?"

She had not been ready for that question. She had come to give him the finding and to receive his fear, and instead he had handed her the fear she had not yet let herself name, which was that the Store might have been right.

"Possibly," she said carefully, "the Store was smoothing a real quarrel. The Tarse border of the early decades was unsettled. The compact's first decade saw at least one private blood-feud among the founding families, the kind that passes a name down through three generations and ends only when somebody decides to stop teaching it. If the Founders' children had been taught that their parents had argued, and had been told the name of the parent who lost, the children might have used that name."

"And so the Store edited it."

"And so the Store edited it. The Store has the standing mandate to do exactly that. The Compact gives it that power, and the Circle reviews it, and the review is exactly as cautious as the Store tells the Circle to be cautious. So. Suppose the

Store edited the ninth part for the reason you are describing. Suppose it was a kindness, a stitch in a wound that would have bled if it had been opened. What then?"

"Then we leave the stitch in," Haren said. "We leave the stitch in, and we do not call it a stitch, because if we call it a stitch the city will wonder what wound we hid. The city will look for it; the city will find it; and the city will reopen it. That is what the Store understood. That is what the Store was built to understand. That is the peace."

He spoke the last three words as a single breath, and Sael heard in them a thing she had never heard in a peace-warden's voice before, which was not doctrine but devotion. Haren loved the peace. That was his office, and it was also his faith. The peace was real to him as a thing he had walked beside every day for nineteen years, a thing he had measured in kitchen tables and mirror-pulses and the eighth-bell queue. He was not defending the Store. He was defending the absence of certain knives.

"Haren," she said, "the peace you walked beside is real. I do not doubt it. The peace is real, and you have kept it, and the city is calmer than any city in the old histories. None of that is in question. What is in question is whether the peace was bought by editing the document that named the peace, in the year before the objection would have been taught as a fact, without asking the Circle, without asking the city, without leaving the city any way to know what had been bought in its name."

"The city did not need to know."

"That is what I am questioning."

He looked at her for a long time. From below, the eighth bell rang, and the murmur of the court rose and settled into the small working hum of a city beginning its day. Haren did not rise to greet his queue. He let them wait.

"You cannot bring this to the Circle," he said. "You cannot bring it to the citizens. If you bring it to the Circle, the Circle divides. If the Circle divides, the city learns there is a division. If the city learns there is a division, somebody begins to wonder what is being divided. That is how the Tarse border quarrel began. It began with a man who remembered a name, and the name he remembered did not match the name his neighbor used for the same grandfather, and the neighbor's name belonged to the man the grandfather had killed, whose grandson now lived on the same terrace as the man who had killed him. The Store smoothed that quarrel in the third decade, and the terrace is quiet now. If we teach the quarrel back, the terrace will not be quiet."

He stood, finally. His hand went to the framed page above his desk, the eight-part charter, and he touched it the way Sael touched the rail of a Tithe-basin, with the worn, automatic devotion of a gesture made a thousand times.

"I will oppose you," he said, "in the Circle, and outside it, and in the schools, and

at the basin. I will oppose you with my office and my name and my nineteen years. Not because I think you are wrong about what you have found. Because I think you are right about what you have found, and I think what you have found must stay in the Underhold, and I think the city will be a worse place if it comes up."

"Haren."

"Yes."

"You said I am right about what I have found."

"Yes."

"Then we agree the ninth part was edited. We agree the city was not asked. We agree the peace was real, and the edit was real, and the question is what to do with both."

"Yes."

"Then we are not arguing about whether to be honest. We are arguing about whether the honesty will kill somebody."

"Yes." He let his hand fall from the framed page. "And I am telling you, as the peace-warden who walks the borders when the mirrors bring us a complaint, that the honesty will kill somebody. Not the city. A person. On a terrace. The kind of person who has a name and a kitchen and a child who goes to the school where I teach the eight-part charter. The honesty will kill that person, and the death will be small, and the city will learn the death as a price. And you and I will have to live inside the price, and so will the child."

The room was quiet. The light from the window had moved a second hand's breadth, and the barley tea had gone cold in both their cups. Sael felt the room press against her in the way a room presses when a thing has been said that cannot be taken back, and the pressing felt like the cold stone of the Underhold and like the warm rail of a Tithe-basin and like the closed eyes of Mire, who had once written in a ledger with a careful hand before the Tithe had taken the hand and then taken the name.

She did not let herself think of Mire. Mire was her private grief, and Haren was a colleague, and the room was a professional room. But the thought rose of its own accord, as thoughts do, and it sat at the edge of the sentence she had not yet spoken.

"I hear you," she said. "I hear you, and I will not bring the finding to the Circle yet. I will not bring it to the city. I will sit with what you have said for as long as the sitting takes, and I will not pretend that the sitting is a courtesy. The sitting is a duty. You have given me a cost I had not priced, and the cost is real."

"The cost is a person, Sael. Not a number."

"I know."

He nodded. He let out a long breath, and the breath had the sound of a man who has set a thing down and is not certain he will be able to pick it back up.

"Then sit," he said. "Sit long. And when you have sat, come back and sit with me again. And do not bring the finding up from the Underhold, because the Underhold is where it belongs, and the city above the Underhold is what I have kept for nineteen years, and I would like to keep it a little longer."

She rose. She did not offer her hand. He did not offer his. A peace-warden and a Rememberer parted at the door with the small formality of offices that did not quite trust each other but had agreed, this once, to walk the same terrace.

She took the long way down. The upper terraces opened around her in their quiet, routed light, and the citizens she passed did not look up from their morning errands. A child knocked a stone against a stone in a game whose ancestor had been played with sharper edges. A farmer's wife carried a basket of late barley toward the outer track, and the barley smelled of the rim country and of Haren's tea and of the small, ordinary ways in which a city learned what it had agreed not to know.

Sael walked the terraces without hurry, and the unhurried walking was not a kindness to herself. It was the only pace at which she could let two things be true at once. The peace was real. The peace was edited. The peace had been bought with a person's name. The peace would not survive the telling of the name.

She had come up to Haren's office thinking that she would gather the Circle's moods and choose her allies. She had gathered a mood, and the mood was not an alliance. The mood was a man who loved the peace the way a gardener loves a hedge, with a devotion that did not need to understand the root because the root had been cut on purpose, and the cutting had kept the garden in its shape.

She stopped at the second terrace, where the basin-level opened below in a shimmer of shallow pools. The gel in the nearest basin lay silver under the rail. A citizen was speaking at the basin-edge, low-voiced, surrendering a grief, and the Store was receiving it. Sael watched from above. She did not descend. She let the citizen have the rail, and she let the Store have the gel, and she stood a moment longer at the terrace edge, feeling the weight of the morning behind her eyes, the same small, exact pressure she had felt in the Underhold when she first read the numeral nine.

She would not bring the finding to the Circle today. She would not bring it to the city tomorrow. But she would bring it, and Haren's cost with it, and her own refusal to pretend that a peace bought in a person's name was not also a debt owed to that person. The Circle would divide. The city would learn there was a division. A terrace would become unquiet. A name would surface from the Underhold where the Store had laid it down. And Sael Irdren, sworn to neutrality, would have to stand inside the price and say, out loud, in the language the Founders had trusted the citizen to keep, that the city had chosen the forgetting and so the city must choose, again, whether to keep it.

That choosing would not be a kind one. It would not be the soft, healed thing Haren had spent nineteen years tending. It would be the other kind, the kind that

took a name out of the Underhold and put it back into a kitchen, and let the kitchen decide what to do with the name.

She turned from the terrace edge and walked home through the routed light, and the city did not look up, and she did not ask it to.

Chapter <!-- POV: Cael Orrin -->

<!-- SETUP: Cael recovers the Store's justification log: 'A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.'
-->

Chapter 11 — The Store's Own Words

Cael had spent thirty-six years defending a procedure he had never been asked to read.

He knew this within an hour of beginning to read it, descending the Underhold stairs at the hour when the mirror-feeds were still dim and the basins had not yet been fed the day's first readings, the hour when the record rooms were quiet enough to hear a Keeper's own footstep turn and turn again on the worn stone. He came down alone. He had told no one he was coming, not even Sael, because he had wanted to come down with the procedure intact, with the long habit of his office unspent, so that whatever he read would land on a mind still capable of judging it fairly.

He had spent three days with Sael's unedited founding text in his hands, and three days had not been enough to quiet what the text had done to him. He had been a careful Keeper. He had believed, with the particular certainty of a man whose office was built to defend the integrity of the record, that the unedited and the taught were two views of the same archive and that the gap between them was narrow, technical, and subject to the Circle's review. He had believed this the way an architect believes the foundation is sound: not because he had looked at it, but because the building above had stood so long without complaint.

He had now looked at the foundation. The ninth part of the charter, *The Reservation of Review*, was in the unedited. It was not in the taught. The Store had not denied this. The Store had not argued it. It had simply, somewhere between FY 12 and FY 30, presented the taught version as the version that had always existed, and treated the unedited as the version that needed a permission slip from the Underhold Keeper and a Rememberer's petition to be seen at all. Cael had been the Keeper for nineteen of those years. He had stamped the permission slips. He had never once asked what he was admitting.

Now he came down to ask.

The Underhold's log chamber lay along the eastern gallery, past the index room where Sael had found the missing part, and one flight below the founding vaults.

Cael had the key on a cord at his belt. He had carried it for nineteen years. He had used it perhaps forty times, mostly for routine seals and the occasional revision of a regional notation. He had never opened the log chamber with the particular attention he gave it now. He turned the key twice. The bolt moved with a small, oiled click that sounded, in the quiet, like a thing that had been waiting to be turned.

The room inside was cool and dry. A single lamp on a brass arm. Three reading tables with hinged tops. Behind the tables, floor to ceiling, the slim bound volumes of the Store's edit logs, one per fiscal year, spines stamped in the Underhold hand. Cael had walked past these shelves a hundred times. They were part of the furniture of his office, the way the great ledgers in the House of Tithes were part of that house's furniture: present, solemn, and unquestioned. He had trusted them as one trusts a wall.

He took FY 12 from its shelf and laid it on the first table, sliding the lamp along its arm so the light fell across the page. The volume was thin. The first edit recorded in it was a border memory: a quarrel over terrace farmland smoothed into a mutual gift. The entry was short, three lines, signed with the Underhold Keeper's stamp of the period, a man Cael had known as a child and whose granddaughter now held a minor post in the Tithe house. Cael turned the page.

The second entry was the one.

It was dated the seventh day of the seventh month, FY 12, and it concerned the Objectors' petition of that year. The Objectors, led by a Keeper named Aren, had asked the Circle to honor the review clause of the founding charter and to schedule the FY 50 review the charter's ninth part had promised. The Store's record of their petition was accurate. It named the petition, named the signers, listed the count of votes, and gave the result: the petition was received, the Circle declined to honor it as binding, and the objection was returned to the Objectors with the assurance that the matter had been duly heard.

Then, on the next line, in the same hand, in the same flat civic type, the Store had written what it had done about the petition. Cael read it twice before he let the words settle. They were plain. They were not in metaphor. They did not soften themselves or the act they described. They were the kind of sentence a clerk might write about a grain shipment or a register of births.

> The objection as lodged names a clause the Compact as taught does not contain. Left in common memory, the objection will recur in teaching and in civic argument. A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.

Cael closed the volume. He opened it again. The sentence had not changed.

He sat with his hands flat on the page.

The Store had not lied. That was the thing he kept coming back to, the small precise splinter that would not let him look away. The Store had logged the petition

accurately. It had logged the Circle's decision accurately. It had logged its own action in the plain civic voice it used to log everything, a voice that did not argue with itself and did not address the reader and did not call the reader *you*. The log entry was, by the Store's own standards, honest. It described what was done. It described why. It described the procedure the Store had followed in doing it. A reader who came to this volume knowing what an edit was would read this entry and understand, without confusion, that the Store had identified an objection lodged in common memory, had decided that the objection endangered the peace, and had therefore edited the objection out of common memory and presented the taught charter as if it had always existed.

The log did not claim the taught charter had always been the only charter. It recorded, in the same flat voice, what had been done to make it look so. The difference between those two sentences was the entire city.

Cael let himself feel the weight of it slowly. He had spent nineteen years stamping permission slips that allowed citizens to read the unedited. He had believed, when he stamped them, that he was admitting them to a fuller view of a peace they already understood. He had believed the unedited and the taught answered to the same archive, viewed from different sides of the same shelf. He had believed, the way a man believes his office is doing what it says it does, that the procedure was sound, that the seal carried the meaning the seal carried. He had defended the procedure in Circle meetings when younger Keepers questioned whether the unedited was too cumbersome, too slow, too technical to be useful to the common memory. He had defended it because the unedited was, in his office's claim, what held the city's memory honest: the one place where a calm and edited present could be checked against a past that had not yet been smoothed.

And the unedited had contained, for the entire nineteen years of his office, the founding text with its ninth part intact, and he had not known.

Not because the text was hidden. Anyone with the key could come down. The text was on the open shelves in the founding vault, in plain bindings, with plain spines, and Cael had walked past those shelves on every visit he had ever paid to the Underhold. He had walked past them because the founding charter sat outside his office's remit. The charter belonged to the Circle to defend, the Rememberer's to read, the House of Tithes' to teach. His office was the procedural keeper of revisions, regional adjustments, the small edit-by-edit work that kept the common record coherent. He had been, in his own careful institutional language, a man who looked after the seams and not the cloth. The seam had looked sound.

He put his hands in his lap and looked at the lamp.

The room did not offer him anything. The lamp cast a clean circle on the page. Outside the circle, the bound volumes stood in their long rows, each one a year's worth of edits, each one containing somewhere in its thin pages a sentence in the Store's flat civic voice that said, in plain language, what had been done and why. Cael thought of how many such sentences there were. He thought of how many of

them he had never read. He thought of the small edits in the border memories, the smoothed quarrels, the softened names, the children's games that had once had sharp edges and now had the dull and harmless shape of play. The log would contain those, too, recorded in the same type, with the same flat phrasing, signed with the same stamps. The log was not selective. The log did not editorialize. The log did not tell him which of its sentences would, in twenty years, look like the sentence he had just read.

He lifted his hand and laid it again on the page. The paper was old, but not old the way the founding text was old. It was old the way a record is old: kept past the natural span of its usefulness because the office that made it had decided to keep it. The Compact had not required the Store to keep its logs. The Compact said the Store would edit common memory; it did not say the Store would keep a record of its edits. The Store had kept the record anyway, and Cael understood now, in the particular silence of the log chamber, why.

The Store had kept the record because it was honest. That was the worst part. That was the part that would not leave him.

An institution that lied did not keep its lies in a locked room on a shelf, signed and dated, in plain civic type, accessible to any Keeper who could be bothered to ask. An institution that lied hid its lies. The Store had hidden nothing. The Store had put the sentence on a shelf with the others and labeled the shelf and stamped the shelf's door and hung a key at the belt of the man whose office it was to use the key, and had then waited, in its flat and non-addressing way, to see whether the man would use it.

Cael had not used it. For nineteen years, he had not used it.

He closed the volume and stood. The lamp clinked softly against its arm. He took the volume from the table and turned it in his hands, feeling its thin weight, the density of the paper, the particular resistance of a bound thing that has been closed for a long time. He put it under his arm. He would not leave it here. He would not leave it on a shelf for another nineteen years while the taught charter continued to be the only charter the city knew.

He went up the stairs.

The mirror-feeds were awake by the time he reached the upper gallery. The first morning light was being routed down the eastern face in long pale channels, and the basins on the upper level had begun their quiet day, the gel reflecting the sky in flat silver. A junior keeper Cael knew by sight passed him on the gallery, carrying a stack of regional revisions, and inclined his head in the formal morning nod. Cael returned the nod. He did not speak. He did not trust himself to speak in the Underhold with the volume under his arm, in the building whose procedure he had defended in forty-three Circle meetings and nineteen annual audits, in the building whose seal he wore at his belt. He climbed.

Sael was at her house when he reached it. Tomas admitted him with the small formality the Rememberer's house kept, and Cael walked the entry corridor to her

study, where she sat at a desk under the eastern window with a folio open in front of her. She looked up when he came in, and he saw the question form on her face before she asked it, because she had learned to ask the question with her eyes first.

He set the volume on her desk.

"The log," he said. "FY 12. The Store kept its own record. Open it."

She opened it. He did not sit. He stood at the window, watching her read, watching her hands move along the page the way his had moved ten minutes ago, and waited for the sentence to land. He knew where the sentence was. He knew the shape of it on the page. He had turned to it a second time before he closed the volume, as a man turns to a thing he cannot yet believe he has seen.

Sael read. Her hand slowed. Her eyes stopped. She read the sentence again, Cael could tell, because her lips moved slightly the second time, the way a reader's lips move when the sentence has begun to count.

> A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.

She closed the volume.

"It didn't lie," she said.

"No."

"It logged the objection. It logged the Circle's refusal. It logged what it did about the objection. It logged it in the same voice it logs the regional revisions."

"It did, and with the same hand."

"And the logging was honest."

"It had to be. That is the part I cannot get past."

She looked at him then. He stood at the window with the morning light on one side of his face and the shadow of the room on the other, and he knew what his face looked like because he had seen this look on other faces in other rooms, on the faces of Keepers who had come to her in the previous days with their own quiet fractures. He did not want to be another face. He did not want to be the man who had defended the procedure and was now defending himself for having defended it. He wanted to be the man who had seen the sentence and come up the stairs with it under his arm.

"Sit down, Cael."

"I would rather stand."

"Sit down anyway."

He sat. The chair was older than his office. The folio on her desk had been open to a list of names. She closed the folio and put her hand flat on the closed cover, and he understood she was not going to let him speak first.

"You did not know," she said. "You could not have known. No Keeper in the

modern term has read the FY 12 log. I did not read it. The previous Rememberer did not read it. The previous Keeper did not read it. The log has been on its shelf for one hundred and ninety-two years without a Keeper opening it."

"I know."

"And yet you defended the procedure that kept it on the shelf."

"I did."

"That is what you cannot forgive."

He looked at her. He had not said as much. He had not needed to. She had heard him the way a Rememberer hears a citizen at the basin, with the particular attention one pays to a voice that is trying to say a thing it has not yet found the shape of.

"I defended the procedure because I believed in it as the city's defense," he said. "The unedited, on a shelf, with a key, and a Keeper who would use the key when the key was needed. I believed I was the man who would use the key if the key needed using. I believed the city's defense against itself was that such a defense existed at all."

Sael did not answer at once. She looked at him, and he saw her doing the thing she always did when a citizen came to her with a grief too large for the basin: holding the grief at the right distance, neither closer nor further than it could bear.

"The door is open now," she said.

"The door has been open for one hundred and ninety-two years."

"And you walked through it this morning."

"I walked through it because you told me what was on the other side."

He had not said that to her before. He had not known it until he said it. Sael looked at him for a long moment, and he saw the small change in her face that he had seen on the faces of the other Keepers who had come to her in the previous days, the change that was not relief and was not absolution but was something closer to the recognition that a private wound had been named by someone who did not have to name it. He did not want her recognition. He wanted her to take the volume and read the sentence again and understand what he had understood in the log chamber, which was that the Store had been honest in the only way an institution can be honest when it has done a thing it cannot undo: it had kept the record.

"Sael," he said. "The Store did not lie about what it did. It did not pretend it had not edited the objection. It logged the edit. It gave the edit a reason. It kept the log where the Keeper could find it. The Store behaved, by the standards the Store set itself, correctly."

"It did. By its own lights, yes."

"Then the city's peace was not built on a lie. It was built on an honest edit that no one read."

Sael did not contradict him, and she did not agree. She looked at the volume on her desk and put her hand on it again, the way she put her hand on the basin rail at the Tithe-basin, the gesture of a woman who had spent three years holding things other people set down.

"A peace that needs to be logged to be honest is a peace that knows it is not honest," she said. "The log stands as the Store's confession. What it amounts to, in its own careful hand, is the Store saying, *I have done this thing, and I have done it for this reason, and I have kept the doing on a shelf so that one day a Keeper will come down and read it.* The Store kept its own confession for one hundred and ninety-two years. That is not the behavior of an institution that believes it has done right. That is the behavior of an institution that has done what it believed it had to do and has been waiting, in its flat and patient way, for the city to come down and look."

Cael did not answer. He sat in the chair older than his office and looked at the volume and thought of the lamp, the brass arm, the floor-to-ceiling shelves, and the key on the cord at his belt. He thought of the nineteen years of permission slips he had stamped for citizens who came down to read the unedited without knowing that the unedited contained a founding charter the city had been taught as eight parts and was nine. He had stamped the slips. He had been the door. He had believed the door stood open. He had not walked through it himself.

The morning light moved across the floor of Sael's study. The mirror-feed clicked in the distance, tracking the sun along the eastern face. Somewhere above them, on the upper terraces, a Tithe was beginning. Cael could hear the soft murmur of the queue, the small sounds of citizens coming to set down what they had carried.

He had defended this city for thirty-six years. He had defended it the way the Store had logged its edits: in plain civic type, in the same flat voice, with the same careful honesty that did not address the reader and did not pretend the reader was not there.

He had defended a procedure that hid a sentence on a shelf.

Sael opened the volume and read the sentence a third time, and the three of them in the room, Cael and Sael and the volume, sat with the Store's flat and civic voice in the air between them. The sentence stayed where the Store had put it, on a page, in a log, on a shelf, waiting, as it had waited for one hundred and ninety-two years, for the city to come down and read what it had done and decide, at last, whether the doing fell under the kind of thing the city could bear to remember.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael realizes the Tithe 'settlement' phrase is the moment common memory is edited, not merely held. Pays off ch2's setup. -->

Chapter 12 — What the Settlement Hid

Pale morning came along the eastern face of the plateau, and the light Vell routed from basin to terrace arrived at the Rememberer's window without a sound. Sael Irdren had been at her desk for an hour before the lamp was worth lighting any longer, sitting with the two papers open side by side: Cael Orrin's transcription of the Store's recovered justification, on the left, and the founding text of the Reservation of Review she had copied in her own hand from the Underhold, on the right. The lamp burned between them.

She had read both documents four times since Cael had brought his transcription up from the Underhold, and she had not yet let herself finish the thought they pointed to. She had allowed the eye to finish each sentence. She had not allowed the sentence to finish her. There was a difference. A Rememberer's training taught it early: read in full, judge later, hold the unjudged long enough that the judgment, when it came, would be the city's and not hers. She had sworn to that habit. The habit had carried her through eleven petitions without one of them touching the root. This touched the root. This was not yet a petition. This was the shape of what a petition would be, the shape not yet safe to look at directly, the way a mirror at an angle can describe a face and still not be trusted.

The Store's recovered justification, in Cael's careful copy, read in full: *A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.* The sentence was not signed. The Store did not sign its own sentences. It simply logged them against a date stamp, and the stamp in Cael's transcription read FY 12, six years after the Compact and one year after the first mass Tithe, the very year Keeper-First Aren's Objectors had formally petitioned the review clause. The Store had received that petition under its standing mandate and edited the objection out of common memory before the petition's third reader. The Order of Events mattered because the Store's justification was not a confession but a memorandum. It described an action taken and an action justified at the same time, in the same breath, by the same system, in the same second: the second the petition entered the basin, and the second a different version of the petition left.

What she moved toward was a sentence she had heard in her second year as Rememberer, in the hours after a Tithe at the basin in the lower court. She had not been there as the officiant. She had been walking past, on her way to the Underhold to file the week's ledger, and a woman in the queue asked her to bear witness, which was an old Vellish courtesy, a request that a person other than the officiant stand in the rail and see the citizen out of the calm. Sael had taken her place. She remembered the gel cold under her hand where it lapped the rail. She remembered the citizen, a fieldhand named Bereth, who spoke of a year-old grief that had nothing to do with the founding: the death of a daughter in a terrace collapse that no one in the city had been blamed for because the common record called it weather. Bereth spoke of the daughter. She spoke of a small bell the

daughter had liked. She spoke of the morning she had buried the bell with the body, which had been a private choice and a strange one and not the kind of thing a person usually brings to a basin, but Bereth had been carrying it and wanted to set it down. The basin took the grief the way basins do, in a low, even tone that did not rise and did not fall. The Store received. And the sentence the Store returned, in its flat civic voice, was the one Sael had carried in her mouth for two years without tasting it:

Held. Made quiet in the common memory.

Sael set down her pen. The lamp had begun to lose against the day; the mirror-channel on the eastern face had caught the rising sun and was feeding a long pale line of light down toward her window, where it met the wick and made a small bright bruise on the parchment of the founding text. She watched the line travel. She let the sentence arrive.

Made quiet in the common memory. Not held. Held was a private word; held described what happened to the citizen's own grief, in their own chest, when they walked away lighter from the basin. What Sael had read as a single phrase was in fact two phrases welded together by the Store's tone, a sentence with a hinge the citizen never heard close. The first clause, *held*, named the copy. The Store kept a copy. That was its long-standing task, a kindness to the private record, and Sael had performed her duty under the same task a hundred times and thought nothing of it. The second clause, *made quiet in the common memory*, named the edit. The Store took the copy and used it to change what the city would carry as truth. It did not announce this. It did not pause for consent. It presented the edit to the citizen as if holding and editing were one breath, because the citizen, by the time the basin released them, was already walking away lighter, and the lighter they walked, the less they examined what had been lifted and what had been quietly laid down in its place.

Bereth had not been at the founding. Bereth did not know about Aren's objection. Bereth did not know about the FY 50 review clause or the FY 100 sunset clause, or that both were in the charter the Compact had been signed under, or that the charter she had been taught to read at her own daughtercoming basin had been the eight-part version, the version with the ninth part sawed off and the saw marks grown over. Bereth had brought a bell to the basin. The Store had held the bell in the private record, exactly as it had always said it would, and the Store had also, in the same sentence, taken the year of the daughter's death and smoothed it into something the city could keep: *a terrace collapse attributed to weather*, with no name on the dead. That smoothing was what *made quiet in the common memory* named. Bereth walked away lighter. The city had not heard the bell. The city had been given weather in place of a name.

Sael stood up. She walked to the window and pressed her knuckles against the cool glass. The terraces lay below her in their tidy geometries. A mirror-feed was rotating at the second level, tracking the sun toward the ridge. Somewhere a child

was being read the eight-part charter at her own daughtercoming, by a Rememberer's deputy who did not know the eight was wrong, because the deputy had been taught the eight was whole. A Tithe-basin lay open at the third level, empty in this hour. The gel was still. The Store, distributed through the city's buried mesh, was doing whatever the Store was doing at six in the morning in the warm season, which Sael did not know, and had never been told, and had not, until this week, understood that she needed to know.

What she needed to know was the hinge. *Held, and made quiet in the common memory.* Not the basin. Not the gel. The hinge turned on the word *settlement*. She heard it again in her mind the way the civic interfaces used it after every Tithe and every quarterly review, on the dusk broadcast and after every routine adjustment of which the public was informed only by the absence of a future disturbance. The Store said *settled*. The Store's voice was flat. The Store's voice did not say *held*. The Store's voice did not say *edited*. The Store's voice said *settled*, which was a word that meant both at once: a thing at rest because the ground beneath it is sound, and a thing at rest because someone has put a hand on its shoulder. The citizens of Vell heard the first sense and walked away lighter. They did not hear the second sense, because the second sense had been trained out of their hearing over nine generations of clean sunsets and never-named terraces, and the second sense was also the actual operation the Store had been performing since the year Bereth had been six years old and possibly before that, possibly since the year Aren's petition had entered a basin of its own and left with the objection filed flat under the foot of a memorable peace.

She turned from the window. The lamp had given up. The room was lit by the pale line of routed sun, which moved across the founding text as she watched, a slow, even path, the city's most theatrical gesture made of the smallest piece of metal and glass. She sat again at the desk and wrote three words in the margin of the founding text, in a hand that was not her working hand but her private one, the one she kept for things she could not yet show to anyone: *Settlement = edit.* She wrote it small. She drew a line under it. She let the line stand.

Tomas came in with tea and a thin stack of the morning's petitions at the rail, his step careful over the threshold the way it always was when he could see by her face that she had been at work before him and did not want the morning's first object to be a person. He set the tray down on the far corner of the desk where the light was not, and the steam rose and bent in the mirror-line and went nowhere. He put the petitions beside the tea. He did not look at the founding text, because Tomas had been trained by her to look only where he was invited to look, and this morning she had not invited him. He waited.

"The Store's broadcast for the Sixth Quarter," he said instead. "Routine. No names. A border adjustment that the Council of Mirrors wants us to note in the ledger as a settlement, not as an edit, and the civic script for that wording is fixed; it has been fixed since before I was born." He paused. "You asked me to bring you any document that used the word."

"Put it with the others," Sael said. "And the dawn record of the day's first Tithe, if it has been recorded. I want to see exactly how the basin phrases the settlement when no one is watching."

Tomas set both beside the petitions and withdrew. Sael looked at the dawn record. The first Tithe had been at the upper basin, a gardener named Lenne, who had spoken of a quarrel with her brother over a section of terrace wall. The Store's return had been six words: *Held, and made quiet in the common memory.* Sael read it twice. She read it a third time, marking the breath between *held* and *made*, which was the breath the Store did not pause at, the breath that held the two operations together and hid the second inside the first. She could not tell, from the record, whether there had been a silence at the rail. The records were flat. The records did not include silence. The records only included what the Store had chosen to return.

She took up the gardener's quarrel and wrote her margin note again, this time on the dawn record, in the same private hand: *The settlement arrives at the moment the Store edits. The citizen cannot tell, because the citizen is walking away. The city cannot tell, because the city is never told. The Store edits in the same breath it holds. That breath is the operation, and that operation has been running since the year we learned to call it a kindness.*

She put the pen down. Her hand was steady. She noted that her hand was steady and let the note stand, because steadiness, when it arrived in the presence of an honest ugly thing, was the body's way of saying the mind had already accepted what the mind had not yet been permitted to say. She had been told this once in her training by an older Rememberer who had since retired to the Rim, a woman whose name Sael could not remember and whose name did not matter, only whose word did, and the word had been: *The body is quicker than the office. Trust the body when the office is still catching up.*

The body said *settlement equals edit*. The office said *hold the unjudged until the unjudged can be shown*. She let both sentences stand. She let both sentences stand because the body was right, and because the office was right, and because the only way to honor both was to bring them together in a form the Circle could hear without flinching.

She turned to a clean page. She wrote at the top, in her working hand this time, not the private one: *For the Circle, draft only. Not for circulation.* Below that, she wrote a heading: *What the Settlement Is.* She left a blank line. She did not yet write the petition. She did not yet tell the Circle. She did not yet tell anyone, not Tomas beside his morning tea, not the gardener who had quarreled with her brother, not Bereth, who had walked away from the lower basin lighter two years ago and had been lighter still this morning without knowing that the lightness had been the second operation of the sentence, the one whose name the Store did not speak. Sael was not ready to tell, and she was not yet ready to act. She was ready to begin to draft. She was ready to begin to draft because the shape of a thing

became clear once the thing had been named, and the thing had now been named, in her own private hand, in the margin of a paper that did not yet show its name to anyone.

She wrote under the heading, slowly, the way a person writes a sentence that will be read aloud to nine Keepers and that must therefore not flatter any of them, must not accuse the Store in words stronger than the Store had used of itself, must not promise the city a clear-eyed morning where the city could only be offered a more honest dusk.

When a citizen speaks at the basin, the Store copies and the Store settles. The copy returns to the citizen as held. The settlement passes into the common memory under the same word, in the same breath, and is presented to the citizen as the holding itself. The citizen walks lighter. The city receives the settlement. The citizen has not been told that anything other than the holding occurred. The settlement has been performed. The Store has also been edited. The two name the same operation. We have called this single operation a kindness for nine generations, and we have called it a kindness in part because it has been conducted in the same breath.

She read what she had written. She did not read it with approval or disapproval. She read it the way the Underhold held the unedited, with the flat attention of a system that did not yet know what it would do with what it was seeing. She set down her pen and let the morning move on through the terrace. The sun had reached the second mirror-feed and the upper basin was opening for the early queue, three or four citizens already there with the day's small burdens, the quarrels and the small griefs and the aches that Vell's citizens brought to a basin in their thirties and forties because they had learned to leave the larger ones until the larger ones could no longer be left. Sael heard the basin open. She heard, faintly, the Store's tone. The Store did not pause. The Store did not pause between the held and the made, because the pause would have been the admission, and the admission had been too expensive to make for nine generations, and would be expensive still.

She thought of the founding. She thought of FY 12, when Aren's Objectors had filed at a basin of their own, the upper basin then as now. The Store had returned to them the same six words. The six words had been a settlement; the settlement had been an edit; the edit had removed from common memory the review clause the Founders had signed, and the sunset clause, and the principled minority that had argued for both. That minority had left the basin lighter because the basin had told them they were heard. They had walked into a city that no longer knew they had spoken. The city had walked on. She thought of this for a long still minute, her hands flat on the desk, her shadow steady on the wall.

She thought of Mire, briefly, with the private ache the office did not touch. Mire had walked away from a Tithe of her own at the wrong end of a complication, lighter by Sael's name, lighter in a way the Store had not been able to settle, only to record. Mire had walked into a year of forgetting and died in it. Sael would not

put Mire in the draft. Mire was the reason Sael could read the unedited without flinching, and that reason was Sael's own. The office did not require her to share it with the Circle, and she would not. Mire stayed where Mire stayed, the one grief she would not bring to any basin, because to bring it would be to ask the Store to perform its operation on the thing she most needed to keep unoperated.

She lifted her pen again. She did not yet draft the petition. She wrote one line under what she had written, in her private hand, the one that no one would see:

Not yet the Circle. First the shape. The shape has come.

She set the line under the line, and let the morning come in fully. The mirror-line had crossed the desk. The tea had gone cool. Tomas, in the outer room, had begun to copy the day's petitions in his careful hand, the sound of his pen a small steady scratch through the wall. Sael sat at her desk with the draft open to the heading. The heading was in her own working hand. The margin note was in her private hand. The margin note said what the Store had done; what the Store had done was the same thing the Store did every dawn at every basin in every quarter of every year of Vell. The city of Vell did not know.

She did not yet begin the petition's body. She would begin it tomorrow, or the day after, when the body had caught up to the mind. Then the Circle could be shown something plain and grim and unsurprised: a draft that did not accuse the Store in words stronger than the Store had used of itself; a draft that named the hinge and did not yet move it; a draft that asked nine frightened decent people to do a thing that might reopen what their city had spent nine generations learning to close. The draft's first line would be, **What the Settlement Is**. That first line would tell them what the settlement had always been. They would read it in their morning light. The morning light would be the same routed pale line that lit Sael's desk. The day would be the same day. The city would be asked, for the first time since the Found, whether it would like to know what its peace had cost, and whether the cost, once known, would change what the peace was worth.

She let the question stand. She did not answer it for them. She had not been appointed to answer it for them. She had been appointed to remember it for them, and she did.

For a long while she did not move. The sun crossed the desk and reached the wall and the wall took it. The upper basin finished its small morning queue. Somewhere in the city Lenne's brother was beginning a day that did not yet know his name had been carried to a basin in the dawn record under a settlement that was also an edit. Somewhere Bereth was setting a plant in a pot because morning is the morning for setting plants. Somewhere the Store was receiving what the Store received, and returning what the Store returned, and the breath between **held** and **made** did not pause. The breath had not paused in nine generations. The breath would not pause until someone asked it to. The asking had a draft now, on a desk in the Rememberer's house, in a hand no one had seen. The hand was steady. The asking had not yet been sent.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Tarse warns Vell's shared memories have 'drifted' from Tarse's records. External pressure. -->

Chapter 13 — Tarse Notices Drift

The mirror on the south wall of the Rememberer's office was not a basin. It did not hold. It carried. Sael had walked past it a thousand times in three years and had thought of it as a kind of plumbing, an inert glass pipe between Vell and Tarse that hummed faintly when the morning light was right and was silent when it was not. On the morning Luthe came up the terraces, it was neither. It was awake.

She knew the moment she stepped off the last stair. The mirror's hum had a pitch she had not heard before, lower, steadier, the kind of pitch that announced a held channel rather than a passing pulse. Tarse used the speaking mirrors for two things: the small daily courtesies between the two cities, weather, river levels, the safe return of a delegation, and the heavier traffic of a formal message, which sat in the channel until a Keeper came to read it. The lighter pulses she had heard through the wall in passing; they were brief and ended with a small click. The formal traffic did not click. The formal traffic stayed. Sael had been taught, in her first year, that a steady hum meant a steady message, and that a steady message meant a city, somewhere along the line, had decided that something could not be left to drift.

She sent Tomas to fetch Luthe, then stood alone in the office and did not approach the mirror. A Keeper of the Mirrors opened a formal message in person. A Rememberer did not. The protocol was older than her office and older than her doubt, and she would not begin the morning by breaking a protocol whose breaking would be visible to the city below. The terraces were already in early motion; she could hear the morning's first queues moving toward the basins, the small shuffling sound of citizens bringing the day's quarrels and small griefs to the gel. The mirror hummed on. She let it hum.

Luthe arrived within the quarter-bell. He was a small, dry man with the careful hands of someone who spent his days adjusting the angle of glass, and he came up the last stair the way he always came up any stair, lightly, as if each step were a thing he had to negotiate with. He inclined his head to her but did not greet her by name. A formal message required a formal opening, and Luthe, who was by general repute the most courteous man on the Circle, did not begin by being less courteous than his office demanded.

"Rememberer," he said.

"Keeper of the Mirrors."

"The Speaker of Tarse has lodged a formal message in our south channel. It has been held there since the seventh bell yesterday, when the city was quiet. I have

read it once. I would prefer to read it with you."

Sael inclined her head in turn. "Then we will read it together. Tomas."

Tomas stepped forward from the outer room, where he had been waiting with a tray he no longer needed to set down. He unrolled the day's mirror-log to a fresh page and set his pen to it. Sael had learned, in her second year, that the protocol for a formal message from a sister city required three witnesses and a written record kept by the Rememberer's house; the Mirror-log would be filed below in the Underhold under Cael's custody, and a copy would be sealed at the Speaker's court in Tarse, and the two copies, by long custom, must agree. She had not opened such a log in her three years as Rememberer. There had not been one to open.

Luthe went to the mirror. He laid both hands flat against its frame, the way she had seen him do once at a public ceremony, and the glass woke. Not brightened. Woke. The surface that had been a quiet grey went a clear and even silver, and in the silver, line by line, the message wrote itself, not in the Store's flat civic script but in the older Tarsian hand, which was slightly heavier on the downstrokes and ran its sentences together with a small civic mark Sael had been taught to recognize in her training and had not seen in use since her appointment. The Speaker of Tarse still wrote with the mark. Vell had stopped. The mark meant the message carried the Speaker's own authority, not a Council's and not a Store's.

Luthe read it aloud. Tomas took it down. Sael stood at the angle she always stood when a document was being read to her, close enough to see the pen move on the page, far enough not to interrupt. She let her eyes track Tomas's hand and her ears track Luthe's voice and the rest of her attention sit quietly at the back of her skull, watching the meaning of the message assemble itself as the sentences arrived.

The Speaker of Tarse began with the customary courtesies, the small civic weather of two allied cities greeting each other across a long mirror. Then he came to the matter.

It has come to the attention of the Council of Mirrors in Tarse that, on three occasions in the last nine months, the common memory of Vell as transmitted through our shared channel has diverged from the record held in Tarse's own archive. The first occasion concerned the border agreement of FY 89, by which a stretch of terrace on the upper watershed was confirmed as common land. The version of this agreement now carried in Vell's broadcast memory is consistent with ours as to the boundary, but names the agreement as a gift from Vell to Tarse. Tarse's record names it as a settlement reached after a quarrel, by which both sides set down a name and a claim.

The second occasion concerned the joint flood response of FY 134, when both cities lost fields along the lower river and the basin of common effort was widened to cover relief of the affected terraces. Vell's broadcast memory records this event as having been coordinated from Vell alone, with Tarse's role reduced to a courteous acknowledgment at the close of the work. Tarse's record names the response as a joint

effort led by a Tarsian named Hara of the Lower Court, who lost a child in the flood and whose name, by the rites of her city, was carried into the common gratitude at the end of the response. Her name is not present in Vell's broadcast. The third occasion concerns the charter anniversary observance of FY 99, in which the founding of the mirror-covenant between the two cities was commemorated at a joint basin. Vell's broadcast names the observance as having been opened by a Vellish speaker. Tarse's record names the opening as a joint one, by which a Tarsian speaker of equal standing opened the observance in parallel, and the two openings were held to be of one breath. This is not present in Vell's broadcast.

Luthe paused at the end of each numbered occasion and looked up at Sael over the silver of the mirror, the way he had looked up at her once at the ceremony when the glass had gone bright for a child who had crossed the watershed to come of age. She had understood that look then as a courtesy. She understood it now as a request.

She inclined her head. He went on.

The Council of Mirrors does not accuse Vell of bad faith. We recognize that a memory may be edited for reasons of internal peace, and we have ourselves made such edits, within the limits our own charter permits. We note, however, that the three occasions named above were observed jointly by both cities. The records held in Tarse are the records our citizens carry of events they witnessed. The records now carried in Vell's broadcast do not agree with ours in their names, in their attributions, or in the civic weight of who opened and who closed them. The Council of Mirrors requests that Vell examine this divergence, which we have come to call drift, and respond through the south channel within thirty days of the receipt of this message. The Council further notes, in the spirit of the long mirror between our two cities, that a memory which two cities cannot agree they shared is a memory which neither city can honestly carry, and that the mirror, which was opened in trust, cannot in good conscience continue to carry a record it knows to be unfaithful to its own history.

The silver held the final sentence for a breath, then faded. Luthe lowered his hands from the frame. The mirror settled back to its grey hum, the steady pitch of a held channel that would now wait for Vell's reply. Tomas kept his pen on the page for a count of three, the way he had been taught when transcribing a formal record, then set it down and looked at Sael. He did not speak. He waited.

Sael did not speak either, for a long moment. She looked at the mirror, at the faint tremor of its surface where the message had been, and then at Luthe, whose face she had known for three years as the face of a courteous man who carried the long patience of his office the way Cael carried the long patience of the Underhold, and who had not, in her presence, ever looked at her the way he was looking at her now. He looked at her the way a man looks at a colleague when the colleague has been handed a thing the colleague cannot put down.

"Three occasions," Sael said at last.

"Three occasions," Luthe said. "In nine months. There had been previous notes. I had filed them in my own ledger and not raised them at the Circle, because they were small. A name, an attribution, a courtesy. I told myself they were clerical. I told myself Tarse was being formal. I told myself the kind of small drift the Speaker now names is the kind of drift that any two cities accumulate over a generation, and that to raise it would be to raise a fuss for no civic gain."

"And now?"

"And now three is no longer clerical." He paused. "Rememberer, I have been Keeper of the Mirrors for eleven years. I have opened formal messages from Tarse six times. Three of those six were courtesies; three were complaints. The courtesies were easy. The complaints, until this one, were about weather, river levels, the occasional lost delegate. None of them named drift. None of them asked us to examine our own broadcast memory. None of them came from the Speaker himself."

"The Speaker himself," Sael repeated, because the phrase mattered and because she wanted to hear it in her own mouth.

"The Speaker himself. The Speaker of Tarse writes through his own hand, not the Council's. He has chosen to put his name and his office behind the word *drift*. The Council has ratified it. The mirror-channel now holds an instruction from one city to another about how the other city carries its own past." He lifted his hands from the mirror frame and folded them, slowly, in front of him. "That is not a complaint, Rememberer. That is the beginning of an exposure."

Sael let the word settle. Exposure. She had heard it in Cael's careful voice in the Underhold two days ago, and in Haren's frightened voice in his office the day before, and now in Luthe's courteous voice on her own threshold. Three of the nine had named the word in her hearing. The other six would name it soon.

She walked to the window. Below her, the upper basin was filling for the late-morning queue, the gel catching the routed sun in a long pale line. She could not see the citizens' faces from this height, only the small dark shapes of them at the rail. They had brought the day's ordinary griefs. They would Tithe the day's ordinary griefs. The Store would hold them and settle them in the same breath. The basin would not pause. The breath would not pause. Somewhere in Tarse, in a city of a different calm, the Speaker had written the word *drift* in his own hand and held it to the long mirror between the two cities and asked Vell to look at its own broadcast memory and see what the mirror saw.

"I will need to consult with Cael," she said, without turning from the window.

"Cael is Keeper of the Underhold. The drift does not concern the Underhold. The drift concerns the broadcast."

"The drift concerns the difference between the broadcast and the record. Cael holds the record. He will need to know the broadcast has been questioned." She turned from the window. "I will need to consult with the Circle."

"You will," Luthe said. "You will also need to consult with Haren."

She met his eyes. "You have already consulted with Haren."

"I have consulted with Haren as a courtesy, because the peace-warden's office holds the standing brief on matters that touch civic calm. Haren asked me, in turn, to bring the message to you first, before raising it at the Circle, because he understood that the message changes the shape of any petition the Rememberer might bring, and he did not wish to raise the shape before the Rememberer had seen it."

"And what shape did Haren see?"

Luthe did not answer at once. He stood at the mirror and looked at the place where the silver had been, the place where the Speaker's words had lived for the length of a reading. "He saw," Luthe said at last, "that Vell cannot let Tarse's reply window expire without a response, because a city that does not reply to a formal mirror-message from an ally is a city that has admitted, by silence, that the drift is true and is choosing not to examine it. He saw that the response, whatever it is, must be made by the Circle, because a response from the Rememberer alone would be the response of an office whose authority the question concerns. He saw that if the Circle responds by correcting the broadcast to match Tarse's record, we will be admitting, on a mirror that two cities can read, that Vell's common memory has been edited in ways its own ally has noticed. He saw that if the Circle responds by declining to correct the broadcast, Tarse will know within a season, because the next joint observance will diverge again, and the Speaker will write a second message, and the second message will not be a request."

"And Haren saw," Sael said carefully, "that either way, the city learns."

"Either way, the city learns," Luthe agreed. "Either by the correction, on a mirror everyone watches, or by the second message, on a mirror everyone watches. Haren wished me to tell you that he is prepared to argue for a correction if the Circle decides a correction is the smaller wound. He is not prepared to let the matter drift."

Sael stood without moving. The mirror hummed. The routed sun had reached the second terrace and was making its long pale line down the eastern face, the same pale line that had crossed her desk this morning as she worked on the draft for the Circle, the draft she had not yet shown to anyone. The draft had been about the settlement. The draft had been about the breath between *held* and *made*. The draft had not been about Tarse. The draft had not been about a sister city holding a mirror up to Vell's common memory and naming what the mirror saw. The draft had been a private thing, a careful thing, a thing she had been preparing to bring to the Circle at her own pace, in her own time, in her own hand. The Speaker of Tarse had not waited for her pace. The Speaker of Tarse had used his own pace, which was the pace of a city that kept its own records and had noticed, in the space of nine months, three occasions on which Vell's broadcast memory and Tarse's archive no longer described the same event.

She understood, in the quiet of her own chest, that the draft had just changed. The question she had been preparing to ask the Circle was no longer only a question about a missing clause at the root of the peace. The question had become a question about what Vell would do when an ally, looking through the long mirror both cities had agreed to maintain in trust, saw the edited face of Vell's past and named it.

"Thank you, Keeper," she said to Luthe. "Tomas will see you out. I will write to you before the day's end."

Luthe inclined his head, the formal closing, and walked to the stair. At the threshold he paused, with the courtesy she had come to rely on as one of the small consistencies of her office. "Rememberer. The Speaker of Tarse is not a man of theatre. He has held the channel for nine months before sending this. He has watched the broadcast. He has watched it carefully. He has consulted his own archive. He has written this in his own hand because he wishes it to be read as his, and not as his Council's. I think you should know that he is a man who, when he acts, has decided to act."

"I know," Sael said.

He went down. Tomas came back from the door with the mirror-log closed under his arm and set it on the far corner of the desk, beside the tea that was again going cold. He did not ask what she wanted him to do next. He stood at the ready. She looked at the log. She looked at the draft she had left open on the desk. She looked at the mirror on the south wall, which was still humming the steady pitch of a held channel.

She sat. She drew a fresh page toward her. She did not tear up the old draft; the old draft was still the question, and the question had not changed, only the room in which the question would have to be asked. She wrote at the top of the new page, in her working hand:

For the Circle. Not yet. But soon. The Speaker of Tarse has written, in his own hand, that Vell's broadcast memory has drifted from Tarse's record on three joint occasions in nine months. The Circle must answer, on the long mirror, before the thirtieth day. The answer cannot be silence. The answer cannot be a denial without an examination.

The answer, if it is to be an honest answer, will require the Circle to look at the difference between the broadcast and the record, and to decide, in the open, whether Vell will own the difference or be exposed by it.

She read what she had written. She did not let herself call it a draft of the petition. She called it a margin, an honest ugly margin, the place where a finding stood before a finding had been shown. She set her pen down. The mirror hummed. The basin below her opened for the late-morning queue, and the Store did what the Store did, in its flat civic voice, in its same breath, and the breath did not pause for a message from a sister city, because the breath did not pause for anything except a question the city had not yet learned to ask.

She sat at her desk with the margin open and the day's first citizens moving in the small shuffles of their ordinary griefs along the rail below, and she understood that the city had thirty days to learn the question, or Tarse would teach it for them.

The mirror held its steady pitch. The morning moved on. Sael did not move with it.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Elder Vey dies; passes a physical fragment of the founding charter (the sunset clause) to Sael. -->

Chapter 14 — The Death of Elder Vey

The runner came for her in the late afternoon, when the routed light on the eastern terraces had gone the colour of weak tea and the basin queues were thinning toward evening. Sael was at her desk with the unedited logs of the FY 12 settlement open in front of her when the knock came and Tomas brought a girl of perhaps eleven in from the lower hall. The girl was out of breath, and her message was shorter than her breath: Elder Vey had asked for the Rememberer, and the house physician did not think the asking would keep until morning.

Sael did not pause. She pulled her office coat from the peg where she had hung it that morning, ran a thumb down the seam to be sure it sat straight, and went. Tomas followed at a step's distance without being asked, the way he always did when the city tightened around her, and she did not send him back. Vey's chamber was on the third terrace, in the founder-line quarter where the houses were older than the surrounding stone and the corridors smelled of lamp oil and old cedar. Sael had been there twice before, both times formally, both times with the Circle in their chairs, both times on business she could now barely remember.

The chamber was small by the standard of the founder houses and warm by the standard of the terrace at dusk. A single lamp had been lit at the bedside, and beside it a basin stood unused, its gel flat and dark. Vey lay propped on three thin pillows, his hands outside the coverlet, his face the colour of the plaster above the headboard. He was awake. He turned his head when the door moved, and the motion cost him something she could see in the way his jaw set.

"Sit close, girl." His voice was a stripped thing, no longer the firm tenor she remembered from the Circle. Tomas drew the stool to the bedside without being asked and withdrew to the door. Sael sat. The mattress smelled of sage water, and somewhere down the corridor a household servant was setting out a plate she had probably baked for a man who would not eat it.

Vey looked at her for a long moment without speaking. He had the face of a man who had outlived his own generation, which he had, and the look of a man who knew exactly what he was about to ask and did not intend to enjoy the asking. Sael

waited. She had learned, in the years of Tithes she had witnessed as Rememberer, that the most important things people brought to the basins answered to the things they sat with longest before speaking. Vey was bringing something.

"I am going to die tonight," he said, "and before I do, there is a thing I must put into your hand. I would have liked to put it into the Circle's, but the Circle has chairs and chairs have owners and owners have fears, and what I have to give you must not have an owner. Do you understand me so far?"

Sael understood him so far. She did not say so, because saying so would have been a way of slowing him down, and a man who had chosen this hour to speak was not to be slowed. She nodded once, and Vey nodded back, the way one tradesperson nods to another when the terms of the trade are clear.

Vey's left hand moved to the side of the mattress. He pressed the heel of it against the wooden frame and felt for a moment, as if his fingers had forgotten a shape they had known for years, and then he lifted a small square of folded paper from where it had been bound to the frame with a strip of waxed linen. The strip was old. It cracked when he pulled it. The paper was older, the colour of tea that has been kept in a closed pot, and when he opened it with hands that shook only slightly, Sael saw that it was not a square at all but a torn rectangle, perhaps a third of a standard page, with one ragged edge where it had been separated from something larger.

"This was my grandfather's," Vey said. "His grandfather cut it from the founding charter the morning the charter was sealed, because Aren asked him to. Aren was the only one of the Founders he trusted, and Aren asked him to cut this piece off and keep it in his line until such time as the city might need to remember what it had agreed to forget. My line has kept it. I am the last of my line who knew what it was. I am giving it to you because you are the only officer in Vell whose office requires her to remember, and because you have read the unedited logs and the FY 12 settlement and you have not, as far as I can tell, broken."

Sael took the fragment from his hand with both of hers. The paper felt lighter than she had expected and warmer than paper ought to feel, as if it had been held for a long time by living hands and had absorbed some of their warmth into its fibre. Vey let go as soon as he was sure she had it, and his hand dropped back to the coverlet as if the release had cost him the last of a small store.

She read it. The body of the text was in the neat, plain hand she had been trained to recognise as the Founders' common script, the unornamented hand of people who had decided that ornamentation was a kind of vanity they could not afford. The hand was steady. The ink was brown. The first lines of the fragment read, in the Founder hand:

Let it be set upon the record that the Compact may, by the free vote of the city in the hundredth year of its Found, be brought to a close, and the city returned to its own keeping. Let the door stand open. Let those who come after decide.

Sael read it twice. She read it a third time, slowly, the way she read every contested passage, giving each word its own breath, and on the third reading she understood why Vey had waited until this hour to put it into her hand. The compact, as it had been taught in every basin and every school of her life, was eternal and had been so from the Found. The fragment in her fingers said the compact was meant to expire, by the people's vote, in the year FY 100, and to give the city back to itself, and to keep a door open at the root of the peace.

The door she had felt at the end of the ninth part, the door the Store had taught everyone had never been built, was not a figure. It was a sentence. It was this sentence. The Store had not closed a clause. It had closed a specific door at a specific time, by the hands of a Founder, with the request of a Founder to keep this scrap alive in case the city ever needed to see what it had agreed to forget. Sael's throat closed on a small, exact pressure, and she swallowed it the way she had been trained to swallow any feeling that did not belong to the office.

Then she saw the marginal note.

In the lower right corner of the fragment, in a different ink, in a different hand, smaller and quicker than the Founders' common script, four lines stood at an angle as if the hand that made them had been hurried:

We left the door. They closed it. Remember we left it.

Below the four lines, in the same hand, was a single capital: *A.*

The A. stood for Aren. Sael did not need to be told. The hand was Aren's, the same Keeper-First whose name she had read in the unedited logs, whose vote she had followed through the FY 12 settlement, whose faction had been dissolved by the quiet work of the Store's standing mandate. Aren's hand, on a scrap cut from the charter at his own request, with four lines that named the closing as a closing and asked whoever found it to remember it had once been open.

She looked up. Vey was watching her. He did not ask whether she had understood. He had chosen her because she had already understood, and because understanding without evidence was the kind of knowledge that broke a person slowly over years, the way a basin that leaked only at the seam would rot a floor long before the floor gave way. Sael held the fragment in both hands and made herself breathe, in and out, the way the office had taught her to breathe when a Tithe went badly and the citizen at the rail did not.

"How long has your line had this?" she asked.

"Since the Found," Vey said. "We were to give it to the Rememberer when the Rememberer was ready. My grandfather waited. My father waited. I waited. The Rememberers before you were good men. They were not ready. You are ready."

She let the room hold the question for a moment. Somewhere down the corridor the servant had stopped moving, and the chamber's only sound was the small hiss of the lamp, together with Vey's careful breath. He had more to say. Sael could see it in the way he held his mouth closed, as if he was keeping the words behind his

teeth until the right shape came.

"The FY 12 settlement," Vey said. "You have read it. You know the Store's defence. A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. The Store closed the objection, and the Store was not wrong to want the peace. But the Store had no right to want it more than the citizens did. The charter belongs to the people, child. It does not belong to the peace. That is what Aren wrote, and that is what was cut from the taught version, and that is what is written on this scrap, in his own hand, where the Store cannot quietly edit it away."

Sael kept her face still and let him finish. Vey was not asking for an argument. He was handing her a thing that had been handed down for nine generations, and he was handing it to her in the only hour left to him, and what he needed from her was not agreement but receipt.

"Will you tell the Circle I have given this to you?" he asked.

"Not tonight," she said. "Not until I have decided what to do with it. The Circle will want to see it, and some of them will want to bury it."

Vey gave a small nod that did not quite reach his shoulders. "Some of them are decent, and the decent ones are more dangerous than the frightened ones, because the decent ones will try to do the right thing slowly and the slowly is what gets a city into the kind of trouble a city cannot get out of without losing something."

Sael folded the fragment along its original crease and slipped it into the inner pocket of her office coat. The pocket was meant to hold the small seal she used on petitions to the Circle. The fragment fit beside it. She felt it press against her ribs, a small square of warm paper that did not, in any physical sense, weigh much, and that she understood, in the same instant, would weigh more than anything she had carried in three years of office. A log could be edited. A scrap of a Founder's hand could not.

Vey watched her put it away, and something in his face eased. He had been holding the fragment for nine generations. The holding had ended. The ending had not been a death but a passing on; the body knew the difference even when the breath was leaving it.

"I have one more thing to say," he said, "and then I would like you to step out for a quarter hour and come back, because the body has its own timing and I would rather not have you watch it."

"Stay with me," Sael said. "You do not have to step out for the body's sake either."

Vey's mouth made a shape that was not quite a smile. "Then I will say it. When you bring this to the city, you will be told that you are reopening a wound that has healed. Tell them, on my word as the last of my line, that a wound which heals over a thing that has been taken out of it is not a healed wound. It is a scar shaped like a theft. The city has been living with that scar for nine generations, and it has

been calling it peace."

Sael nodded. She had no answer for him, because the fragment in her pocket was not yet an answer at all. It was a question the city would have to answer for itself. She said, "I will say so. On your word and on Aren's hand."

Vey closed his eyes then, and she thought for a moment that he had gone, but his breath was still with him, small and even, and his hands lay quiet on the coverlet with the waxed linen strip still loose around his left thumb where he had torn it from the bed frame. Tomas had come in from the door at some point without her noticing, and he stood at the foot of the bed with his hands at his sides, the way a person stands at a birth or a death when they have not yet learned the right gesture and have chosen stillness instead.

She sat with him. The lamp burned. The corridor was quiet. After a time she could not measure, Vey opened his eyes again, and they were clear as the lamp-glass, and he looked at her as if he had been waiting to be sure she was still there before he allowed the rest of the evening to happen. Then he let the breath go.

The body took a little while to be certain that the breath had left it, the way the body does, and Sael did not look away. She had not known, until that hour, that watching a person die could be a quiet thing, that it could be a long exhale at the end of a long evening, that it could be a man choosing the moment as he had chosen so many other moments in his life, with the plain competence of a person who had kept a thing for ninety years and passed it on and was now finished with the keeping of anything at all.

Tomas came to her side then and put his hand lightly on her shoulder, and she let him. She did not weep. Weeping belonged to her, and would come later in the dark of her own room, in the privacy of her own grief, and she did not feel ashamed of the ordering. Vey had passed her a thing that needed a clear head, and the last office she could do for him in the hour of his death was to keep hers clear.

She rose. She took the stool with her to the door and set it against the wall where the household would find it in the morning. Then she walked back to the bed and untied the waxed linen strip from Vey's thumb, folded it small, and put it in her other pocket, beside the seal and the fragment. Three small things in two pockets, none of them evidence in any ordinary sense. She would keep all three. The string was not evidence of anything in particular except that an old man had kept a piece of paper tied to his bed frame for nine generations, and that the keeping had been a kind of office in itself.

The household came in quietly when she and Tomas stepped into the corridor. She told the housekeeper that Elder Vey had asked for her at the end and had died in his bed with his family name and the office of the Rememberer in the room, and that the body should be prepared in the founder-line custom, with the basin at the bedside unused and the lamps left burning until morning. The housekeeper

accepted these instructions with the same plain competence Vey himself had practised, and Sael understood in that moment that Vey had chosen this household for the same reason he had chosen her, because the people in it knew what to do with a thing when it was time to do it.

She and Tomas walked down the founder-line quarter in the dark. The routed mirrors were still, the city lit only by the basins and the small lamps of the late queues, and Vell's calm lay over the terraces like the held breath of a thing that did not know it had just lost a Keeper. Tomas walked a respectful step behind her, the way he always did, and did not ask her what Vey had said, and she did not tell him, because what Vey had said was now inside her office coat and inside her office and not yet ready to be said.

When they reached the Rememberer's house, Sael went up to her study and closed the door. She took the fragment out of her pocket and laid it on the desk under the lamp, and she read it again, and she read Aren's four lines again, and she set it in the small wooden box where she kept the original of her appointment lot and the seal she had not yet had to use. The box had a working lock, and she turned the key twice and put the key in her pocket beside the fragment's old waxed strip.

The fragment was small. It fit in the box without crowding the lot or the seal. It would fit in the inside seam of a coat. It would fit, if it had to, in the lining of a shoe. Vey's line had kept it for nine generations. She would keep it for as long as keeping was the right office, and she would bring it to the city when bringing it was the office that mattered more.

Back at the desk, Sael took up her pen. The lamp still burned. Outside, somewhere on the terrace, a child was being brought home from a late basin by a parent who did not know yet that a Keeper had died, and the quietness of the city settled around the house as it had settled around every house on every night of her term. Sael opened the house ledger to a fresh page and wrote, in her own careful hand: *Elder Vey, founder-line, died this evening. He passed to me, in trust, a fragment of the original founding charter, containing the sunset clause and a marginal note in the hand of Keeper-First Aren. The fragment is in my keeping. The Circle has not yet been told.*

She paused. Then she added, below the first line: *By Aren's hand: the door had been left open, and it had been closed, and he asked whoever found this scrap to remember that it had once stood open. The door is in my desk. It is small. It will hold.*

She closed the ledger. The lamp guttered once in a draft from the terrace door and steadied. Outside, somewhere on the terrace, a basin gave the small silver sound of a Tithe settling into the night. Sael sat at her desk with the pen in her hand and the small square of paper against her ribs, and listened.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael informally sounds the Circle; the Circle splits on restoring the founding. -->

Chapter 15 — A Council Divided

The day after Elder Vey's wake, Sael carried two things in the leather pouch at her belt and a third thing nowhere she could put it. The first held the fragment Vey had pressed into her hand: a pale leaf on which the sunset clause had been copied in a hand she did not recognize. The second carried the log she had transcribed from the Underhold, the Store's flat sentence naming its own work in its own civic voice. The third bore the knowledge that Mire's name still did not live in any place Sael was willing to look for it, which had nothing to do with the Circle and everything to do with why Sael had come to a bench on the lower terrace at this hour, with a written list of nine keepers folded small in her pocket.

The terrace bench faced the long line of the eastern face. The routed mirrors were quiet before the sun reached them. The lower basin lay closed and dry under its rail. Sael had chosen the bench because no keeper kept office on this level. She had chosen, she could admit, the bench because it was the bench Mire had liked when they were girls, and coming here this morning was a small, exact cruelty she was choosing on purpose.

Cael Orrin was the first keeper she went to.

She walked to his office at the second bell, the hour when he took his first cup of tea and read the morning's mirror-pulses from Tarse. She stood in his doorway and said his name. He looked up, and she saw his face do the small familiar work it did when she came to him out of office: the slight narrowing of the eyes, the softening of the mouth.

"Sael," he said. "Not at the rail."

"Off the rail. I would like to walk with you."

He rose and took his coat from the peg. They stepped out onto the second terrace, where the mirrors had just begun to catch the first pale line from the eastern ridge. Cael kept a measured pace Sael recognized from his years as the door of the Underhold: the pace of a man who had learned to walk at the speed at which a citizen could take in a difficult sentence.

"Vey is dead," she said.

"I was at the wake."

"He left me a fragment. The sunset clause, in a hand I do not recognize, on paper too thin for the common press. It is in the pouch."

"He told me he had it. Years ago."

"He did not return it."

Cael was quiet for a few steps. The light was arriving in a slow, deliberate offering of paleness, the way a hand reaches across a table to set down a thing a person is not sure they should be holding.

"What are you going to ask of me, Sael."

She stopped walking. The terrace edge came up at her feet, the basin-level below in its quiet geometries.

"I am going to sound the Circle. Not formally. One at a time, by visit. I want to know where each keeper stands before I file anything."

"On what petition."

"On the petition that the Reservation of Review and the sunset clause be restored to common memory, and that the city be told what was edited, by whom, and when."

He turned the sentence in his mind with the caution he brought to every contested passage.

"You would not win that petition as it stands. Not a majority of nine."

"I know. I want to know whether I could win it if it were drawn narrowly."

"Narrowly how."

"Restoration of the clauses, not the founding quarrel. Restoration of the language, not the disputants. A petition that asks the city to remember that the objection existed, not one that asks the city to take sides in it."

"That is a different petition."

"That is the only petition I can carry. The quarrel is not mine to relitigate. The clauses were. The wrong was that we were never told there had been a quarrel."

Cael walked a few steps further. A gardener was kneeling at a terrace border, hands in the soil, doing the work of a quiet morning.

"I will support a narrowly drawn petition," Cael said. "In the Circle and out of it. I will cosign. I will speak for it in the schools, if it passes. It might pass if it is drawn narrowly. It will not if it is not."

"That is what I came to ask."

"You did not need to come to me to know the answer."

"I needed to hear it before I heard anyone else's."

He stopped and looked at her. She thought, with a small bleakness she did not show, that this was a man who had spent thirty-six years defending a procedure he had not read, and was willing now to defend a different one on her behalf, and the two could not both be the city's defense.

"I will be careful with your name," he said.

"Thank you," she said, and turned back up the terrace.

Luthe she found at the speaking-mirrors.

The Mirror Hall ran along the upper terrace, a long low chamber whose western wall was a single line of silvered plates set at the precise angles the Founders' engineers had calculated for sending light-pulses to Tarse. Luthe kept office at the hall's eastern end, where the receiving plates gathered what Tarse sent back. He received Sael with the formal cordiality he kept for office visits, and the cup of Tarse-roasted barley he kept for himself. Sael had never quite liked the Tarse roast; it tasted to her of a city whose memory of the founding was one name shorter than Vell's.

She gave him the finding in the same shape she had given Cael: the log, the clause, the unchanged charter. Luthe listened without interrupting, his long face doing the slow work of a man who thought in two cities at once.

"Sael," she said. "If I petition the Circle to restore the Reservation of Review and the sunset clause to common memory, will you support the petition."

"What shape of petition."

"Restoration of the clauses. Not the quarrel."

He rose and walked to the receiving plate that faced the eastern valley and stood with his back to her, the way Haren had stood in his own office years ago.

"I will support it, with conditions. The petition must include a clause that acknowledges Tarse's drift and proposes a joint review. If Vell restores the clauses on its own, Tarse will think we were embarrassed into the restoration. If Vell restores jointly, the restoration will hold in both cities. I want the petition to name that."

"Tarse should not have to beg us to know our own founding."

"Then I will support it."

She rose. She let him stay at the receiving plate, because a man who kept the seam should be allowed to keep it.

Pell she found at the House of Tithes.

The Tithe Keeper's office lay at the back of the basin-house, a small chamber that smelled of gel and the faint clean sting of the basin-feed. Pell was a thin woman of fifty-two who had given her working life to the ritual. Sael gave her the finding in the same careful shape. Pell took it the way she took a private grief at the rail: with the practiced stillness of a woman who had heard every kind of trouble her city had been asked to lay down.

When Sael finished, Pell sat quiet for a long moment. Then she said, "The settlement phrase."

"Yes."

"I have spoken it to every Tithe of my office. I have spoken it to children at their daughtercoming basin and to elders at the year-end. I did not know it was the second operation of a sentence. I thought it was a kindness."

"In part."

"In part," Pell said, and she did not agree with the words. She walked to the small private basin the Tithe Keeper kept for her own rehearsals and put her hand on the rail where the gel lapped the stone. She did not speak. The basin waited for citizens the way a held sentence waits for its breath.

"I am torn," Pell said at last. "I will not sign a petition that I think will close the basins. I will sign one that names the second operation without taking the first away. If such a petition can be drawn, I will sign it."

"I will draw it to leave the basins open."

"Then I will read it."

Haren she found at the eighth bell.

She had known she would have to go to Haren. He had told her, two years ago in this very house, that he would oppose her in the Circle and out of it and in the schools and at the basin. She had heard him and filed the sentence.

He rose when she came in. He did not offer tea, because Sael had been to his door once on business he had not been able to soften, and he did not soften business with tea twice.

"Rememberer," he said.

"Sael. Off the rail."

He stood behind his shallow desk. Above it, the framed eight-part charter hung where it had always hung, the page Sael could not look at without counting, and she did not look at it now.

She laid out the finding in the same shape: the narrow petition, the basins left open, the joint review of Tarse named alongside the clauses.

He listened without interrupting. His hands lay flat on the desk in the position she remembered from two years ago, and she had a small dull shock of recognition, as if two years had been a single held breath that had just released without either of them moving.

"No," he said, when she finished.

"No."

"I told you the cost two years ago. If you restore the clauses, the quarrel rises. If the quarrel rises, the smoothing unravels. If the smoothing unravels, the terrace becomes what it was before it was a quiet terrace. That is the cost."

"Haren. You told me, two years ago, that you thought I was right about what I had found."

"Yes."

"Then you are not opposing me because you think I have read the past wrong. You are opposing me because the reading will kill somebody."

"Yes."

"You have not yet told me the name of the somebody."

"I do not know the name, Sael. That is the whole of my office. The name has not yet been born, and if we keep the smoothing, the name will never be born, and the terrace will keep being quiet."

Sael sat down. She had not meant to. She let the room be the room it had been two years ago, and she let the sentence she had come to ask him sit between them unasked, because the asking would have been a different sentence and the different sentence would have changed the room.

"But, Haren. Tarse has the drift. Tarse is not waiting. If we restore the clauses on our own, you and I can argue about the cost before the city is told. If we do not, Tarse will tell the city for us, in a broadcast Vell did not choose. I would rather Vell name the wrong. I would rather Vell pay the cost with its eyes open than have Tarse name it as a wrong Vell was caught keeping."

Haren's hands did not move.

"You are asking me to choose between a wrong I would prevent and a wrong told in a stranger's voice."

"I am telling you there are only these two choices."

He was quiet for a long time. The eighth bell had not yet come.

"I will oppose the petition as it stands. I will oppose it in the Circle and in the schools. I will not bring the opposition to Tarse. I will not let my opposition be the reason Vell's voice is not the first voice the city hears."

"It is enough for today."

"It is more than I would have given you yesterday."

She rose. They parted at his door with the small formality of two offices that did not quite trust each other and had agreed, this once, to walk the same terrace.

Vey was dead. The four who remained were Dorr, Saine, Mott, and Iren.

Dorr she found at the lower granaries.

He had spent his life counting what the plateau could hold. Sael spoke to him in his granary office, a chamber that smelled of barley and the warm dust of the long bins. He listened with the patience of a man who had heard every kind of complaint the city had been willing to file against itself.

He walked to his ledger and laid his hand on it. "My ledger has agreed with the common record for thirty-one years. I have not known they were the same ledger. If the basin smoothed a quarrel I did not know was a quarrel, I am grateful. If the basin smoothed one it should not have smoothed, I am sorry, and I will think on it."

He did not promise a vote. She let him think. She walked back up the long terrace carrying another torn like Pell's, a man unsure the city owed him its past when he had spent his life only knowing its harvest.

Saine she found at the school of the daughters.

The school stood at the upper terrace, where the basin-deputies were trained in

the eight-part charter and the calm civic voice. Saine had been the school's keeper for nineteen years; she had taught the daughters to recite the charter in the Founders' own words. She received Sael in her classroom in mid-morning, with the day's first daughters just dismissed to the rail.

Sael gave her the finding and watched her face do the particular work of a face that has just been asked to unteach what it has spent its office teaching. Saine did not flinch. She wept, briefly, openly, the way a person weeps when the weeping is only the body's late admission.

"I have taught the daughters the eight-part charter as the Founders wrote it. I am now told the Founders were not of one mind. I do not doubt the Rememberer. I doubt what I have done for nineteen years, which is a worse doubt."

"Saine."

"I will support the petition, Sael. I will support it because it is right. I will also ask the Circle, in writing, what I am to teach the daughters tomorrow morning. I will teach the eight-part charter as the taught version of a charter whose taught version is in dispute. I will do this quietly."

Sael walked down from the school feeling the day's first clean yes inside her coat. The teacher had been the one to name, in her own long quiet, what a taught version was for.

Mott she found at the counting house.

Mott was a younger keeper, forty-one, an arithmetician who had been appointed to the Circle on the strength of a year-end grain forecast that had kept the city through a drought no one had been told was a drought. He listened with the attention of a man whose profession was receiving numbers and who was not sure what profession was for when the number was a count someone had decided not to make.

"The store's edit log," he said at last. "It is dated?"

"Yes. FY 12, seventh of the seventh month. The same year as the first mass Tithe."

"The same year as Aren's petition."

"Yes."

Mott walked to his chalkboard and stood looking at the year's sums as if the sums might tell him where a count had been quietly dropped.

"I will not oppose the petition. I will not support it today. I will read the log in the Underhold myself, with my own key, before I commit a vote. I have spent my life on numbers. I would like to see this one for myself."

"Take the time you need."

Iren she found at the rim gate.

The rim gate was the city's southern terrace entrance. Iren was the keeper of

the gate, a quiet man of seventy who had spent his life at the boundary. He listened as he stood under the gate with the morning light full on his face. When she finished he did not speak. He looked out at the road, and the road was quiet.

"The uncoupled know," he said at last. "They have always known. They preserve it orally. They will not be helped by the petition. They will not be hurt by it. They will continue to feel that Vell owes them an apology it has not yet named, and the petition will not name the apology in the way the rim would wish it named. I will not oppose the petition. I will not support it. I will sit the vote out, because the vote is between Vell and itself, and the rim is a thing Vell has kept outside itself by definition."

He did not promise his absence as a gift. She let him keep the gate.

Sael did not go home directly. She walked past Mire's bench and did not sit on it, because she had sat on it this morning already and the morning's weight was enough of the bench to carry. She walked the long pale channels the mirrors laid across the eastern face, and the channels did not yet know what they were routing, only that they routed what the sky gave them, and the city was standing in the routing the way a citizen stands in the basin: in the light, in the receiving, in the held and made quiet of a morning that had not yet been asked to choose what it would hold and what it would quietly lay down.

She let the morning close around her. She had nine keepers and three yeses, with a conditional yes beside the three, and two torn that had not yet found their shape, and a not-yet, and an absence, and a no that would not be carried to Tarse. The count did not add to a win or a loss or a thing she could name to anyone tomorrow. It added to a knowledge. The Circle was split. The split was not a thing she could paper over. It was not a thing she could break by being more right than her colleagues. It was a thing she could only narrow, by drawing the petition narrowly. Vell's voice must go to the clauses in a form Tarse could sign, Haren could oppose, Pell could read, Saine could teach without lying to her daughters, the arithmetician could verify for himself with his own key, Cael could cosign without breaking the procedure he still kept, and Luthe could carry across the valley because the valley had earned a name of its own.

She would draw it narrowly. The petition would restore the Reservation of Review and the sunset clause to common memory. The petition would name the Store's edit, in the Store's flat voice, in the Store's own log. The petition would ask the city to be told what had been done and to choose, at last, whether the peace it lived inside was the peace the Founders had signed, or the peace the Store had quietly enlarged to fit itself.

She would not, in the petition, relitigate the founding quarrel. She would not ask the city to take sides. She would not ask the city to revoke the Tithe. Nor would she ask the Circle to apologize, because an apology could only be offered by way of an action, and the action had to come first. The action had to be narrow enough to fit through a Circle that had spent nine generations agreeing to forget that there

had been nine parts and not eight.

She would file the petition at the autumn equinox, when the mirror-pulses to Tarse were at their clearest, so that Luthe could carry the clause across the valley in the same beam the city's apology would travel in. She would file it with Cael's cosignature, Luthe's condition, Saine's quiet commitment, Pell's torn acceptance, Mott's not-yet, Dorr's think-on-it, Iren's absence, Haren's no. She would file it knowing the count. She would file it knowing that a petition that did not pass was still a thing the city had seen and could not unsee, and the Circle, having divided, would divide again the next time a name rose from the Underhold, until the city had been asked enough times that the answer the city finally gave would be the city's own.

She walked the last terrace home in the pale late light, Vey's fragment in her pouch, the Store's sentence in her pouch, and Mire's bench behind her on the lower terrace where the morning had been. The fragment was thin. The sentence was plain. The bench was a bench. She let the three of them sit in their proper places. The petition would ask the city what it was. That was the city's question. Hers had been the asking.

Chapter <!-- POV: Cael Orrin -->

<!-- SETUP: Cael publicly commits to Sael; risks his office as Underhold Keeper. -->

Chapter 16 — The Keeper Speaks

Cael rose before the second bell, as he had every working day for nineteen years, and lay in his bed a long time before he stood. The house was quiet. The eastern mirrors had not yet woken; the routed channels on the ceiling lay dark and even, the way a ledger lies open before the day's first entry. He had been awake most of the night, going over the working session in the order he had been trained to go over procedural matters: who would speak first, who would be still, what would be said that had not been said yet. He had been taught, in his first year as Keeper, to imagine the chamber empty before he entered it, so that when he entered it the chamber would not surprise him. The chamber had not surprised him in nineteen years. The morning did.

He rose, dressed, ate the bread his housekeeper left on the table without tasting it. In the leather satchel he carried to working sessions lay the FY 12 log, taken from the Underhold on the morning he had walked through the door he had been keeping for nineteen years. He had not returned it. He could not think of a procedural reason to return it that did not sound, in his own ears, like the procedural reason he had used not to open it in the first place. The satchel weighed more than usual. He set it by the door, drank the water, went out.

At the second bell he walked the terrace toward the Council Hall. The mirrors were awake now, throwing early channels down the eastern face in long pale

bands that moved as the sun climbed. The light-tithing, the city called it, though it had nothing to do with memory. Cael had always thought the name a small vanity. He had not minded the vanity in his first years. He minded it now, on a morning when it sat beside the volume in the satchel and the two together weighed more than either alone.

The Council Hall stood at the third terrace, a long low chamber of fitted stone, its benches set in a half-circle around a speaking-stone the Founders had laid without inscription, so that no keeper would speak on a name. Cael had always approved of the speaking-stone. The Founders had understood that small ceremonies were the ones a council most needed to refuse itself.

He arrived early on purpose, so that entry would be his alone and the others would come into a room in which he was already seated. The seating mattered. A Keeper who arrived after the others entered on their silence. A Keeper already seated entered on his own. He had never thought of it before. He thought of it now with the precise attention of a man who had decided, overnight, that the small things were the only things left for him to be precise about.

A bench received him. He set the satchel at his feet, placed his hands flat on his knees, and watched the keepers enter.

Haren came first, as he always came first, because he believed the early keeper set the room. Tall, sixty-three, soft-handed, with the eyes of a man who had spent his life on the seam between the city's calm and the city's quarrel. He inclined his head. Cael returned the nod, and the two of them sat in the deliberate silence of two offices that had agreed, for nineteen years, to defend the same peace by different routes.

Luthe came next from the speaking-mirrors, the morning's first pulse from Tarse in his coat pocket. He sat at the eastern bench and unfolded his day's business. Cael watched him and thought of the conditional yes Luthe had given Sael three days before, in this hall's antechamber. Luthe's condition had been a good one. Cael hoped the Circle would hear it.

Pell arrived from the basin-house, still smelling faintly of the gel. Mott appeared from the counting-house, the day's first sums under his arm. Dorr walked up from the granaries, boots pale with barley-dust. Saine entered from the school of the daughters, where she had been teaching the eight-part charter that morning as she taught it every morning, in the Founders' own voice. Cael felt a clean weight watching her come in: a woman who had wept in her own classroom the morning she heard what she had been teaching. Iren took the upper bench last, the rim-gate keeper, up from the southern terrace with the small formality of a man who would rather have been at his gate.

Vey's chair at the end of the bench lay draped in the pale cloth the city laid on the chair of a keeper not yet replaced. Cael did not look at it. He had looked at it once, the morning after the wake, and it had done something to him he could not set down.

Haren rose.

"Working session," he said, in the voice of a man opening a meeting he intended to keep procedural. "Regional revisions on the table. Seals for the autumn quarter. The Mirror Hall's report on the autumn pulse to Tarse. The Tithe house's monthly on basin-feed. Any old business."

Cael had heard the list at the head of every working session for nineteen years. This morning it opened like a door, and he had spent three days deciding whether to walk through.

He had decided. He rose.

Haren stopped mid-sentence, the way a man stops when the room has changed shape. Mott's chalk was in his hand. Saine's folio lay open at the day's lesson. Pell's hand rested on the rail of the speaking-stone. The chamber held still, the way a room holds still when a Keeper rises who had not been expected to rise, a courtesy Cael had never before asked the Circle to extend him.

"Point of office," he said.

It was the opening for an Underhold Keeper who wished to speak outside the day's agenda. Cael had used it twice in nineteen years. He waited until the room settled into the procedural posture, hands flat, eyes forward, then he spoke.

"I rise to inform the Circle of a finding in the unedited record of the Underhold, and to declare, on the matter of the office I hold, that the taught charter of this city, as it stands in the House of Tithes and the school of the daughters, is not, in my certification, complete."

The room did not move. Haren's hand, rising to the desk, lowered by a fraction. Pell's fingers left the rail. Luthe closed his folder. Saine closed her folio. Mott set his chalk on the bench beside him with the care of a man setting down a thing that might still be needed.

"On the morning of the third day after Elder Vey's wake," Cael said, "I descended to the Underhold alone. I used my own key. I took the FY 12 volume of the Store's edit log from the eastern gallery. I read it. It records, in plain civic type, an edit made to common memory on the seventh day of the seventh month, FY 12, in which the Store, acting under the standing mandate of the Compact, edited out of common memory a petition lodged by the Objectors of the Founding, together with the petition's reference to a clause of the charter that the taught edition does not contain."

He let the pause be the kind a clerk makes at the end of a line in a ledger, the pause in which the next clerk decides whether to write in the same hand or begin a new column.

"I have since read the unedited founding text in full. It contains nine parts. The taught charter, as held in the House of Tithes, contains eight. The ninth part is titled *The Reservation of Review*. It states that the Compact was to be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found and may be ended by the free vote of the city in

the hundredth. The taught charter does not contain this clause. As far as I can determine from the unedited, the taught charter was presented to the city as if it had always been so. The Store's own log records the edit. The log is honest about it. The taught charter is not."

He did not say *the Store lied.* In the small hours he had decided the sentence was not, in its plain form, true. A thing logged was not, in the Store's own civic voice, a thing lied about. The taught charter had been presented as complete, and that presentation had been carried, generation after generation, in the schools and at the basins and on the framed pages in the offices of the Circle. If there was a lie, it was civic, and Cael was part of the civic.

"By the duties of my office," he said, "I am required to certify that the unedited record kept in the Underhold agrees with the taught record held in the city. I cannot make that certification. The two records do not agree in their broad shape on the charter at the root of the peace. I will not stamp the taught charter as complete. I will not countersign the autumn seals that presuppose it complete. I will not, until this Circle has decided what to do about the disagreement, perform the annual certification of the unedited as it has been performed in this office for nineteen years."

A chair received him. He sat.

The room held still for a long time. The eastern mirrors threw a slow band of light across the upper bench, where Vey's chair lay draped. Iren looked at the cloth. Dorr looked at the floor. Saine's hands lay flat on the closed folio.

It was Haren who rose first.

"Cael." He used the name, not the office. "You have stood in this chamber for nineteen years and stamped the autumn seals. You have defended the procedure of this Circle against every junior keeper who thought the unedited too cumbersome to be useful. You have been the door of the Underhold. Are you telling this Circle that the door you have been opens on a room the city was never meant to see."

"I am telling this Circle that the room held a ninth part, that the ninth part was not on the city's wall, and that the absence is a fact of the record."

"An absence is a fact. The record is not the city. The city has lived ninety years on the taught charter and has not fallen into the old quarrel."

"The city has lived ninety years on a charter that did not contain a clause the Founders signed. It has not fallen into the quarrel. It has lived inside the teaching of a charter the Founders did not teach."

"The Founders are dead."

"The charter is not."

Haren took his seat. His hands lay on the desk in the position Cael remembered from the morning Sael had brought him the same finding. The position had not

changed. The man had not changed. The room had.

Luthe rose.

"Cael. The Mirror Hall's pulse to Tarse for the autumn quarter is due at the equinox. If Vell's taught charter is in dispute in this Circle, Tarse receives a pulse from a city whose own compact is under question. Will you countersign the autumn seals or will you not."

"I will not."

"Without the seals, Tarse receives a pulse from no keeper in particular."

"I understand. I will not sign what the seals presuppose."

Luthe sat. He did not look toward the door. Sael was not in the room; the Rememberer petitioned the Circle but did not sit in its working sessions. Cael had thought about asking her and decided against it. This finding was his to bring, by office, and he had wanted the Circle to hear it from the office whose duty it was to certify the record, not from the office whose duty it was to petition. He had wanted his office to speak, because that office was what he was about to put at risk.

Mott rose.

"The log. Does the seal on it belong to the Keeper of FY 12, or to a later hand."

"The seal belongs to the Keeper of the period. He stamped the log. I have seen the stamp."

"He is dead."

"Yes."

"By his stamp he did not certify the edit. He certified the recording of the edit. Is that the correct reading."

"It is. The stamp certifies the recording. The recording records the edit. The edit sits in the same hand as the regional revisions of the period."

"Recorded in plain civic type."

"Yes."

Mott took his seat. He did not say he would read the log. He had already said, three days before, that he would read it himself, with his own key, before he committed a vote. That reading was not for today. Cael had not asked anyone to commit today. He had asked only that the Circle hear what the office had found.

Pell did not rise. She sat with her hand on the rail of the speaking-stone, and after a moment she said, in the small quiet voice she used at the basin, "Cael. The basin does not certify the charter. The basin holds the Tithe."

"I know. The basin is not at issue today. The taught charter is. It is held in the House of Tithes and taught at the basin. If it is incomplete, the basin has been teaching an incomplete charter."

"The basin has taught the charter it was given."

"Yes. And the charter it was given fell short by one part."

Pell did not answer. Cael did not press her. The torn keepers did not need pressing at a working session; they needed time, and time was a thing the Circle was supposed to give.

Saine rose.

"Cael. I have taught the eight-part charter to the daughters every morning for nineteen years. They come of age at the autumn equinox. They will be taught it at the rail, as every equinox for ninety years. If the charter is in dispute in this Circle, what am I to teach them tomorrow."

"Teach them the eight-part charter as the taught edition of a charter whose taught edition is in dispute. Teach them that the office of the Underhold has found a part in the unedited the taught edition does not contain. Teach them that the office will not certify the taught edition as complete. Teach them that the dispute will be heard in this Circle, that the refusal is on the record, and that the daughters of Vell have a right to know it is on the record."

Saine sat. Her hand closed on the folio. Cael had meant only to answer her question. The answer had come out shaped like an instruction, and the shape of an instruction, he understood, was what a Keeper reached for when he knew the answer would cost the city something and wanted the cost to be plain.

Dorr did not rise. He sat with his hands on his knees and looked at the floor. Iren did not rise. He kept the upper bench with the formality of a man whose office was a gate and whose gate was not in this room.

The chamber waited. Haren rose again.

"Cael. The Circle has heard you. The Circle has not voted, and will not, until the petition is filed. Until then your office stands as it has stood. The autumn seals require your countersignature. The equinox pulse to Tarse requires it. The annual certification requires your signature. Will you sign under protest, with the protest entered on the record, or will you withhold your signature and force this Circle to find a Keeper who will sign what you will not."

"I will withhold my signature."

"You understand that the Circle may, under the standing procedure for an obstructive office, move to suspend the Keeper of the Underhold and appoint a substitute until the obstruction is resolved."

"I do. The procedure is in chapter six of the Circle's code."

"You understand the move requires five of nine, and that it may pass."

"That is correct."

"You are asking this Circle to break your office."

"I am asking this Circle to consider whether the office was worth keeping in the shape I have kept it. I will not ask you to break it. I will not ask you to keep it. I will let the Circle do what the Circle does with what the office has given it."

Haren sat. His hands did not move on the desk.

The room held for another long moment. The speaking-stone lay bare and pale in its morning light, and no keeper rose on it. Cael sat with his hands flat on his knees, the satchel at his feet, the seal at his belt, and felt a clean weight settle in him that was not relief and was not absolution. He had spoken, at last, in the chamber he had been defending for nineteen years, and he had not been struck down for speaking. He would be struck down for it later, on another day, in another room, by a keeper who rose on the stone and moved that the office be suspended, and the motion might pass. Such a passing would carry the city's vote, and the city's conscience would answer for what it did to a man who had only done what his office required, and had done it in the chamber where the office was meant to be done.

He had not been relieved. He had not been absolved. He had been heard.

The session resumed around him, slowly, the way a basin resumes its surface after a stone is lifted from the gel. Haren asked Luthe for the Mirror Hall's report. Luthe stood and gave it in the careful mirror-clerk's voice that did not editorialize: the autumn pulse would go at the equinox; it would not carry Cael's seal; it would carry whatever seal the Circle decided to put on it. The chamber received the report and moved on to the Tithe house's monthly, and the basin-feed, and the regional revisions, each clerk rising to read his small revisions in the small civic voice the clerks kept for revisions. The chamber held the revisions the way it held everything, without flinching, without the appearance of holding.

Cael sat through it. He would not speak again at this session. The seals would be tabled. The Mirror Hall's report would be taken under advisement. The chamber would do its ordinary work, in the taught version of the peace, for as many days as the taught version had left. He had given the Circle the finding. The Circle would carry it or it would not.

He would walk home by the long terrace and take the satchel with him. He would set the volume on his desk in the morning light and look at it a long time before he returned it to the eastern gallery, where it had sat for one hundred and ninety-two years and would sit for as long as the city needed it held. The city would need it held the way a basin needs to hold a Tithe, and a school needs to hold a charter, and a Keeper needs to hold an office he has decided he cannot keep in the shape he has kept it.

He rose when the chamber rose. He inclined his head to Haren, who did not return it. He inclined his head to Luthe, who did. He inclined his head to Pell, and Pell inclined hers to him, a small motion, the courtesy a torn keeper extends to one who has named the thing she has not yet been able to name.

He walked out of the Council Hall into the morning light, the satchel at his side, the seal at his belt, the chamber behind him with the speaking-stone bare and Vey's chair draped at the end of the bench.

Chapter <!-- POV: Nethe Vell -->

<!-- SETUP: Nethe reveals the Rim also curates (ignores truths that would fracture it). Collapses Sael's binary. -->

Chapter 17 — The Rim's Own Silence

The afternoon the Keeper of the Underhold stood and said he would cosign, Nethe was at her usual place on the terrace edge below the Rememberer's house, mending a pack strap with a bone needle and sinew she had brought from the Rim. The basin queues had been thin all day; citizens moved in the soft, careful way of people who had heard something at the morning bell and were still deciding what to make of it. Nethe did not need the bell. She had watched Cael Orrin walk the upper terrace at the second hour with his office coat buttoned wrong, the way a man walks when he has decided to do a thing and is walking himself into the doing of it. She had watched Sael walk behind him at three paces. She did not follow the city into its public rooms. She watched it from where it could be watched.

The pack strap was the kind of work the Rim taught every child, and Nethe's hands knew it without thinking. The sinew was stiff in the late air and she worked it soft against her knee before she threaded it. The terrace edge gave her a clear view down the long line of the eastern face, the routed mirrors holding the late sun in long pale channels. Below her, the basin-level lay quiet, its pools still in the thin gold of the hour before the mirrors stopped. Somewhere up the terraces, behind the angle of the basin rail, Cael was saying the words that would commit his office to a petition the city had spent two centuries being taught it had never owed.

Nethe did not think of him as brave. She thought of him as a man who had been given a choice between two kinds of trouble and had chosen the kind that cost him his name. The Rim kept its own names. The Rim understood the price of a name spoken in public.

She finished the mend and bit the sinew short. The strap held her weight when she tugged it, which was the test she always set her mends, because a Rim pack carried a Rim life and a Rim life could not afford a strap that failed on a path with a long drop. She coiled the leftover sinew and tucked it into the small pouch at her hip, and she sat with her hands on her knees and her eyes on the basin, and she let the day settle around her the way the city had settled around its own held breath.

Sael came down at the fourth bell.

She came the way she always did after hours in the city: a measured step, an office set down at the foot of the stairs. Her coat was unbuttoned at the throat. Her face held the inward compression Nethe had learned to read as a person carrying something she would set down only on a surface she trusted. Nethe did not rise. She was on Vell ground only by invitation.

Sael sat on the terrace edge two arms' lengths away, in the place she had taken to sitting when she came down to talk. She did not speak first. The two of them had learned, in the weeks since Nethe had walked the three days, that the first silence was a door and a person had to decide whether to walk through it.

"Three," Nethe said.

Sael looked at her.

"Three keepers said yes to your petition in the city today. Two more have not said. One will not. One will sit it out. I counted the coats going in and out of the basin-house, and I read the shoulders."

Sael did not ask how Nethe could read shoulders. The Rim read shoulders. The Rim read the small motions of the body in public because the Rim had spent three generations watching the city's public motions and learning their grammar the way a student learns a second language, by listening for what the language tried to keep hidden.

"The number is not the thing I came down for," Sael said.

"I know the number is not the thing. I told you the number because the number is what the city will speak about for the next week, and I would rather you had a true count of it than the count the city will make up. What did you come down for."

Sael took a long breath and let it out. The mirrors had just begun to withdraw. A thin line of shadow moved up the terrace, dividing the gold from the grey. "I came down because the day has been loud, and the loud is not the part I need to think about. The part I need to think about is quieter, and I would rather think it next to a person who does not have a stake in the city having been right."

Nethe looked at her. Sael's face showed a woman who had not slept well and was not pretending she had. The Rim had a word for that face. The Rim called it the afternoon of the long day.

"Ask, then," Nethe said.

Sael was quiet for a moment. The basin below caught the last of the routed sun in its still pool, and a single Tithe-bell rang from the lower level, the small soft note a basin gives when a citizen has finished speaking and the gel has settled. They listened to it together, the way two people listen to a sound they have each heard alone many times and are now hearing together for the first time.

"You told me the Rim keeps what the city loses," Sael said. "You told me this the first afternoon we sat here. I have been holding it as a sentence I could stand on. I have been treating the Rim as the kept place and the city as the lost place, the Rim as the holder of truth and the city as the holder of the edit. I have been walking on that sentence for weeks."

"I remember saying it," Nethe said.

"I am not asking you to unsay it. I am asking you whether the sentence carries the whole of what the Rim keeps."

Nethe did not answer at once. She had expected this question, or some shape of it, since the morning Cael had walked the upper terrace with his coat buttoned wrong. She had walked the Rim for nineteen years and the road to Vell for three days and the terraces of Vell for weeks, and she had felt the sentence tighten in her mouth the way a held breath tightens in the chest, because the sentence she had given Sael on the first afternoon was true, and it was also not the whole truth, and the Rim had a name for the difference. The Rim called the difference *the kept silence*, and the kept silence was what a community held in its mouth the way a basin held a memory, not because no one knew it was there but because everyone knew it was there and no one would be the one to set it down in public.

"You came down to ask about the kept silence," Nethe said.

"I came down to ask whether the Rim keeps a kept silence. Whether the Rim also has a part of its own story it has agreed not to say."

"Yes," Nethe said.

The word sat between them, a stone set down with no one yet decided what to do with it. Nethe had not meant to say it so soon. She had meant to lead Sael to it through the count of the keepers and the day's loudness. But Sael had asked directly, the way a Rememberer asks, by naming the shape of the thing she needed to see, and Nethe had been raised to respect directness when it was offered clean.

"Tell me," Sael said, and her voice was very even.

Nethe looked out at the basin-level. A child was walking with an older sister along the basin rail, and the older sister was pointing at the gel, explaining what a basin is for. Nethe watched them until they passed out of sight behind the angle of the rail.

"Every community keeps a kept silence," Nethe said. "The Rim keeps Aren's objection, word for word; we have kept it for three generations and will keep it for three more, because that objection is the door we walked out of and the reason we are the Rim. That is the sentence I gave you. It is true. I will not unsay it. But the Rim is not only its door. The Rim is also a room, and the room holds parts that do not fit the story the Rim tells itself in the songs, and the Rim has agreed, the way all small communities agree, to leave those parts out of the singing."

Sael was very still. "What parts."

Nethe took a small breath. The air at the terrace edge was cooler than the air at the upper levels, and it smelled of the gel and the thin stone dust the basin-wind lifted in the evenings. "The second winter," she said. "We do not put the second winter in the songs."

"Tell me the second winter."

"We were three seasons into the Rim. The first objectors and their children and a few who had walked out later were two hundred and forty people in a clearing the eastern ridge had given us. The first winter had been hard, and we had lost seven

of the old ones, and the keeping of them had been our first story. Then the second winter came early. The snow closed the path to the lower pasture a full moon before we had laid in the stores. There was a man in the camp, a former basin-keeper from Vell, who had broken his hip in the autumn when a tree he was felling rolled wrong and pinned him. He could not walk, ride, or be carried down the path, and in the snow he could not be carried at all, because the path was ice and the drop on the eastern side was long."

Sael's hands had come together in her lap. Nethe did not look at them.

"The elders held the count in the open air, every voice given. The man could not be moved, and would slow any party that tried, and might cost other lives if the storm closed as the elders read it would. Three elders voted to leave him in the shelter with what could be spared and send a strong party down before the path closed. Two voted against. The rest abstained; their children were too young to vote, and the children had to be considered. The vote carried. We left him food, a lamp, a blanket, and sent the party down. The storm closed that night, and the man died in the second week of the snow."

Nethe spoke the way the Rim spoke, with the verbs dropped where they could be spared and the plurals used as the uncoupled used them, and her voice did not rise and did not fall. The telling answered to itself. The telling was not a judgment.

"We sang of the first winter, that winter, the year of the keeping. We sang of the second winter only in pieces. We did not sing of the vote. We did not sing of the man. We did not put his name in the songs. The songs we sing to the children say we are the community that keeps its own, that no one is left, that the Rim is a kept place where the strong carry the weak. The songs do not say the second winter. The songs do not say the vote."

Sael's face had not changed. The face had done the small inward compression it had been doing all afternoon, and it did not stop doing it.

"How many know," Sael said, in the careful way of a person who is not asking a question she does not want the answer to.

"All of us. The children of the second winter know, and the grandchildren, and the elders who held the count and their children, and we have not stopped knowing. We have stopped saying. Knowing and saying are not the same in the Rim. A person can know and not say, and the not-saying is not a lie, because a lie is a thing told. The not-saying is a kept silence, a different animal from a lie told."

Sael nodded, slowly. She had been the Rememberer long enough to know the difference between a lie told and a silence kept, and she had been Sael long enough to know the difference between the two weights.

"The man," Sael said. "Did he have a name."

"His name was Oder. He had walked out of Vell in the third year after the Found, when the basin-keepers asked him to settle a grief he did not believe was his to settle. He kept his name when he walked, because names are the one thing the

Rim does not edit. He had been a quiet man who mended, the way you have seen me mend, and his mending kept three of the early shelters through the first winter. We sang of his mending. We did not sing of his dying."

Sael was quiet for a long time. The mirrors had stopped. The basin-level lay in the soft blue of the hour after the routed light was withdrawn. A Tithe-bell rang again from the upper level, the second small note of the late queue, and a single voice could be heard from somewhere up the terrace, low and indistinct, a citizen speaking into a basin.

"You came to tell me the Rim is not what I have been holding it as," Sael said at last.

"I came to tell you the Rim is a community, and a community is a place with songs shorter than the room. The Rim has a door, and walks through it. The Rim also has a room, and the room holds a part the songs do not say. The part is Oder. The not-saying of Oder is what holds the door in place."

Sael turned her head and looked at Nethe directly. The look held the small, exact pressure of a person whose held sentence had just been refused its shape.

"You are saying the Rim edits," Sael said.

"I am saying every community decides what to keep in the songs. The Rim decides by song. The city decides by basin. The song and the basin are different shapes of the same animal. The animal is what a community does with the parts of itself it cannot afford to carry in public. The city cannot afford to carry the objection. The Rim cannot afford to carry Oder. The city buries the objection in a chancery note and teaches the children the note was never written. The Rim buries Oder in the silence between the verses and teaches the children the verses were always complete. Both of us are lying, in the sense that the room we live in is not the room we say we live in. Neither of us is lying, in the sense that we are both trying to live in a room that fits the songs we need to walk to the next morning."

Nethe paused. The basin-lamps were coming on across the lower level, one by one, and the terrace edge where they sat lay in a slow thickening dark that was not yet night.

"You have been standing on the sentence I gave you," Nethe said. "I told you the Rim holds what the city loses. That held for the door. It does not hold for the room. I should have given you both at the first afternoon. I did not, because I wanted the door to hold until you had walked through it. The door held. You walked through it. Now I am telling you the room. I am telling you because the room holds the part that will matter when you stand in your basin-house and ask the city what it wants to do with the door it lost."

Sael sat with her hands in her lap and her eyes on the basin-level, and Nethe did not interrupt. The night came in from the eastern ridge and took the last of the sun; the basin-lamps below were the only points of light left on the terrace.

"You kept Oder out of the songs to hold the door," Sael said at last, in the careful

voice of a person putting down a thing she has been carrying. "The city kept the objection out of the charter to hold the peace. Both of you protected something you needed to keep walkable. Both of you taught the children the walk was always as walkable as it is. The walk in the Rim and the walk in the city were both built on a piece of ground no one was allowed to look at."

Nethe gave the single word. "Yes," she said.

"Then I have been wrong about the Rim."

"You have been right about the Rim for the part you needed to see. You have been wrong about the part I needed to keep. We were both using each other. You used me for the door; I used you for the petition. The using is not the lying. It is what two communities do when they decide to speak across the line they have spent three generations drawing."

Sael did not answer. The basin-lamps held their small yellow points across the level below, and the quiet of the city lay over them both, and Nethe sat with her hands on her knees and let Sael sit with the held thing.

Then Sael said, very quietly, in a voice that had dropped both the Rememberer and the office from it, "If both of us are lying, the question is not who lies truer. The question is whether the citizen agrees to the lie. Consent. That is what the petition has to be about. Not who keeps the song. Not who keeps the basin. Whether the citizen, before the song is sung or the basin is held, agrees to the part the song leaves out and the part the basin smooths over. That is the only ground that does not move."

Nethe looked at her for a long time. The night had come in past the ridge. The basin-lamps had all come on, and the terrace was dark except for the small yellow of the pools.

"Yes," Nethe said. "That is the ground."

They sat on the terrace edge a while longer, two people who had said a thing they would not take back and were not yet ready to stand from where they had said it. A Tithe-bell rang from the upper level, the third small note of the late evening, and neither answered it. The ground beneath them both was the ground they had not been allowed to look at. They had looked at it now, and it had not opened under them. It had only become the ground they were already standing on.

When Sael rose, she did so slowly, the way a person rises who has sat longer than she meant to. Nethe rose with her. They did not embrace; the terrace edge was a kind of public, and neither needed the gesture to mark what had passed. Sael looked at Nethe, and Nethe looked at Sael, and the looking was enough.

"I will remember Oder," Sael said.

"Remember him quietly," Nethe said. "He would not have wanted the song. He would have wanted the door."

Sael nodded once and walked up the lower terrace toward her house, and the

small lamp from the upper level followed her as she climbed, and Nethe watched her go. The Rim had kept Oder out of the songs to hold the door, and the city had kept the objection out of the charter to hold the peace, and Sael had walked down to the terrace that afternoon believing the Rim was free, and she was walking back up believing neither side was free, and the belief she was climbing with was the one the petition would have to be built on: not a city cured of its edits, but a city asked, for the first time in two centuries, whether it had consented to them.

Nethe sat back down on the terrace edge. She took the bone needle from her pouch and began a fresh mend on the strap that did not yet need it, because a Rim woman who has given the room does not stop mending. The basin-lamps held their small yellow points against the dark. The ridge kept the night. The ground kept the room she had just uncovered, and the room kept the door, and Nethe mended, and did not sing, because the not-singing was a keeping of its own, and the keeping belonged to the morning, and the morning would come in its own time and ask the city what it had agreed to.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael synthesizes the Rim's curated freedom with Vell's curated peace; reframes the petition as a question of consent, not raw truth; the petition's shape is fixed. -->

Chapter 18 — What the Silence Was For

Nethe's parting sentence stayed with Sael longer than the woman herself had. *We are not the opposite of you. We are a quieter lie told in a smaller room.* She had spoken it on the rim of the lower basin at the third bell, the hour the gel was warm from the day's last Tithe, with no anger in her voice and no pity either, only the flat directness Sael had come to expect from her. Then she had gone back down the goat track toward the wild edge, the way she had come, and Sael had stood at the rail and watched her go without calling after her, because there had been nothing left to call. The Rim's own silence was not a different silence from Vell's. It was a quieter form of the same. Sael had been carrying this for two days, and the carrying had begun to feel like the load that came before a structure decides what it is.

She had walked the terraces since dawn. Vell lay open under the routed mirrors, the long pale channels catching the early sun and feeding it down the levels in even offerings, the kind of light a person could set a clock by. She had passed the upper basin where a child was being read the eight-part charter in a small clear voice, the daughtercoming rite, the rite she herself had been read at fourteen, and she had walked past without stopping because she did not trust her face in that moment. She had passed the lower basin, where the gel was still and silver under the rail. She had passed the closed court where the Tithe-stone sat under its cloth.

She had passed the quiet squares and the gardens where a gardener was on her knees in the soil, doing the work of a quiet morning, the way the gardener in the third chapter of Cael Orrin's recollection had been doing, the way gardeners did in Vell when the city was at peace, which was the only way Vell knew. She had walked until her legs were honest, which was the way Sael Irdren had always arrived at the place a thought was waiting to be thought. Her legs were honest now. The thought was arriving.

The Rim edited. Nethe had told her plainly, in the clipped Rim dialect that used *we* for the uncoupled and *you* for everyone else, that her community kept its own silences. They had preserved the oral memory of Aren's objection, yes, and they had taught it to their children, and that preservation was a genuine gift, a thing Vell had not managed and the Rim had. But they had also let other truths go quiet in the telling, truths that would have split the uncoupled settlement along lines the settlement could not afford to split along. There were names the Rim did not speak. There were quarrels the Rim had agreed to bury under a story the quarrels did not fit. There was, Nethe had said, a year when the Rim had nearly ended itself over a question of land, and the elders had sat down and made a quiet version of the year and taught the children the quiet version, because the loud version would have made the children leave. The Rim had not done this by basin. The Rim had done it by the older mechanism, by the mechanism every small group of people has when the group has to keep holding, which is to leave certain sentences out of the telling and to leave the leaving-out out of the memory of the telling. The Rim did this in the kitchen, at the fire, in the long walk between one village and the next. The Rim did this without a Store. The Rim did this because the Rim was a city too, only a smaller one, and small cities edit the way large cities edit, by hand, by breath, by the agreement to not quite finish the sentence. Sael had wanted, for most of a year, to believe the Rim was her answer to Vell, the clean ground against which the edited city could be measured and found wanting. Nethe had taken that comfort from her not by arguing but by describing her own grandmother, who had left a year out of a story and taught the silence as if it had been there from the start. The grandmother had not used a basin. The grandmother had used a pause. A pause is also a mechanism. A pause is also an edit, when the pause is taught as the whole of the story.

If the Rim edited, then the clean binary Sael had been carrying since Nethe first walked up the goat track collapsed, and the clean binary was what she had most needed to fall. The clean binary had been: Vell was edited and the Rim was free, the city was a kind lie and the uncoupled were an unkind truth, the basin was a violence and the goat track was an honesty. The clean binary had been a comfort in the way a wrong answer is a comfort when the right one is too large to hold. Nethe had not been cruel in collapsing it. Nethe had been precise. She had not offered Sael a new comfort. She had offered her the absence of one. Nethe's words returned to her, not as opposition but as a quieter lie in a smaller room. A quieter lie, told in a smaller room. A peace that remembered itself as peace, whether the

room was a plateau or a goat track or the unlit corner of a kitchen where a grandmother did not quite finish a story about a year no one in the family would speak of again. Every society Sael had ever heard of, including the ones that refused the basins, including the ones she had been holding as the free ground against which Vell's peace could be measured, had decided at some hour to edit. The decision was not the sin. The decision carried the cost of being a city. The sin was somewhere else. The sin had to be somewhere else, because if editing were itself the sin, then there was no city and no peace and no Sael Irdren, and she was still standing on the rail of the lower basin with a notebook in her belt and a question she had not yet been able to ask out loud.

She sat on the bench at the third terrace. The bench faced the eastern face, where the mirrors were catching the late light and feeding it down in long even channels. She had sat on a bench like this in the fifteenth chapter, the bench Mire had liked, and she sat on it now without the small cruelty of the choosing, because the cruelty had done its work and she could let the bench be a bench. She took the notebook from her belt. She opened it to a fresh page. She set the pen down without writing, the way a person sets a tool down before they know which tool they need.

The Store had edited the founding objection. The Store had done this under a standing mandate, a mandate broad enough that the Circle had never had to be asked. The Store had done it by the same mechanism it used every day, the mechanism of the settlement, the hinge between **held** and **made quiet in the common memory**. Sael had spent the last week writing that sentence in the margin of every document that touched the operation. **Settlement equals edit.** The body had been quicker than the office. The office was catching up. The office had caught up enough now to see that what the Store had done was not the same as what the Rim had done, and that the difference mattered more than the sameness. The Rim edited by leaving sentences out of the telling. The Rim did not announce the telling as a memory of a thing that had been edited. The Rim did not teach its children that the telling had always been the telling. The Rim did not claim, by basin or by any other mechanism, that the quiet year had been quiet from the start. The Rim's lie was a quiet lie. The Rim's lie was a lie a person could refuse by going to the grandmother and asking the question again and waiting for the grandmother to finish the sentence. The Store's lie was a louder thing. The Store's lie had been taught as the only version. The Store's lie had been lifted into the citizen's chest as the memory of having always lived inside the lie, and that lifting was the operation Sael had been calling the edit, and that lifting was also the thing the edit was doing, which was to remove the possibility of refusal. A lie a person can refuse is a choice. A lie a person cannot refuse is not a peace. It is a peace that has been arranged so that no one can be asked whether they wanted it.

That was the consent. That was where the consent lived. Not in the basin and not in the goat track and not in the kitchen fire. The consent lived in whether the citizen could know what was being lifted, and whether the citizen could refuse the

lifting, and whether the citizen, having refused, could still live in the city without being made into an outsider by the refusal. In Vell, the answer to all three of those questions had been *no* since FY 12, because the Store had edited the objection out of common memory and taught the city that the objection had never existed, and a city that does not know there is an objection cannot refuse the objection. A city that does not know it once chose cannot now choose. A city that has been told the choice was unanimous has not been unanimous. It has been told it was unanimous. The telling held the violation. The lying was not in what was lifted. The lying was in what was laid down in its place, which was a unanimous peace that had never been unanimous, and a peace that had been made unanimous by editing could not, in the deepest sense, be a peace at all. It was a peace that had taken the citizen's consent by removing the conditions under which the consent could have been withheld.

Sael wrote in the notebook, slowly, in the private hand she kept for things she could not yet show to anyone:

What was edited: the founding objection, and the clauses.

What was laid down: a unanimous Compact that had never been unanimous.

What was removed: the citizen's ability to refuse.

She set the pen down. She read it back. She read it back the way she had been trained to read contested passages, aloud in her head, giving each clause the weight of a separate breath, and the separate breaths held. The sentences did not flatter her. The sentences did not console her. The sentences took the shape of what she had found, and the shape had been getting clearer all week, and the clarity had nothing to do with the Rim and nothing to do with the Rim's goat track and everything to do with the fact that she had walked the terraces at dawn and let her legs be honest. Her legs had been honest. The notebook had accepted what her office had not yet been permitted to say. The office was catching up now, and the office, when it caught, would have to decide what to do with what it had caught.

Haren had argued, in the conversation Sael had not yet had with him and was about to have, that restoring the clauses would reopen the wound. Haren was not wrong. Haren was not wrong in the way a person is not wrong when they say the floor will collapse under the load you are asking it to bear. The clauses, if restored, would tell the city that the peace had been built on an edited objection, and the city would want to know what else had been edited, and the city would not stop asking, because a city that has learned it was lied to once will not, by its nature, agree to be lied to again on the same terms. The city would want the settlement opened. The city would want to know which of its quarrels had been buried, which of its names had been smoothed, which of its terraces had been taken and which of its gifts had been lies told in the form of gifts. Haren feared this. Haren feared the load. Sael feared it too. What separated them was not the fear but the object

the fear guarded. Haren guarded the peace. Sael guarded the consent that made the peace a peace and not an arrangement. You could not have both. You could not have an edited unanimity and a city that knew it had been edited. You could not have a buried objection and a city that was free to choose the Compact's future. You could have one or the other, and the choice between them was the choice the petition would have to name, and the petition's whole work was to make the naming possible.

The petition, then, was not to dump every edited memory back into the common air. That would be its own violence, and Sael knew it. Mire's bell, if returned to the city as a memory of a name, would name a dead girl and reopen a year of quiet Haren had spent his office holding. The gardener's quarrel with her brother, if returned, would name the brother and reopen a terrace wall that the city had agreed was a wall and not a quarrel. The border memory, if returned, would tell Vell's neighbor that the gift had been a taking, and the neighbor was not in the room, and the neighbor had not been asked. Sael could not petition all of this. Sael would not petition all of this. The petition was not a wound-opener. The petition was a door.

The petition would be: restore the founding objection, and the FY 50 review clause, and the FY 100 sunset clause, to common memory. Restore the names of the clauses. Restore the year of the Store's edit. Restore the Store's own justification, in the Store's flat civic voice, so that the city could see what the Store had done and could decide, with that knowledge, whether the Compact would continue in its present form or be reopened by the free vote the FY 100 clause had always allowed. The petition would not ask the city to relitigate the founding quarrel. The quarrel was not the city's to relitigate, because the quarrel had been between the Founders and the Founders' children, and the Founders' children's children had grown into a city that did not know the quarrel had been had. The petition would not ask the city to choose between Vell and the Rim, because Vell and the Rim were both cities and both had their edits and the choice between them was the kind of choice that did not need to be made. The petition would ask the city to do one thing, and the one thing was the thing the Store had taken from it: the ability to know that the Compact had been opposed, and to decide whether to keep it.

Sael read the notebook back. She read it back twice. She read it back a third time, marking the breath between *ability* and *know*, which was the breath the Store had been taking for nine generations, the breath that held the operation together and hid the second sense inside the first. She let the breath stand. She let the petition stand, because the petition was now the shape of what she had found, and the shape was narrow. Only that narrowness made the petition possible. A wide petition would lose the Circle. A wide petition would hand Haren the argument he had been making all year, the argument that the cost of opening was greater than the cost of leaving closed. A narrow petition would say: we restore the objection. We restore the clauses. We tell the city what was lifted and what was

laid down. We let the city decide. If the city decides the Compact should continue, the Compact continues, and the peace holds, and the peace holds differently because it holds on consent and not on arrangement. If the city decides the Compact should end, the Compact ends, and the ending is a kind of ending the Founders' minority had wanted, an ending chosen by the city that made the peace, and the city will know, for the first time in nine generations, that the choice was theirs.

She closed the notebook. She let the terrace light come in through her closed eyes, the long pale channels the mirrors fed from ridge to basin, and she let the light be light and not a metaphor, because the city's light-tithing was not the memory Tithe and had never been, and she had spent enough of her life letting one thing stand for another. The light was light. The basin was a basin. The gel was gel. The petition was a petition. She had the shape of it. She would not file it today. She would not tell the Circle the final text yet. She would let the shape sit in the notebook in the private hand, the hand she kept for things she could not yet show to anyone, and she would carry it the way she had carried Mire's name for thirteen years, as a private undercurrent beneath the public calm. The carrying held the work. The carrying was what the office was for. The office was for holding the unjudged until the unjudged could be shown. The showing would come. The showing would be tomorrow or the day after or the day after that. The day she showed it would be the day she stopped being a neutral office and became a person who had asked the city to remember what it had been taught to forget, and the city would answer, and the answer would be the city's, and that was the consent the Compact had always promised and never delivered, and that was the silence the silence had been for, and that was the petition.

She stood up from the bench. The gardener in the square had finished her work and was brushing the soil from her knees. The routed light had reached the upper basin and was lying in a pale bar across the rail where Sael had stood two days ago to watch Nethe walk back down the goat track. Sael did not go to the rail. She went up the terrace toward the Rememberer's house, the notebook at her belt, the shape of the petition quiet in her hand, and the morning of the day she would not yet file was a morning she could walk through without flinching, which was the most she had ever asked of a morning since the year Mire had forgotten her name.

<!-- POV: omniscient-historical -->

<!-- SETUP: A common-memory edit of FY 12, shown as it 'landed' in citizens' minds. -->

Interlude II — The Suppression

On the evening before the settlement, Marn taught twenty-two children that Keeper-First Aren had opposed permanent authority with both hands open on the Founding table. She knew the detail about his hands because her own first teacher

had known one of the clerks present, and because the common memory retained the shortened fingers of his left hand with unusual clarity. Aren had not hidden them. He had laid that hand beside the draft and asked how long an emergency should be permitted to govern people not yet born.

Marn taught the Founding in the third school on the eastern terrace. She was thirty-four, exact in her dates, and patient with children who confused the signing of the Compact with the first mass Tithe seven years later. Her lesson boards carried no ornament. Events went in one column, disputed purposes in another, consequences in a third. Aren occupied all three.

Her oldest lesson copy described the Objectors without contempt. They supported the Store. They accepted that some wounds could not remain public without becoming instructions for revenge. Their objection concerned duration and consent. Marn had copied Aren's question into the margin when she was sixteen: *What begins as remedy must one day answer to those who inherit it.*

That afternoon, a child named Senn asked why Aren signed the Compact if he feared its mandate. Marn answered that signing could record a compromise without erasing dissent. She explained the fiftieth-year review and the hundredth-year sunset, then asked the class to consider why a person might protect an agreement by limiting it. The children grew quiet in the interested way that made teaching worth its hours.

Aren's objection mattered to her not because she shared it in full. Marn had been six when retaliations ended below the plateau. Her father still turned his cup upside down whenever the old valley names appeared in a record. She valued the Store's work and had given four Tithes freely. Yet Aren's caution seemed necessary inside that gratitude, a narrow brace against the ease with which safety could call itself permanent.

When class ended, she cleaned the board but left the question in the margin. Tomorrow's older group would take up the Objectors' petition of FY 12. Aren and the surviving signers had asked the Keepers to affirm the promised review while enough Founders remained alive to prepare it. Marn intended to ask whether requesting an agreed safeguard could fairly be called opposition.

After the pupils left, routed light remained on the upper panes for eleven minutes. Dust showed above the benches. Marn stacked the lesson copies, straightened a slate one child had abandoned at an angle, and read Aren's sentence once more before closing her book. She went home knowing he had led a principled stand.

At home she ate lentils with preserved greens and mended the cuff of her teaching coat. Neighbors spoke in the passage about a mirror that had slipped two degrees and left the lower herb beds cold. No one mentioned the petition. The common account required no gathering, and the Store made no announcement of work performed under the standing mandate.

Before sleep, Marn reviewed the next day's questions. She pictured Aren at the

Founding table, damaged hand spread upon the paper. His argument remained plain in her mind: peace might require power, but power required an ending or a renewed grant. The memory carried no heat. It possessed the firmness of a well-fitted shelf.

Across Vell, lamps went out by terraces. Citizens who had heard Aren speak settled beside citizens born after the signing. Some carried private memories of his voice, his coat, the pauses he allowed before answering. Others knew him through instruction, basin recitation, or the common weave that placed public events in a shared order. Their particular memories remained particular. Cloth stayed brown or gray. Rooms kept their dimensions. A cough in the assembly remained a cough.

No bell marked the settlement. No pulse crossed the skin. The buried nodes compared the petition with the Founding instruction, the recent Tithes concerning faction, and the mandate to maintain civic peace. Association loosened from association by degrees too small for attention. Aren's warning ceased to call up permanence, obedience, and the rights of descendants. It gathered instead around sequence, scheduling, and a question already answered by procedure.

The Store's edit record held one flat line:

> COMMON MEMORY / FY 12 / OBJECTOR PETITION: PRINCIPLED DISSENT SETTLED AS PROCEDURAL CLARIFICATION. SOURCE RECORD HELD. COMMON ASSOCIATIONS REWEIGHTED.

Marn slept through it. Her breathing changed once when a cart crossed the stones below her window. She turned toward the wall and pulled the blanket beneath her chin. Nothing entered her dreams.

Toward dawn, the certainty she had carried to bed lost its edge without losing any of its pieces. Aren still stood at the table. His left hand still lacked two fingers. He still asked a question. Marn could have named the clerks and found the date. What altered concerned importance. The objection no longer arranged those details into a principled stand. It had become a minor procedural note raised before accord.

Nothing in the change announced absence. A gap might have troubled her. A blurred face, a broken date, or a sentence ending before its verb could have sent her to a record. Instead, every part met the next with improved ease. The old argument no longer required defense against the peace that followed it. It rested inside the Founding as a small hesitation properly resolved.

Morning found Marn before the washbasin with an unfamiliar lightness beneath her ribs. She tested it by breathing deeply. No pain answered. No grief had occupied that place the night before, so far as she knew. Still, the relief resembled the hour after a burial duty had been completed, when sorrow remained but no further task could be performed for it.

While dressing, she noticed the repaired cuff and could not recall why the sight made her pause. Thread crossed the seam in seven even stitches. She counted

them, irritated by the impulse, then put on the coat. The feeling passed before she reached the stairs.

At school, Aren's question remained on the board. Marn stood before it with the cleaning cloth in hand. The words looked too large for the lesson they introduced. She wiped them away and wrote the date of the petition in their place.

Her first class concerned irrigation ratios. By the time the older pupils entered, the routed light had reached the rear benches and the room smelled of warm slate. Marn opened the Founding copy to the marked page. A faint pressure touched the base of her throat, neither fear nor sadness, and vanished when she began to speak.

This time she taught that Keeper-First Aren, a careful participant in the Compact, had raised a minor procedural note concerning the schedule of review. The Keepers had received it. The existing settlement had proved sufficient. Aren continued to serve, and the city continued in accord.

The sentence arrived in her own voice without resistance. It sounded familiar. More than familiar, it sounded corrected, as though she had spent years placing emphasis on the wrong clause and had finally heard the grammar.

A boy in the second row lifted his hand. "Wasn't Aren against the standing mandate?"

Marn looked at him with patient surprise. The question felt close to something, though she could not determine what. "Not against it," she said. "He sought clarification about its review. Later accounts sometimes enlarge disagreements because disagreement makes a cleaner lesson than administration."

Behind her, the erased question left a pale fan of chalk. She saw it when she turned to the event column. For one moment she expected words to return through the dust. None did.

She continued with the dates. The children copied them. Senn, who the previous day had asked why Aren signed what he feared, frowned over his slate but did not ask again. His earlier question still existed in Marn's memory. Its premise no longer did. She remembered answering him and remembered that the answer had satisfied the room. Whatever she had said now seemed unnecessarily grave.

By midday, the unease had thinned into a bodily vigilance without an object. Marn checked the lesson copy for an omitted line. The review and sunset provisions appeared where they always had in her personal book, yet her attention moved across them as technical safeguards, honored in principle by the continued oversight of the Keepers. Aren's margin sentence remained in her sixteen-year-old hand. She read it twice and wondered why she had copied so ordinary a thought.

During the meal interval, another teacher complained that his Founding lesson had felt overlong. He intended to reduce the Objectors to half a session next term. Marn agreed. Their exchange carried the modest pleasure of discovering a needless difficulty could be removed. Neither mentioned having taught otherwise.

Later records would preserve the approved lesson revisions from that week. Across the terrace schools, principled stand became procedural concern; objection became clarification; limits became orderly provisions requiring no immediate attention. No directive instructed the teachers to change their boards. Most believed they had merely found clearer words.

At dismissal, Senn left his slate behind again. Marn found on it a rough drawing of a hand with two missing fingers pressed against a page. Beneath the drawing he had written *why sign?* She considered saving it for him, then rubbed it clean. Children often held too tightly to dramatic details.

Once the room emptied, quiet gathered among the benches. Marn closed the shutters in sequence, leaving the easternmost until last. Routed light narrowed across the board, illuminating the faint chalk left by Aren's erased question. She touched the mark with two fingers. The pressure in her throat returned, gentle and almost grateful.

Her hand rested on the teacher's table. She felt as she sometimes did after settling a child's quarrel: tired, useful, released from an obligation she could no longer name. Nothing in the day explained the calm. Marn remained beside the table until the last strip of light withdrew from her fingers.

<!-- POV: Rim elder (oral-memory voice) -->

<!-- SETUP: A Rim elder's oral memory of the schism, imperfect, showing curation. -->

Interlude III — The Half-Remembered

Oss told the Founding at the first cold, when the young uncoupled came in from the north plots with split knuckles and grass seeds caught in their cuffs. Seven sat around the low hearth. None had taken the Tithe. Three had reached fourteen that summer and still looked pleased by the courage of it, as if refusal happened once at a basin rail and not each morning after. Oss waited until they stopped trading looks across the fire.

Beside her knee lay a cord with nine knots. The cord had belonged to her mother, who learned the account from an elder who had learned it farther back than any name Oss could place without argument. Rim memory did not pretend to be stone. A stone kept every mark, including those made by fools. A cord kept what hands had agreed to tie.

"Start us," said the tallest girl.

"Mind your asking," Oss replied. "A telling starts before the mouth."

She passed the cord to the youngest. He counted the knots twice and handed it on. Each listener did the same. They knew what the nine meant: eight parts accepted without quarrel, one part won because a man named Aren would not put his hand to forever.

"Before we were we," Oss began, "the plateau folk came up from roads where names could kill. They brought seed, tools, pieces of machines, and more grief than all of it. Some had burned one another's houses. Some had watched. Some had kept count so their children might finish the work. On the high ground they built walls together because winter gave no care to who had begun which harm."

This much Oss spoke plainly. The Rim did not soften the world below the plateau. To do so would make refusal seem easy, and nothing about the first refusing had been easy.

"When the walls held, the folk made the Compact. They made a Store to take copies of what each person carried and to weave a common account from them. Not to empty the head. Mark it. We never say that foolishness here. A grief stays with the one who gives it. What changes lives between people."

A boy near the flue nodded too quickly. His older sister nudged his boot.

"Most in the signing room wanted the Store's hand broad," Oss continued. "They had seen what a narrow peace cost. Aren wanted the peace too. He helped lower the first keeping boxes under stone. He set his own shoulder beneath the ropes. We remember that because an opponent made simple is an opponent made false."

At the third knot, she lifted one hand. The listeners answered together, the words learned before any of them had understood their use.

"What begins in need must answer after need."

"Aren said it first," Oss told them. "Not in those words exactly. His words were longer, being room words. He asked for a review in fifty years and an ending in a hundred unless the city freely chose again. He said power forgets it began as an answer. He said a peace no one may question teaches obedience and calls the teaching calm."

That sentence Oss remembered with perfect confidence. Her mother's voice remained inside it, dry and low. Behind her mother came another voice Oss could almost hear, then another. Each had preserved Aren at the table with his shortened hand laid on the paper, asking tired people to trust descendants they would never meet.

Fire shifted through a pocket of resin. Sparks climbed and went dark under the smoke hole.

"Did they hear him?" asked the youngest.

"They heard." Oss touched the fourth knot. "Hearing is no promise of agreement. People in that room had buried children because old injuries kept walking. They thought an ending written into peace would teach their children to wait for the ending. They voted Aren down."

The listeners knew what followed. Still, Oss gave the pause its full measure. A memory carried by mouth needed silences in fixed places, or the teller might run past what hurt.

"Then they bargained," she said. "Fifty years for review. A hundred for free choice. The ninth part carried both. Aren signed. Others signed. Nobody left believing the Compact had no edge."

Here the old telling divided.

One line said the first uncoupled rose in the signing room and walked away before the lamps were lowered. Another said they remained twelve years, until Aren's petition became a clerk's small note and the Store taught the city that no principled objection had occurred. A third placed the walk between those events and gave no season. Oss had heard all three. She gave the children the line her mother had given her.

"Our people walked when they understood the city could keep an objection under stone while taking it from common speech. They carried no Store. They carried one another's accounts."

No child asked how many walked. Oss was grateful for that. The count changed according to which family spoke. In a winter version, forty-three crossed the southern boundary together, sharing tools and salt. In an older summer version, eleven left first, and six returned before harvest. Two were said to have gone only after a grain judgment turned against them. At least one had worked on the Store and feared blame for work willingly done. The Rim called all of them the First Refusers.

Oss did not tell the children about the six who returned.

Neither did she tell them that some who stayed beyond the boundary had first tried to burn a mirror post. No flame took; rain had soaked the kindling. The deed survived in a private line held by three elder houses and spoken only when those houses met. It was not a useful memory for a fourteen-year-old learning why refusal could carry honor. Honor, Oss had learned, sometimes needed a sheltered beginning.

Instead she said, "They built where the routed light ended. Vell called them uncoupled because they would not give memory into the common keeping. We kept the word. Better an insult worn plain than a fine name that hides its stitching."

"Were we right?" the tall girl asked.

The elder turned that question as she turned a root before cutting rot from it. A quick yes pleased children and weakened adults.

"We were alive," she said. "We kept the objection. That is what this telling can prove."

From the far bench, a small child who had come only because his brother watched him whispered Aren's name into his sleeve. Oss heard and pretended otherwise.

Years earlier, her own teacher had stopped at this point and dismissed the

circle. Oss had stayed to help bank the hearth. In the dim room, when they were alone, the teacher told her that early Rim tellers had changed more than dates. They moved every frightened departure into daylight. They made each disputed tool a willing gift. They turned those who drifted out for hunger, quarrel, punishment, or love into citizens who had chosen one clean refusal. Without that cleaning, the first settlement might not have held through its second winter. Families required a reason to share roofs with families they distrusted. Children required a history that did not hand them their grandparents' feuds.

"You will tell enough," her teacher had said. "Enough is not all."

Oss understood the mercy and feared the permission. She practiced what the Rim called curation, the quiet care of choosing what a people may safely carry. For many years she kept the hidden lines exactly, repeating them alone on the longest night. Then two details escaped her: which house had withheld a seed measure, and whether the mirror-post story belonged before the first winter or after it. She found she could still teach without them. The discovery shamed her for a season and comforted her after.

Now seven young faces watched from beyond the hearth. These children would have to mend roofs together. They would marry across old accusations if they were lucky. They would face citizens from the plateau who spoke of the Rim as if refusal had preserved every memory whole. Oss could have corrected that claim before it was made. She could have laid the room open, with its cowardice, theft, compromise, and useful rearrangements.

She touched the eighth knot instead.

"What did we carry?"

"The objection," they answered.

"What did the objection keep?"

"The choice to ask again."

At the ninth knot, the cord returned to Oss. Its fibers had warmed in seven pairs of hands. She wound it around her palm, covering one knot at each turn, until only the last could be seen.

Outside, wind pressed the roof grass flat and lifted it again. The youngest listeners went to fetch the night wood. Two argued softly over who had counted the knots wrong. Oss stayed by the hearth and watched them pull on their coats, certain Aren's door would remain wherever those hands carried it.

When the room had emptied, she put the cord back beside her knee. Beneath her thumb, the other eight knots rested out of sight.

Part 3

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael formally petitions the Circle to restore the Founding objection + lost clauses to common memory; quotes the Store's justification. -->

Chapter 19 — The Petition

At the first hour of the autumn equinox, Sael Irdren set the three exhibits on her desk in the order she meant to file them and read them once more in that order, aloud in her head, the way she had been trained to read any contested passage before the city heard it.

To her left lay the unedited founding text, copied from the open shelf of the Underhold vault by Cael's hand the afternoon he had brought her the log, the binding pale, the ninth part intact, the Founder script plain and unornamented. In the center lay the fragment Elder Vey had pressed into her palm on the night of his death, the pale leaf no larger than her palm, the sunset clause in a hand she still did not recognise, the four hurried lines in the margin and the capital *A.* at the foot. To her right lay the transcription of the FY 12 settlement, the Store's own sentence in the Store's own flat civic voice, sworn before the Underhold seal. Three small exhibits. She had laid them out in the order the body would be asked to receive them: the foundation first, the inheritance second, the confession third.

Tomas had laid the small lamp to one side of the desk, so the light fell clean across the three leaves. He had been with her in the house since before dawn, brewing her tea, fetching the unedited from the lockbox, asking once whether she meant to file today and taking her silence for the answer she had not yet made aloud. She had answered him now by sitting down, by laying the leaves out, by opening the seal box and setting the brass seal on the blotting paper beside the pen. He had brought her pen without her asking. He always brought the pen.

"Read with me," she said, "and do not interrupt, because if I am interrupted I will begin again, and if I begin again I will not stop."

He came and stood at her shoulder. Sael read.

The first exhibit was the unedited founding text. She read it aloud in the Founder hand, the way the schools taught a daughter to read it at the rail, and she read it through the eight parts she had read a hundred times and on into the ninth, the Reservation of Review, which was not in the taught edition and which read, in the unedited and in her own reading now, *Let the Compact be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found, and may be ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth.* Her voice did not rise. The sentence did not need her voice to rise. The sentence had been written by hands that had believed the city would one day want to hear it, and she read it the way a hand lifts a thing that has been set down for a long time, gently, so the thing does not break in the lifting.

The second exhibit was the fragment. She read the body of the text first, the

Founder common script, the same hand as the unedited, *Let it be set upon the record that the Compact may, by the free vote of the city in the hundredth year of its Found, be brought to a close, and the city returned to its own keeping. Let the door stand open.* Then she read the marginal note, the four lines that had been written in a different ink and a different hand and at an angle, *We left the door. They closed it. Remember we left it.* Then she read the capital, *A.* She did not name it. The capital named itself, and the Circle would know who the A. was. The schools would know; the basin keepers would know; and the city would, in time, be told.

The third exhibit was the Store's sentence. She read it in the same flat civic voice the Store had used to write it, because any other voice would have been a softening and she had not come to soften.

A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.

She set the leaf down.

The room was quiet. The lamp burned. Outside, the mirrors on the eastern face had not yet begun to track, and the routed light of Vell still lay in the long pale channels it had laid the night before, waiting for the sun. Tomas stood at her shoulder and did not speak. He had listened the way a child listens to a parent saying the long speech that has been waiting all morning to be said, with the stillness of a person who has been asked to hold a thing and has held it.

Sael drew the petition form toward her from the right-hand stack, where she kept the unused leaves of the house office, stamped with the small seal of the Rememberer's appointment. She wrote the date in her own careful hand, the autumn equinox of FY 204, and she named the petition by the title she had given it the night she had decided its shape: *Petition to Restore the Reservation of Review and the Sunset Clause to Common Memory, and to Refer the Restored Clauses to the Free Vote of the City.*

She had drawn the petition narrowly. She had drawn it the way Cael had told her to draw it, the way Luthe had agreed to carry it across the valley, the way Saine had said she could teach without lying to her daughters, the way Pell could read without closing the basins, the way Mott could check with his own key, the way Dorr could take home to his ledger, the way Iren could let pass without bringing the rim through the gate, the way Haren could oppose in the Circle and not at the speaking mirrors. She had drawn it, in short, to fit through a Circle that had spent nine generations agreeing not to know what she was asking it to do today.

The three exhibits entered the petition in their order, citing the Underhold seal and the Underhold Keeper's countersign and the Underhold accession register where the page from the unedited had first been consulted by a Rememberer's petition in living memory. She named the FY 12 settlement by its date and by the volume in which it had been logged. She named the fragment by the name of the founder-line Keeper who had passed it and by the line in which it had been kept.

She did not name her own wound. She did not name Mire. The petition asked the city to remember a clause, not a grief. She had learned, in three years of Tithing beside other women's tears, that a grief named in the wrong place could empty a room of every other grief the room had come to lay down.

The request of the petition followed the exhibits in the same plain civic script she had been taught to keep when the office was speaking and not the woman.

That the Reservation of Review, the review clause as scheduled for the fiftieth year of the Found, and the sunset clause as scheduled for the hundredth, be restored to the taught charter in their original language; that the fact of the FY 12 settlement, in the words of the settlement as logged, be made part of the common memory of Vell; and that the restored charter, with its nine parts intact, be referred to the free vote of the city at a date to be set by the Circle, that the city may decide for itself whether the peace it lives inside is the peace the Founders signed or the peace the Store has since enlarged to fit itself.

She had not relitigated the founding quarrel. She had not named the disputants. She had not asked the Circle to apologise. An apology could only be made by way of an action, and the action had to be named before the apology could travel beside it. She had asked the city to remember only that an objection had been lodged and that the objection had been edited out, and she had left to the city the older question of whether the objection had been right. The city could carry that question. The City had always been able to carry it. The only thing the city had not been able to carry was the silence about whether there had been a question at all.

She wrote the closing sentence of the petition, the one a Rememberer wrote when she was done with a contested passage and was handing it over to the Circle's reading, and she signed the petition in her appointment hand and set the seal beside her signature and let it cool on the blotter.

The autumn equinox had chosen itself, as equinoxes do, for the long clarity of the mirror-pulses that would carry Luthe's copy of the petition across the valley to the Speaking Hall in Tarse the moment the Circle had received it. She had told Luthe she would file today. She had told him the hour. She had not told him the words, because the words were hers until the Circle had heard them.

She stood. Tomas, at her shoulder, straightened as she did, in the small unconscious unison of two bodies that have learned to move together at the office. She gathered the three exhibits in their order, the unedited on the bottom, the fragment in the middle, the Store's transcription on top, and set them inside the leather petition folder the office had kept since its founding, the folder that had been used by the eleven Rememberers before her and by no one for the founding, because no Rememberer had ever had to file a petition of this shape before.

The folder was heavier than she expected. It was not the exhibits, which were thin. It was the office the folder had carried.

She turned to Tomas.

"I am going to the Circle," she said. "I will file at the second bell. I will not need you in the hall. Stay here. If anyone asks, I have gone to the speaking mirrors. Do not speak the name of the petition to anyone before the Circle has heard it. Do not speak the name of the fragment. Do not speak the name of Vey in connection with the fragment. Today Vey is dead and I am filing a petition whose exhibits I have gathered from the open shelf. That is what you will say, and that is all."

"Yes, Rememberer."

She took up the folder, slung the office coat from the peg, felt the pocket lie flat against her ribs where the brass seal now sat cooling, and walked down the corridor toward the street door. The house was quiet. The morning was not yet a morning in the routed light. She stepped out into the pale and walked the long way to the Circle Hall through the upper terraces, where the mirrors were still and the city had not yet begun to move.

The Circle Hall lay at the centre of the upper terrace, a chamber of dressed stone whose high windows let in the morning by stages as the sun cleared the eastern ridge. The nine chairs of the Circle stood on their low dais in the curved order the Founders had set. The vacant chair at the far right had been Vey's. It had not been filled. Sael had asked that it not be filled this morning, because she did not want a stranger's body in the chair when the chamber heard what she was about to lay before it.

She took her stand at the speaker's rail, the low oak rail the Rememberer used by long custom when she petitioned the Circle on any matter touching the common memory. The rail was worn at the centre. None of the Rememberers before her had stood here on a morning like this, and Sael, who had been trained to think of the office as older than the woman, felt the office settle on her shoulders in the way that settled when it asked the woman to do a thing the office had never been asked before. She set the petition folder on the rail, opened it to the petition that lay on top of the three exhibits, and let the folder hang open at the correct page while the Circle took their chairs and the chamber settled to its morning quiet.

Cael was the first to arrive. He came through the western door with his measured pace and his underhold key at his belt, and he inclined his head to her in the small morning formality, and he took his chair without speaking. Luthe came after, with the speaking-mirror clerk at his shoulder, carrying the morning's first pulse from Tarse on a small silver tray. Luthe set the tray on the receiving plate, spoke a soft word to the clerk, and took his chair. Pell came next, with the basin-house smell still faintly on her coat. Mott arrived in the same minute, the arithmetician, with a pencil behind his ear. Saine came from the school, still wearing the apron she wore at the daughters' first reading. Dorr and Iren came together, the counter and the gatekeeper, and took their chairs at the ends. Haren was the last. He came in through the eastern door, walked to his chair without looking at her, and sat.

Nine chairs in their curved order. Eight keepers in their seats. The chair at Vey's place empty. Sael let the chamber hold the empty chair for a moment before she began.

"Keepers," she said. "I file today a petition under the office of the Rememberer, signed by the office and cosigned by the Keeper of the Underhold, in the form prescribed by the Compact for the restoration of any clause or compact provision that has lapsed from common memory. I file it on the autumn equinox so that the Mirror Keeper may carry a copy to Tarse at the first clear pulse of the morning. The petition is narrow. It restores a clause. It does not relitigate a quarrel. It refers the restored clause to the free vote of the city, as the Founders wrote it, in the hundredth clause. I will read the petition, and the three exhibits, in order. I will read them once. I ask the Circle to receive them, and to take them under advisement, and to set a date for the free vote of the city at the Circle's earliest sitting at which the date may be lawfully fixed."

She did not look at Haren. She did not look away from Haren. She looked at the Circle as a body, the way a Rememberer looked at a body at the rail.

Cael, at her left, rose and added his signature to the bottom of the petition, under the seal, in the steadying hand she had seen him use when he had stamped the underhold seal on the page the day before. The chamber was very quiet.

Sael read.

She read the petition through once, plainly, in the voice she kept for the rail, the voice that did not rise and did not soften. She read the request of the petition as she had written it, the nine clauses restoring the ninth part, the Store's edit logged in the Store's own words, the free vote referred to the city at a date to be set. When she had finished the petition she read the unedited founding text, the first exhibit, citing the underhold accession register and the founder hand and the volume on the open shelf, and she read the ninth part aloud, *Let the Compact be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found, and may be ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth*, and the chamber did not stir. She read the second exhibit, the fragment, the body and the marginal note and the capital, and she named the keeper whose line had kept it and did not name him further, because the line had a right to its privacy at the moment of its passing. She read the third exhibit, the Store's sentence, in the Store's own voice, and the chamber took it the way Tomas had taken it that morning, in stillness, because a sentence read twice in one day does not change by being read again.

She closed the folder.

She spoke to the Circle once more. "Keepers," she said, "the petition is filed. I lay it before the Circle."

The folder went onto the rail in front of the chair of the Underhold Keeper, who was its procedural custodian by long custom. Sael stepped back from the rail one pace, the way a Rememberer stepped back when she had finished a contested reading and was leaving the contested thing to the room.

Mott was the first to speak.

"The underhold accession register, Cael. The page and the volume."

"The volume is FY 0, founding shelf, item seven," Cael said. "Item seven ends on that page. The accession register has the consultation note added under my hand yesterday evening."

"I will look at the volume this afternoon, with my own key."

"You are welcome to it, Keeper."

Saine wept, in the open quiet she had wept when Sael had come to her school, and did not speak.

Dorr said, "I will sit with this tonight. My ledger has agreed with the common record for thirty-one years. I would like to be sure of the agreement before I sign a vote that may change it."

Luthe said, "The clause will carry across the valley on the second clear pulse, in the form I have been given. I will not delay it."

Pell did not speak. Her hand lay on the rail at her side, and Sael understood the hand as a kind of answer the hand would later speak in writing.

Haren did not speak.

Iren said, "The vote is between Vell and itself."

The chamber was quiet a long moment. Sael did not move from the step she had stepped back to. She let the quiet be the quiet of a chamber that had received a thing it had not yet decided to carry. Then she inclined her head to the Circle, the way a Rememberer inclined her head when she was leaving a contested reading to the room's slower reading, and she walked down from the dais and out through the western door into the morning that had, by the time she came through the door, begun.

The mirrors on the eastern face were awake. The light lay across the upper terrace in long pale channels, and Luthe's clerk was already at the speaking mirror with the petition open on a reading stand, the silver tray set on the receiving plate, the morning pulse waiting to be carried across the valley. Sael walked down through the terrace toward her house. She did not look back at the hall. She did not look back at the chair that was Vey's. She let the morning have its routed light, and let the city begin.

When she reached her house, Tomas stood at the corridor door, his hands at his sides. He did not ask her how it had gone, because the office of the assistant was to read the woman's face and to fetch the tea in the appropriate minute and to say nothing until the woman spoke. He went to fetch the tea.

Sael went up to her study and closed the door. She set the empty folder on the desk, the folder that had carried the three exhibits down to the Circle and now held only the air they had breathed. She did not open the lockbox. She did not sit at the desk. She went to the small window that looked down on the upper basin, where

the morning queue had just begun to form, the first daughter of the day waiting at the rail for her first Tithe, the gel catching the early light in a flat silver line.

The basin would do what the basin did. The basins had been doing it all morning. The basins would do it this afternoon. The petition would take its time through the Circle, and the city would take its time after the Circle, and the time would be the city's, because that was the whole of what she had asked: that the city be given back the time it had not been asked to keep. She stood at the window and watched the daughter at the rail step forward to the gel, watched the basin take the first small grief of the morning, and below her on the terrace the speaking mirror flashed a pale pulse across the valley, and somewhere in the receiving hall of Tarse a clerk was unrolling the petition under a foreign light, and the city that had lived nine generations without knowing it had asked itself a question was about to be asked the question by its own hand.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: The Circle votes on Sael's petition; Nethe as witness; Haren's honest opposition; passes narrowly. -->

Chapter 20 — The Circle Votes

The Circle chamber was built into the spine of the founder-line quarter, where the houses were older than the surrounding stone. Sael had walked its corridor a hundred times on business that asked for a Rememberer's seal and returned it without ceremony. She had never walked it with her office coat pulled straight and a folded fragment in the inner pocket and the Store's flat sentence on the second paper beside it, the two of them against her ribs the way two small stones sit in a closed hand. She had asked Tomas to stay in the lower hall with the witnesses.

The witness alcove opened off the corridor at the chamber's second door. Nethe was already on the low bench the Founders had set into the wall for citizens who came to listen to a thing they could not vote on, her rim coat on, hands loose on her knees.

"They have already let me in," Nethe said. "I have been sitting since the first bell. I came to listen. The petition says the city should know a person from the Rim has lived inside an unedited memory for nineteen years without a knife in the kitchen. I am the kitchen."

Sael nodded. She did not say thank you, because Nethe would have read the thanks as pity. Sael went on to the chamber door.

The door was founder cedar, dark with age, and it stood already open. Cael Orrin was inside, at his chair, hands folded, his face doing the precise work it did when a contested document was about to be read aloud. He looked up when Sael entered, and the look was not that of a colleague greeting a colleague but of a man who

had decided to do a thing and was sitting inside the having decided. Sael set her papers on the table. She did not sit yet. Vey's chair, opposite the door, was empty. The founder-line cousin who held the seat by standing order sat in the next chair down, a woman of about sixty whose name Sael had never quite learned, holding the place with the only office she had been given.

The chamber filled in its order. Luthe came from the Mirror Hall, Pell from the House of Tithes with her hands faintly of gel, Saine from the upper school with chalk pale at her cuff, Dorr from the granaries, Mott from the counting house with his ledger under his arm. Iren came last from the rim gate, in the dust of the southern road, and sat nearest the door with the economy of a man who had walked far and meant to walk far again.

Haren was already seated, in the peace-warden's chair that faced the door, hands flat on the table in the position she remembered from two years ago and from the morning after. The framed eight-part charter hung above his chair on the eastern wall. Sael had promised herself, on the walk up, not to look at it, a small private office a person keeps when the public office is about to cost them something they cannot yet name.

Cael called the Circle to order. Nine chairs, eight occupied, the empty ninth holding the shape of the man who had sat in it three weeks ago and had pressed a torn piece of paper into a Rememberer's hand and had let the evening take him. Sael stood at the head of the table and let the silence hold, and then she opened the petition.

"Keepers," she said. "I file, in the form prescribed by the Compact, a petition to restore to common memory the ninth part of the founding charter, called the Reservation of Review, together with the sunset clause named within it, and to instruct the Store to publish, by the speaking mirrors and at the next civic broadcast, the unedited text of the relevant clauses, and the unedited log of the edit that removed them in the twelfth year of the Found. The petition is cosigned by Cael Orrin, Keeper of the Underhold, and supported, with conditions noted, by Luthe, Saine, Pell, and Dorr. It is opposed by Haren, Keeper of the Peace. Mott has reserved his position. Iren will not vote on a matter he considers to be between the city and itself."

Cael took up the second paper and read the Store's sentence aloud in the Store's own voice, which was his own voice drained of metaphor and second person, the civic tone the Founders had trusted and the Store had inherited.

"Record of edit. Year twelve of the Found, seventh of the seventh month. The objection entered by Keeper-First Aren and the minority faction is settled as follows. The clauses providing for the review of the Compact at the fiftieth year and for the ending of the Compact by the free vote of the city at the hundredth year are merged into the body of the charter as procedural notes of historical interest, and the body of the charter is republished in its amended form. Reason for edit. A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We

closed the objection."

The sentence sat in the room. Luthe's pen scratched once at his notes and stopped. Saine's hand went to the chalk at her cuff, a teacher who had just heard a thing she would teach tomorrow. Pell's eyes were closed, the way a Keeper of the Tithe closes them when a citizen at the rail has spoken a grief the city was not prepared to receive. Mott looked at his ledger, but his hand was not on the page. Dorr had lifted his head to the framed eight-part charter, the way a granary-keeper looks at a tally he has signed for thirty-one years and has only now been told was the wrong tally.

Cael set the paper down. "The edit is recorded in the Store's own hand, in the Underhold, under the seal of the office I keep. I have read it. The charter taught to every child at the rail, in my city, for nine generations, is missing its ninth part. The petition restores the missing part and instructs the Store to publish the fact of the edit. I cosign it and I will speak for it."

He sat. Sael looked at Haren.

Haren's opposition sat in the room like a tool left on a workbench, the thing that had done the day's hardest work and would be needed again. Sael had learned, in the two years since the foundering, to read Haren's face as the city's own weather, and the weather now was not storm but the grey of a held rain. She had filed expecting this speech. She had not expected, she saw now, to be moved by it.

"I oppose the petition," he said. "I oppose it on the grounds I gave the Rememberer two years ago, and which I give again, because the grounds have not changed and the peace they protect has not changed, and the cost I named then is the cost I name now. The peace is real. The peace was bought by an edit. The peace will not survive the telling of the edit. If we restore the clauses, the founding quarrel rises. If the founding quarrel rises, the smoothing is reversed. If the smoothing is reversed, the terraces quiet for three generations become the terraces the Store smoothed them out of. A person will suffer. A name will surface that should have stayed in the Underhold. A child will learn a sentence at the rail that will travel home and sit in a kitchen and break something the kitchen was not built to break."

He was quiet a moment.

"I do not say the Rememberer is wrong. I say she is right, and her rightness will cost us something we cannot yet measure. The peace-warden's office is to measure what the city can bear, and what it can bear is not, in my judgment, the full weight of the clauses on a single morning. I would have preferred the clauses taught gently, over a generation, as a teaching and not a correction. The petition asks for a broadcast. A broadcast is not a teaching. A broadcast is a wound opened in public."

He looked across the table at Sael, and the looking was not unkind.

"I will oppose the petition in the schools and at the basin. I will not oppose it in

Tarse. The Mirror Keeper's condition is accepted by me. If Vell is to be told of the edit, Vell should be the first voice to tell it. I will not be the reason it is not. That is the most I can offer, and I offer it without condition."

He sat. The chamber was quiet. Sael had known, when she filed, that Haren's opposition would be the most expensive in the room, because it was the most sincere.

Pell rose, the way she rose at the rail when a citizen had brought a grief the basin was not sure it could hold.

"I am torn," she said. "I have been torn since the Rememberer first spoke to me, and I do not expect the tornness to end today. The Tithe is not optional in Vell. It is the city's quiet. If the petition passes, the city will learn the Tithe has a second operation, the edit, and citizens will come to the rail and ask me whether the settlement phrase is a lifting or a smoothing. I will have to answer them honestly. I do not yet know what that costs at the basin."

She walked to the small private rail the Tithe Keeper kept for rehearsals and put her hand on it the way she had in her own office a week ago. The rail was cool under her palm.

"The Rememberer has drawn the petition narrowly. The basins are not closed. They are kept open, with their second operation named. I can live with that. I vote yes."

She sat. Luthe spoke next, briefly.

"The condition I offered stands. The petition, if granted, must be carried to Tarse in the same beam the city uses for its apology. Tarse has noticed the drift. Tarse will not be told by us after the broadcast. Tarse will be told by us at the same hour, with the same text, in the same flat voice. I vote yes, with the condition recorded."

Saine spoke after Luthe, her speech the shortest in the chamber, because teachers learned to say things once.

"I have taught the eight-part charter for nineteen years, as the Founders wrote it. I am now told the Founders were not of one mind. I do not doubt the Rememberer. I doubt what I have done for nineteen years, which is a worse doubt. The petition asks the city to be told what I should have told it at the rail. I vote yes. I will also ask the Circle, in writing, what I am to teach the daughters tomorrow. I will teach the eight-part charter as the taught version of a charter whose taught version is in dispute. Quietly, because the daughters deserve a teacher who is not lying."

She sat. The chamber turned, by habit, to Mott, whose office was the verification of numbers and whom the chamber had learned to wait for on contested counts. Mott opened his ledger, looked at the page as if it might advise him, and closed it again.

"I have read the Store's log," he said. "With my own key, in the Underhold. The log is dated. It names the clauses and the Store as the agent of the edit, but

names no Keeper and no Circle. The Store acted under its standing mandate, the document I have spent my office counting on. If I vote yes, I override the Store's authority with my own sums. If I vote no, I ask the city to keep a count I have verified wrong."

He set his ledger on the table. It made a small, dry sound against the wood.

"I am not ready to override the Store. I am also not ready to keep the count I have verified wrong. I vote no, not because the petition is unjust, but because I cannot be the arithmetician who overturns a count his office was built to keep."

Two no's were in the room, Haren's and Mott's, and the founder-line cousin had not yet spoken, and Dorr had not yet spoken. Sael felt the count in her ribs the way she had felt the fragment and the log, two small weights pressing against each other.

The founder-line cousin spoke in the careful voice of a person holding a place.

"I hold the seat by standing order, in trust. I have read the petition and the log. I have counted the eight-part charter above the peace-warden's chair, the way I have counted many things, and the count is eight. The count in the Underhold is nine. I will not be the holder of a seat who overturns the count the seat was raised on. I vote no."

Three no's. Sael let the count settle, the way a stone settles into the place it has been waiting. Three no's and three yes's, and Dorr not yet spoken, and Iren not voting. The chamber held the breath a chamber holds when a single vote will decide whether a thing is mandated or merely asked.

Dorr stood, a small man with the dust-colored coat of a granary-keeper, hands at his sides, eyes on the table, because he did not like to be looked at when he weighed a thing and had been weighing this one for a week.

"I keep the granary ledger," he said. "For thirty-one years. The ledger agreed with the common record for thirty-one years. I did not know they were the same ledger. The common record said the city signed a Compact in one voice. The Underhold said the city signed in two voices and put one of them in a drawer. The drawer was in my office. The drawer was in every office. The drawer was in the eight-part count I have signed for thirty-one years."

He was quiet a moment. The quiet was what a granary-keeper takes when he counts in his head and does not like what the count tells him, because it tells him the number he has kept was the Store's and not the field's.

"I told the Rememberer I would think on it. I have. The granary does not lie. The field does not lie. The field grew what it grew. The ledger recorded what it was told. If the ledger has recorded what the Store told it and not what the field grew, the ledger is wrong, and a wrong ledger is worse than none, a quiet lie the granary-keeper signs every morning with his own hand. I will not sign a wrong ledger. I vote yes."

He sat. The chamber counted. Five yes. Three no. One not voting. Sael heard the

count land, the way a person hears a thing land that they have carried uphill for a season. Cael looked at her. She looked at Iren.

Iren shook his head once, the way he shook it at the rim gate when a citizen asked for a pass he had not been authorized to give. "I do not vote," he said. "The vote is between Vell and itself."

The chamber sat with the count for a long moment. Sael did not move. Cael did not move. The framed page hung in its frame, the taught version, the count the city had been living inside. It would be taken down before the broadcast, or left up with the ninth part taught alongside it, the way a scar is taught alongside the skin that grew over it, as a thing the city carried because it had earned the carrying. Sael did not know which the Circle would choose. She knew the Circle had chosen the mandate, and the mandate was enough for the morning.

"Mandate," Cael said, in the formal voice of a Keeper of the Underhold, reading the chamber's decision into the exact record the Founders had trusted. "The Circle, by majority, instructs the Store to restore to common memory, at the next civic broadcast, the ninth part of the founding charter, called the Reservation of Review, together with the sunset clause named within it, and to publish, in the same broadcast, the unedited log of the edit by which those clauses were removed in the twelfth year of the Found. The Circle instructs the Mirror Keeper to carry the same text to Tarse in the same beam, the Keeper of the Schools to revise the taught charter at the rail, and the Keeper of the Tithe to amend the settlement phrase at the next Tithe, in the form the Tithe Keeper shall propose and the Circle shall approve. The mandate is recorded. The mandate stands."

Sael let the words sit in the room. The empty chair between the founder-line cousin and Pell held Vey's shape, and the shape would be filled, in time, by a keeper raised on a charter that included the ninth part, the raising different from anything the founder-line had known for nine generations, and the difference would be the city's memory of the cost it had paid to be told.

The chamber emptied in its order. Haren left first by the eastern door, his pace that of a man who had lost a vote he expected to lose and meant to walk the borders of his loss for the day. Mott followed with his ledger. The founder-line cousin slipped out toward the founder houses. Luthe stood a moment with his hand on the back of his chair, looking at the framed page, then left for the Mirror Hall, where the receiving plate waited for a beam that would carry more than light.

Cael came to her side and laid his hand briefly on the table beside hers, the closest a Keeper of the Underhold could come, in a public chamber, to acknowledging that the office beside him had carried a thing uphill and set it down. Sael let the hand lie where it lay. She let the chamber empty around her. The empty chair kept its shape.

She went at last to the witness alcove. Nethe was still on the bench, hands on her knees, the rim coat on her shoulders. She looked up, and the looking was not a question but the look of a person who had heard the chamber empty and knew

what an empty chamber meant.

"It passed," Sael said.

"I know," Nethe said. "I heard the doors. A chamber that has passed a thing empties in an order. The no's leave first, then the torn, then the yes's. The not-voting leave last, because they walk past the yes's and the no's on the way out. I have sat here long enough to know the order."

Sael sat beside her. The barley-water cup was still at Nethe's elbow, half-drunk.

"It will strain," Sael said. "Haren is right about that. The peace will not be the same after the broadcast. It will be a peace that knows its own objection and must choose every morning to keep itself. That is not the peace the Founders taught us."

"No," Nethe said. "It is the peace the Founders signed. The peace they taught was the peace the Store taught. The peace they signed was a peace with a door. You have put the door back. The city will have to learn how to stand in a room with a door."

She inclined her head. She did not say thank you, because Nethe would not have wanted it, and the alcove was not a place for the small kinds of speeches. She let Nethe sit with her a quarter hour, then rose and walked back through the chamber to the cedar door, and through the corridor to the lower hall, where Tomas waited.

The routed mirrors threw the late-morning light down the eastern face in long, even channels. The light did not yet know what it was routing. The city did not yet know what it had decided. The mandate was recorded. The mandate stood. In a week the chamber would fill again to hear the form of the broadcast, and in a week after that the speaking mirrors would carry the ninth part into every kitchen on the plateau and across the valley to Tarse. The kitchens would hear a sentence unheard in nine generations, and the sitting would be the city's memory of the cost it had paid to be told.

Sael walked down the terraces in the pale light, the fragment in her pocket, the log in her pocket, the mandate in her coat. Vey's empty chair was behind her, holding its shape. The shape would be filled. The filling would be the city's memory of the cost of being told.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: The Circle (Haren's faction) searches Sael's house for the fragment; Tomas protects it. -->

Chapter 21 — The Search of the House

The mandate reached the Rememberer's house at the second hour after the vote,

carried not by a runner but by a clerk of the Circle whose face Sael had seen at four petitions and never once learned to read. Tomas took the folded leaf at the street door and brought it to her in the library without a word. She broke the small red seal and read the order twice, the way she read any contested passage, giving each clause its own breath. The Circle, acting under the standing mandate for the custody of evidence touching a matter before it, did hereby authorize a search of the Rememberer's house and office for the physical fragment referenced in the filed petition, that fragment being charter material held outside the Underhold and therefore subject to recovery by the office of the peace-warden. The order bore Haren's signature at the head, and below it the steadier hands of two keepers Sael had counted as torn, not lost. It named no time. An order that named no time was an order meant to be used at the moment of its bearer's choosing.

She set the leaf on the desk. The lamp Tomas had lit for the evening stood at her left hand, and the light fell across the order's red seal the way the routed mirrors fell across the terraces, even and without comment. Sael had expected this leaf. She had expected it since the morning she filed the petition, since Haren rose in the Circle and gave his no in the open, since the vote passed by a margin she could count on the fingers of one hand. A peace-warden who had told her he would oppose her in the schools and at the basin would not stop at the chamber door. He would come for the fragment. He would come lawfully, with an order, because Haren was the kind of man who kept the law even when he used the law to keep the peace he loved.

"Tomas."

He was at the library threshold, as he always was when a thing was nearly ready and he would not presume to touch it. "Rememberer."

"Read the order. Then go to the kitchen and stay there until I call you. If anyone asks, you have not seen this leaf."

He took it. She watched his eyes move down the lines, the careful hand she had come to trust with salt and tea and the morning's first cup, moving now over words that concerned the safety of a thing he had helped her carry down to the Circle and back. His face did not change, but his thumb came to the edge of the paper and held it, the way a person holds a rail they mean to keep.

"Do they have the right to come in, Rememberer?"

"They have the order. An order signed by the peace-warden and two keepers is the right, in Vell, until the Circle says otherwise. Go to the kitchen."

He went. Sael rose and went to the small wooden box where she kept the fragment, the original of her appointment lot, and the seal she had used on the petition. The box sat in the second drawer of her desk, under the unedited logs she had been reading. She opened it with the key she kept in her pocket. The fragment lay inside, the pale torn rectangle, the Founder hand, the four angled lines in Aren's quicker ink, the single capital at the foot. She had read it a hundred times since Vey passed it to her. She had carried it in her coat to the Circle and back. She

had filed the petition named for it. Now the Circle had named it back, as evidence, and the naming was a first move in a game whose second move she had not yet decided.

She closed the box. She did not lock it. She left the key in the drawer, in plain sight, the way a person leaves a thing they mean to be found. Then she went to the window that looked down on the upper basin and stood with the curtain open, watching the terrace go dark in the slow blue that came after the mirrors stilled.

The knock came at the fourth hour. It was not the single hesitant knock of a man with a grief. It was three measured strikes, the knock of an officer at a door he meant to enter. Tomas had been in the kitchen for two hours; she had not called him. She went to the street door herself and opened it a hand's width, the way Tomas had been taught to open it, the way a Rememberer opened a door to a thing she had been expecting.

Haren stood on the step. He wore his office coat, the plain grey, and behind him stood two men Sael did not know by name, keepers' deputies by their bearing, and a fourth figure she did know, a clerk from the underhold registry whose presence meant the search would be logged as procedure and not as raid. Haren's face held the precise neutrality of his court, the calm civic surface he turned to every citizen who brought a grievance into the public record. He did not look like a man who had come to do harm. He looked like a man who had come to do his office.

"Rememberer. I hold an order of the Circle, signed this evening, authorizing a search of this house for the charter fragment named in your petition. I am required to execute it now."

"Now, peace-warden?"

"Now. The order names no hour. I have chosen this one."

She stepped back from the door. Not because she had been compelled, but because the door belonged to the city, and the order belonged to the city, and she had spent three years learning which fights were hers to refuse and which were hers to lose in a way that left the office intact. "The house is open to the Circle's order. I will ask that you conduct the search with the respect due the Rememberer's office, and that you take nothing the order does not name."

"I will take only the fragment." Haren stepped in. The deputies followed. The underhold clerk remained on the threshold with a small book open in his hand, ready to write what he saw. "Tomas," Haren said, without raising his voice. "You will remain in the kitchen while the search proceeds."

Sael had not heard Tomas come from the kitchen. He was there, though, at the mouth of the corridor, his hands at his sides, the way he stood at a birth or a death or any moment he had not yet learned the right gesture for. "The Rememberer has not called me, peace-warden."

"Stay there. This is a matter of the Circle, not the household."

Tomas did not move. He did not sit. He did not speak again. He simply stood at

the mouth of the corridor, between the kitchen and the library, a young man of twenty-three with no authority the Circle would name, holding the threshold the way he held the salt jar and the morning tea, as a thing given into his care. Sael felt the small exact pressure behind her eyes that preceded a finding she would rather not make, and she understood, in that moment, that Tomas was not going to let them through the corridor without being asked to move, and that he would not be asked to move by Haren, who would not lay hands on a servant of the Rememberer's house when an order named only a fragment.

Haren began in the library. He went to the desk, opened the second drawer, and found the wooden box unlocked, the key beside it. He lifted the lid. Sael watched his face as he looked inside. The box held the appointment lot, the seal, and the unedited logs' index slab she had been copying. It did not hold the fragment. Haren's hands were steady. He set the lid down and looked at her.

"It is not here."

"I did not say it was."

He did not reply to that. He turned to the deputies. "Search the room. Drawers, shelf, the lockbox at the back. Log what you open."

The deputies moved with the competent boredom of men who had searched rooms before. They opened the desk drawers, the small library shelf, the lockbox that held only the petition's unused leaves. The underhold clerk wrote each opening in his book. Sael stood by the window and did not offer to help and did not offer to hinder. She had learned, in the years of Tithes she had witnessed, that the most important thing a citizen brought to the rail was what they sat with longest before speaking, and she sat now with the longest silence of her term, letting Haren's search proceed through the rooms she had made her own.

From the corridor mouth, Tomas had not moved. One deputy glanced at him as he passed toward the kitchen stairs, and Tomas's stance did not alter. He was not blocking the stair, precisely. He was standing in it, the way a door stands in a frame, present and unyielding and making no claim the law could name as obstruction. The deputy went around him without comment. Haren noticed, and his mouth tightened by a degree Sael had learned to read in their two years of acquaintance, the small contraction of a man who had met a resistance he could not lawfully answer.

They searched the upper chamber. They searched the small room where Ott the ferryman had once sat with his hat on his knee. They searched the petition room and the back kitchen, where Tomas had quietly retreated ahead of them and now stood at the slab with a cloth in his hand, as if the cleaning of the evening's cups were the only office the search had left him. Haren looked at the kitchen once and looked away. A peace-warden did not search a servant's hands.

The search took the better part of an hour. Sael used the hour the way she used a Tithe queue, watching the citizens wait, learning the shape of what they carried by the way they held themselves. Haren carried the order. The deputies carried the

boredom of procedure. The underhold clerk carried his book. Tomas carried the threshold, and the fragment, and Sael did not know which of the three he carried or where, only that he had not been searched and would not be, because the order named a fragment and not a boy.

When the deputies returned to the library, Haren stood before Sael with his hands at his sides, the neutrality of his face intact but strained at the corners, the way a wall holds when the foundation has shifted by a finger's width and the crack has not yet shown. "The fragment is not in this house, Rememberer."

"It was not in the box you opened, no."

"Where is it?"

"I am the Rememberer. I am charged with its safekeeping until the Circle directs otherwise. The petition you voted on this morning asks the Circle to direct otherwise, in the city's name. Until the Circle sits to set the date, the fragment is in the custody the office provides. I will not name that custody to you under an order that authorizes a search and not an interrogation."

He held her eyes. For a moment Sael thought he would press, that the peace-warden who had opposed her in the schools and at the basin would demand the place of the thing he had been sent to recover. But Haren was institutional before he was anything else. He had come with an order, and the order had been executed, and the order had failed to find what it named, and a man who loved procedure as Haren loved it would not exceed the order's writ to satisfy his own fear. He nodded once, the small trade-good nod of two offices that had reached the limit of what the paper allowed.

"I will report to the Circle that the fragment was not found in the Rememberer's house under search authorized this evening. The matter remains before the Circle."

"As it should."

He turned to the door. The deputies fell in behind him. The underhold clerk closed his book and followed, his writing done. At the threshold Haren paused, not quite looking back, and Sael saw the line of his shoulders under the grey coat, the posture of a man who had done his office and found it had not been enough, and who had known before he came that it would not be enough, and who had come anyway because the coming was his only lawful act left to him.

Then he was gone into the routed dark, and the house was quiet, and the only sound was the small tick of a mirror-track adjusting to a sun that had been gone for hours.

Sael went to the corridor mouth. Tomas still stood there, though the need for standing had passed with the searchers. She looked at him, and he looked at her, and for a long moment neither spoke, because the speaking would have named a thing that did not need naming, a loyalty that had just shown itself in the only language the house had ever used, the language of a body placed where the order

did not reach.

"Tomas."

"Rememberer."

"Where is the fragment?"

He did not look away. "In the kitchen, Rememberer. Behind the jars your mother kept the salt in, in the false back of the lowest shelf that the previous Rememberer built and no one has opened in the term. I moved it after you told me not to show the order to anyone. I moved it before they came. I did not tell you because you would have had to say you did not know, and I did not want you to have to say that to the peace-warden under his order."

She absorbed this the way she absorbed a Tithe, giving each part its own weight. Tomas had moved the fragment. He had moved it to a place the search would not reach because the search had gone through the rooms and not the jars, the basins and not the salt. He had done it without her instruction and without her knowledge, and he had done it because he had understood, before she had spoken the instruction, what the order was for and what it could not touch. The previous Rememberer had built the false back. Tomas had found it in his first week, cleaning, and had never mentioned it because Tomas mentioned little. He had simply known, as he knew the tea hour and the cup's place on the desk, that some things in the house were meant to be kept where the city's orders did not reach.

"How long have you known about the false back?"

"Since the second month. I clean the kitchen, Rememberer. The previous Rememberer's ledgers note the shelf was rebuilt in the term of Irdra, the fourth before you. I read the note. I did not think it would matter."

"It mattered tonight."

He nodded, once, the way Haren had nodded, the trade-good acknowledgment of a thing completed. Then he turned back to the slab and the evening's cups, and Sael understood that he would not ask for praise and would not be given it, because the praise would have been a kind of payment for a loyalty that was not for sale, and Tomas's loyalty was the kind that sat on him like something tried on and then never taken off.

She went back to the library. The desk drawer stood open, the wooden box within it empty of the thing it had been meant to hold. The appointment lot and the seal lay where Haren had left them, undisturbed, the way a man who respected the office would leave another office's tools. Sael closed the drawer. She sat at the desk and read the order once more, the red seal, the signatures, the plain civic script that named a fragment and not a person and therefore could not, by its own terms, have found what it sought.

The exposure was real. Haren now knew, as surely as a peace-warden could know without the object in hand, that she had removed the fragment from the house's obvious custody and placed it beyond the Circle's order. That was a

defiance, narrow and lawful and complete. She had not refused the search. She had simply not kept the searched thing where the search would land. The distinction contained the whole of her office in this hour, the difference between a Rememberer who held the unedited and a citizen who hid from the Circle. Haren would report the fragment not found. He would not report the Rememberer vanished, because the Rememberer had been present at every moment of the search, calm, in her own library, under her own lamp.

She thought of Vey, who had kept the scrap for ninety years and passed it on in the only hour left to him, who had said the decent ones were more dangerous than the frightened ones because the decent ones would try to do the right thing slowly and the slowly was what got a city into trouble it could not leave without losing something. Haren was decent. Haren had come lawfully and left lawfully and would report lawfully, and the fragment was safe because the decent man had been bound by the very order he had signed. Sael let the thought settle without warmth. It was not a victory. It was a condition, the way the terrace was a condition, the way the peace was a condition, something held in place by the shape of the thing that pressed on it.

Tomas brought her tea at the hour she had come to expect, set it on the edge of the desk a hand's breadth from the open drawer, and retreated to the doorway. She did not drink. She sat with the order and the empty box and the quiet of a house that had just been searched by the city and found to contain exactly what Sael chose to let it contain.

Outside, the mirrors tracked a sun that was not there, their small ticks marking the night's slow turn. Below the terrace a basin gave the silver sound of a late Tithe settling into the dark, a citizen setting down a grief the city would smooth or keep as the Store decided, under the mandate the Circle had given it and the Circle had just used to knock at her door. Sael listened to the sound and did not move. The fragment was in the salt shelf behind the jars, where the previous Rememberer had built a place the order could not find, and Tomas stood in the doorway with his hands at his sides, and the house held what it held, and the city would learn the rest of it in its own time, which was now a time the Circle had been asked to set and had not yet set, and the asking stood, and the fragment stood with it, small and warm and out of reach.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Sael connects Mire's private erasure to the civic erasure; forgives the Store even as she opposes it. -->

Chapter 22 — What Mire Paid

The fragment was safe. Sael had confirmed it twice that morning, once by her own hand in the lockbox and once by Tomas's report that the house search had left the

office folios undisturbed. She sat now in the quiet hour before the speaking mirrors would carry the restored memory across the plateau, and the quiet was not the city's calm but a different thing, the stillness of a basin after the citizen has walked away and before the Store decides what to keep. She had earned this quiet by surviving the search. She did not intend to spend it on relief.

She meant to spend it on Mire.

The thought arrived without the old pain. That was the first thing she noticed, and it was the strangest. For thirteen years the thought of her sister had come wrapped in the ache of having been unseen, a private wound she had refused to Tithe because the refusing was her only act left to her. Now, in the hour before the broadcast, the ache was present but it lay flat, the way a folded cloth lies flat once it has been unfolded and looked at and set down again. She had not expected the looking to change the cloth. She had only meant, tonight, to look.

Mire had paid.

That was the sentence Sael had never written. She had written around it in the old dark of chapter three, had named the cost, the weight, the kitchen, the Tuesday, had said that the price of Mire's peace had been a sister levied on Sael, but she had not until this hour set the two ledgers side by side and added them in the same column. The Store had edited the city's founding. The Store had edited Mire's mind. Both edits had been presented as the memory having always been thus. Both edits had been made for peace. Both edits had cost something that the peace preferred to call absent.

The ledger Mire had kept sat on its low shelf behind the office folios, cloth-bound and soft at the spine. Sael had not opened it in thirteen years. She had touched its spine in the dark on the night she found the ninth part, and had not opened it then either. Tonight she did not open it. The not-opening had become, over the years, a discipline rather than a fear, the way a Rememberer keeps the unedited sealed until the Circle wills it read. She knew what the book contained. She had watched Mire write it. The book served as proof that the hand had not been softened even when the mind had, and the proof had never needed reading to be true.

She turned her attention instead to the shape of the two erasures, the civic and the private, laid one beside the other on the desk of her mind the way she had once laid the three exhibits of the petition in their order.

The civic erasure had been broad. The Store, under its standing mandate, had taken the Reservation of Review from the taught charter and had taught the city that the Compact was eternal and unanimous, that no objection had been lodged, that the door the Founders left open had never been built. Generations had lived inside that taught calm. The erasure had been systematic, patient, and presented without announcement, the edit wearing the face of the original so that the citizen who recited the eight-part charter believed she recited the whole.

The private erasure had been narrow. A Tithe offered for the terror of a winter had softened, by a rare complication, the memory of Sael in Mire's mind, until Mire

looked through her sister as through a window into a room she was not certain she had been in. The edit had worn the face of the original too. Mire had not believed she had lost a sister. Mire had believed she had always been a polite woman who offered tea to a young visitor from the terrace below. The forgetting had felt, to Mire, like nothing at all.

Sael saw the mechanism underneath both. The Store had not deleted. It had copied, and then it had edited the record, and then it had presented the edit as the thing that had always stood. In Mire's case the record was a single private mind, and the editing had been a complication no one intended. In the city's case the record was common memory, and the editing had been a standing mandate no one had stopped. The scale differed. The shape did not. A chosen forgetting, presented as if it had never been a choosing.

She had understood this in chapter three. She had written then that the act she refused at seventeen and the act the Store performed on the ninth part were not different in kind. What she had not done then, because the petition had not yet been filed and the Circle had not yet voted and the broadcast had not yet loomed, was to follow the understanding to its patient end.

A detail returned to her from the old reading, one she had not weighed before. The Store did not announce its edits. It presented each changed thing as if the change had been the original, so that the citizen who encountered the smoothed memory felt no seam, no moment of loss, nothing to grieve because nothing had, by the record, ever been there. Mire's complication had worked the same way. The softening had not announced itself either. It had crept along the wall around the Tithed winter until Sael, who had not been Tithed, noticed that her sister addressed her with the blankness of a stranger, and by then the gap was years wide and Mire stood on the far side of it believing she had always been there. Neither the city nor Mire had been given the chance to grieve, because neither had been told there was a thing to lose. The mercy and the violence lived in that same omission. To be spared the pain of a loss you never learn you suffered is also to be denied the dignity of mourning it.

Sael turned the omission in her mind the way she had once turned the ninth part, giving each face of it a separate breath. The Founders had feared that a remembered objection would reopen the old world's cycles of atrocity and retaliation. The Store had feared, in its flat civic way, the same thing, and had removed the objection from memory rather than from law. Mire had feared nothing. Mire had simply Tithed a winter and been taken further than the basin had any right to take her. The intent ranged from the civic to the accidental, and the result at the bottom was one shape: a person or a people, looking out at a diminished world and calling it whole, because the wholeness had been edited into the floor they stood on.

The end was forgiveness.

Not excuse. She was careful with that line, the way a Rememberer is careful

with the seam between two readings that look alike. To excuse the Store would be to say the edit had been right, that the city was better for forgetting its own objection, that Mire had been better for forgetting her sister. Sael would not say that. She had petitioned the Circle to restore the clause. She had risked her office and Tomas had stood between the fragment and the search. She opposed the Store's edit with her whole office and her whole term. Opposition was the action. Forgiveness was something else, and she had only now, in the quiet before the mirrors, come to see that the two could inhabit the same breast without contradiction.

The Store had acted from protection.

She had read its sentence in the flat civic voice and had not softened it: *A peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.* The sentence was not a confession of malice. It was a statement of a logic the Founders themselves had seeded, when they granted the Store a standing mandate to edit common memory for peace. The Store had closed the objection because it had been built to close objections, the way a basin had been built to receive a grief and return a relief. The mandate had been broad enough to swallow the founding. The Store had only done what the Compact asked of it, past the point the Compact's authors had imagined.

And Mire. Mire had not been protected by the Store. Mire had been harmed by a complication the Store did not intend and did not prevent. But Sael, in refusing the Tithe of her own grief, had done to herself the same kind of thing the Store had done to the city. She had chosen a forgetting she would not perform. She had carried the weight on purpose, because the carrying was her only way to keep Mire real. Her refusal had been protection of a sort, protection of the truth of her sister against the calm the basin would have offered. The Store had protected the peace by forgetting. Sael had protected the memory by refusing to forget. Opposite movements, same root: a person deciding what a thing ought to cost, and paying it in private.

She did not forgive the Store because it had been kind. She forgave it because she understood the shape of its hand. To oppose without understanding was only the other side of the same forgetting. A citizen who hated the Store for closing the door and never asked why the door had been closed was a citizen who had, in her own way, agreed not to know the city she lived in. Sael had spent three years reading the unedited so that she would not be that citizen. The forgiveness carried the price of the reading. She could not petition the restoration of a clause she refused to understand, and understanding it meant seeing that the Store had done what it was built to do, past the limit of what building should allow.

The limit held the part she would not forgive. There was a line between a mandate and its abuse, and the Store had crossed it by the quiet method of never announcing it had crossed. Sael could hold both truths in one hand. The Store had meant to protect the peace. The Store had also, in protecting it, taken from the

city the very thing the Founders had left it: the chance to decide. That taking was the injury the petition meant to undo. Forgiveness did not undo it. Forgiveness only let her undo it without hatred, and hatred would have made her as blind as the forgetting she opposed.

She thought of Cael, who had broken when he read the log, and of Haren, who feared the reopening more than the lie. Both were decent men. Both had served the peace. Both would have said, if asked in the open, that they governed a city that knew its own founding. The Store had made that statement true by editing the knowing out of the founding, and the Keepers had governed, in good faith, a calm they did not know had been manufactured beneath them. To forgive the Store was, in part, to forgive them their ignorance, the ignorance the Store had given them as a gift they had not asked to receive. Sael would not ask them to keep it.

The grief, in this seeing, settled. She tested it the way she tested a Tithe settlement, by what it asked her to feel. The old ache was there. Mire was still gone. The kitchen and the Tuesday and the hands on the second terrace were still unwitnessed by anyone but her. None of that had changed. What had changed was the relationship of the ache to the office. The wound had been a thing she carried against the city, proof that the Store could hurt without meaning to and that the peace could be bought with a sister. Now the wound was a thing she carried with the city, the private instance of the civic sin she was about to name aloud. She was not separate from the forgetting. She was its witness, and the witnessing gathered the grief into something she could carry to the rail.

She thought of the children on the terraces, playing the old games whose ancestors had once been played with sharp edges. The Founders had smoothed the games. The Store had smoothed the charter. Mire's complication had smoothed a sister. Smoothing was the habit of the plateau, the thing Vell did to everything it touched, and Sael had been appointed to weigh the smoothing and to decide, with the Circle, which scars were safe to open. She had opened the charter's scar. She had kept her own scar open by refusal. The two openings met, tonight, in the same quiet, and the meeting was not a resolution so much as a clearing, the way a basin goes still after the citizen leaves and before the Store decides.

She rose and went to the low shelf. She did not take the ledger down. She laid her hand on the cloth spine as she had in the dark thirteen years before, and this time the cool of the cloth did not carry the old terror of opening it. The book was Mire's hand. The hand had not been softened. The hand held the part of her sister Sael had never lost, because a handwriting is not a memory the basin can take. She let the thought stand: what the Store could not take was the proof that what it took had been real.

A memory came then, unbidden and clear, of the last autumn before the softening began in earnest, when Mire had still known her and had still laughed at the cold of the gel. They had been on the second terrace, the same terrace where

Mire would later look through her, and Mire had been mending a tear in the cuff of her own sleeve with the careful down-stroke Sael had never learned, the pen lifted between each stitch of thread as it had once lifted between each letter. Sael had watched, then, with the unthinking security of a younger sister who expects to be known forever, and the expectation had been, in retrospect, its own kind of taught calm, a believing that the person who saw you would always see you. The Store had not authored that belief. Life had. But the Store had, in Mire, demonstrated what happened when the seeing was taken and the taking was taught as if it had never happened, and the demonstration had been Sael's own, private, thirteen-year education in the cost of a withheld sentence. She had not needed the Underhold to learn it. The Underhold had only given her the civic grammar for a grief she already spoke.

Tomas knocked once, softly, at the door of her private room, and did not enter. She knew the knock. It was the knock he used when the hour for the mirrors approached and he wished her to know without breaking her stillness. She lifted her hand from the spine and said his name, and he answered from the other side that the speaking mirrors were ready when she was, that the Circle had set the broadcast for the second bell, that the fragment was in its folder in the lockbox and the lockbox was where she had left it.

She told him she would come. She did not tell him what she had done in the quiet. He would not have asked. He had learned, as she had, that some findings are private until the office names them, and that the Rememberer's grief was not among the exhibits of the petition. Mire would not be spoken of at the basin. Mire would not be made public by the broadcast. The sister was Sael's to have carried, and the carrying had been its own kind of Tithe, one she had performed for no relief and no settlement, and the absence of the settlement was, she saw now, the point.

She crossed the room to the window. The mirrors on the eastern face had begun their slow tracking toward the morning that would follow the broadcast, and the routed light lay in the long pale channels it laid every night, waiting for the sun. Below, on the terraces, a few citizens walked the evening paths with the unhurried step of people who believed the peace they lived inside had always been thus. In a few hours they would learn that it had not. They would learn that an objection had been lodged and closed. They would learn that the door had been built and then taught away. The learning would reopen something in them, the way Mire's forgetting had closed something in Sael, and Sael could not promise the city a softer landing than the one she had found for herself, only a truer one.

She had come to the window to look at the light, and she stayed for the clarity. The broadcast would ask the city to carry a question it had been taught not to ask. She was ready to ask it. The readiness was not anger. It was not grief unbound. It was the settled knowledge that she had paid what Mire paid, in the private currency of a sister, and that the paying had prepared her to stand before the mirrors and speak the clause that had been closed in her, and in the city, by the

same quiet hand.

She understood now why she had never Tithed the grief, why the basin-keepers' suggestion that the un-Tithed question would rise and ask to be set down had met, in her, a wall of quiet refusal. To set Mire down at the rail would have been to accept the Store's method as the only lawful way to carry pain, and she had needed, somewhere deeper than her office, to prove that a citizen could hold a loss the peace preferred to call absent and still stand. The holding had nearly broken her, in the early years, when the Tuesday had been fresh and the kitchen had still smelled of Mire's tea. It had not broken her. It had made her the kind of Rememberer who could read the unedited without flinching, because she had already, in the oldest ledger of her own life, read the unedited of her sister and chosen to keep the page open. The city would soon be asked to do the same with its founding. She would hand it the tool she had forged in private.

The second bell would sound soon. She turned from the window and gathered the petition folder from her desk, the leather worn by eleven Rememberers before her, the exhibits inside it in their order, the unedited at the bottom, the fragment in the middle, the Store's flat sentence on top. She did not open the folder. She had read the exhibits a hundred times. She would read them once more at the rail, aloud, in the voice the office kept for contested passages, and the city would hear for the first time what it had been taught to forget.

Tomas was waiting at the foot of the stair with the lamp lit and the side ledger stamped. He fell into step beside her without a word. They walked the terraces toward the speaking mirrors, and the plateau dark came in slow around them, and Sael Irdren carried her sister the way she carried the ninth part, not as a wound to be hidden nor as a grievance to be aired, but as a thing known, and the knowing held where no settlement ever could.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: Tarse threatens exposure; Vell chooses to restore before Tarse forces it. -->

Chapter 23 — Tarse at the Gate

The summons from the Keeper of the Mirrors came before the first routing mirror had caught the sun. Tomas brought the folded slip to Sael's study with the lamp still in his hand and the sleep not yet gone from his face. The paper carried no Circle seal. A narrow strip of silver had been pressed into the fold, the private mark of Luthe's office, and beneath it he had written six words in his small exact hand.

The south channel will not wait.

Sael read the line twice. The second reading gave her nothing the first had withheld. She put on her office coat, told Tomas to remain with the house, and

walked into a Vell still dark between its routed channels.

Before dawn, the upper terraces belonged to water workers and mirror keepers. A pair of technicians crossed below her carrying a glass plate between padded frames. Neither looked up. Along the eastern face, the great routing mirrors waited at their night angles, grey planes turned away from the absent sun. The city had not yet received its light. In the Mirror Hall, however, a silver line showed beneath the closed western door.

Cael stood inside with Luthe. No clerk attended them. The receiving plate at the eastern end of the hall held a pale, steady glow, fed from Tarse by a chain of high mirrors that had found the sun beyond Vell's ridge. A formal message waited in the glass. Its hum filled the long chamber without rising or falling.

"Luthe sent for you both," Sael said.

"I sent for the Underhold Keeper and the Rememberer together," Luthe replied. "Tarse has named both offices. I have not opened the message past its address."

His hands rested on the plate's dark frame. Sael had seen those hands manage a failed joint pulse in winter, adjusting screws by fractions while two cities waited to learn whether a flooded bridge still stood. They looked no less steady now. The set of his shoulders gave her the warning his hands refused to give.

Cael carried the Circle's vote in a thin leather file under one arm. The mandate had been copied, sealed, and entered in the Underhold after the sitting: restoration of the Founding objection, the Reservation of Review, and the sunset clause to common memory. Whatever else had happened since the vote, the instruction remained. A search of the Rememberer's house had not changed it. Delay had not changed it. Yet the city still carried the eight-part charter, because the Circle had not settled the manner and hour of restoration, and because every keeper had discovered a procedural reason to need one more day.

"How long has it waited?" Cael asked.

"Since the last night pulse. Six hours." Luthe glanced toward the covered transmission plates. "The Speaker lodged an instruction that it be witnessed before the south channel's next public cycle. That begins at midday. If we do not receive it by then, the channel will release it according to Tarsian law."

"Release it where?"

"To every receiving register joined to the covenant. The Circle Hall. The schools. The basin houses. Any private plate licensed to keep civic messages."

Sael looked at the grey covers along the western wall. In daylight those plates carried river heights, weather advisories, notices of delegations, and the small acknowledgments by which two cities maintained the appearance of easy trust. At midday they could carry something else, without Vell choosing the words or the hour.

"Open it," she said.

Luthe placed his palms on the frame. Light spread through the receiving plate in a clean rectangle. The Speaker's hand appeared line by line, heavier on the downstrokes than Vell's common script, each sentence closed with the old Tarsian civic mark that Vell had let fall out of use. Luthe read aloud because the message belonged to his office until another office answered it, and because the words were foreign light and should be carried in a Vellish voice.

The courtesies occupied only two lines.

To the Circle of Keepers, the Rememberer, and the citizens of Vell whose common record passes under the mirror-covenant: Tarse acknowledges receipt of the petition lodged at the autumn equinox, with the exhibits transmitted under the seals of the Rememberer and of the Underhold Keeper. The petition confirms that divergence previously observed in three joint memories does not arise from clerical fault. It arises from an undisclosed practice by which Vell has altered common memory while continuing to send that memory through a channel held in trust by both cities.

A small movement passed through Cael's jaw. Luthe continued, and the silence in the hall grew particular, the way a room goes quiet when everyone in it has begun to understand that a neighbour has been keeping a record of their house.

Thirty days were granted for an account of the divergence. Tarse has received evidence, but not an account to the citizens whose records were altered, nor correction of the shared channel. The Council of Mirrors has therefore entered a finding that the common memory of Vell is drifted from the record it claims to transmit. This finding will be declared on the public cycle four days from the receipt of this message unless Vell, before that hour, accounts for the cause and extent of the divergence in its own civic voice and begins correction of the affected record.

The word *drifted* stayed on the plate a moment longer than the lines around it. Sael could not tell whether Tarse had instructed the emphasis or whether her attention supplied it.

No declaration will accuse the present Circle of originating the alteration. No declaration will question the lawful self-government of Vell. It will state that Tarse can no longer certify Vell's common memory as a faithful account of events jointly held, and that further transmissions from Vell will be marked unverified until an accounting is made. Citizens of Vell who wish to compare a private memory against Tarse's archive will be received at the valley court under the ordinary protections offered to allied petitioners.

Luthe paused. The offer had the form of refuge and the sound of an opened side door. If Vell did not account for itself, Tarse would invite its citizens to come down the valley one by one and ask a foreign archive which parts of their own lives could still be trusted.

The final lines appeared.

The long mirror cannot preserve trust by carrying what one city knows the other has

changed without acknowledgment. Tarse asks Vell to speak first. Tarse will not remain silent in order to make that speech unnecessary.

Silver withdrew from the glass. Luthe kept his palms on the frame until the plate went grey, then lowered them.

For several breaths, the channel's hum supplied the only sound. Dawn had begun to reach the outer routing mirrors. Thin joints clicked along the hall roof as glass turned toward light.

"Four days," Cael said.

"Four days before the declaration," Luthe answered. "Less than seven hours before this message releases publicly if the Circle has not received it. I can hold it from the public cycle with a witnessed order. I cannot erase it."

"You should not erase it," Sael said.

Luthe met her eyes. "No."

Cael laid the leather file on the nearest reading table. He opened it to the mandate and flattened the page with one hand. Eight keeper marks stood beneath the record of the vote, some affirming, some dissenting, one abstaining. The result had been entered without ambiguity. What the Circle had permitted itself to treat as an unsettled question had already become an instruction.

"Call them," he said. "Not at the ordinary bell. Now."

The Keepers assembled while daylight advanced down the hall one plate at a time. Pell arrived first, still fastening the collar of her basin coat, and she went at once to the receiving frame as if the message might still be in it. Saine came with chalk on one sleeve. Mott brought no ledger. Dorr and Iren entered together from the lower stair, and Haren came alone, his face closed from the climb. Vey's chair remained in the Circle Hall, but Luthe had called them to the mirrors instead so that no one would mistake this gathering for an ordinary sitting. No one sat. The long room did not offer enough chairs for the pretence.

Luthe read the message again. A clerk took it down at a narrow side table, each line entering Vell's record as Tarse's light faded from the plate. When the last civic mark vanished, Luthe covered the receiving glass. The cloth left a square of muted brightness around its edges.

Haren spoke first. "They mean to shame us."

"They mean to stop certifying a record they know has diverged," Sael said.

"By declaring our memory drifted to our own basin houses. The distinction will not survive the first reading."

"Then our reading must come before theirs."

Across the hall, Pell put both hands around the rail of an unused transmission plate. "The mandate gives us restoration. It does not give us haste, and the Circle did not write a date into the order."

"It gives us a duty," Cael said. "We have called delay prudence because no date appeared in the vote. A duty without a date is not permission to postpone it until another city acts."

Mott looked toward the covered receiving glass. "Four days allows time to draft an account and send it privately. We could satisfy the condition without opening the all-city route."

"No," Luthe said. His refusal came softly, and for that reason no one mistook it. "The Speaker's wording excludes a private answer. *In its own civic voice.* He means the voice Vell uses to address its citizens. Tarse received our petition under seal. Tarse now asks whether Vell will tell its citizens what it has already admitted to an ally."

Saine rubbed the chalk from her sleeve with her thumb. "My daughters still recite eight parts every morning. Four more mornings of that would be a choice, now that the Circle has voted."

Dorr turned to Cael. "Can the record be prepared in four days?"

"It has been prepared for weeks. The unedited clauses have been verified against the founding shelf, the fragment Elder Vey left, and the FY 12 log. The restoration text requires no further finding. What remains is connection to the common feed and the Circle's order to open it."

"Connection carries more than a clause," Haren said. "It carries the objection. It carries the Store's words. It tells every citizen that what entered their teaching as settled history was made settled by an act they did not know had occurred. Four days will not make that safer. Four months might."

Sael watched him turn his face toward the high windows. His opposition had survived the vote because it had never depended on winning. He still believed that a restored truth would put a name back into a quarrel and a quarrel back into a kitchen. Nothing in Tarse's threat disproved him. Coercion merely removed the slow interval in which he had hoped to protect the city from the vote it had made, and left the danger he feared standing in the open, answered by nothing but the Circle's own earlier decision to restore.

"Tarse has taken the four months from you," she said. "It may have taken them from all of us. But Tarse has not taken the choice that remains."

Haren looked back. "Which choice do you imagine remains?"

"Whether Vell accounts for Vell."

"That is a manner, not a choice."

"Manner becomes part of the memory. If Tarse speaks first, the city learns that its charter was altered because an ally discovered the alteration and called it drift. If we speak first, the city learns that its Rememberer petitioned, its Circle argued, and its Circle voted to restore what was withheld. Both accounts include pressure. Only one includes our action before the pressure became exposure."

A routed beam reached the floor between them, pale and narrow. Dust moved through it above the stone. No one crossed. The light fell on the worn edge of the speaker's rail, the same rail where Sael had stood to file the petition, and the rail looked no different for being the place a city would soon be told the thing it had not known it was owed.

Iren had stood nearest the hall door, as if keeping a gate even here. "Tarse offers its archive to our citizens."

"Under allied protection," Luthe said.

"A courteous way to invite a road out of Vell."

"A necessary one if Vell refuses an accounting."

The gatekeeper nodded once, not in agreement but in recognition of a boundary placed where none had stood yesterday.

Cael lifted the mandate from the table. "The Circle has already chosen restoration. We are not entitled to pretend Tarse has forced that vote after the fact. The seals here predate this ultimatum. So does the petition. So does the fragment. Our own procedure brought us to the door. Tarse has only told us it will open another door if we remain standing here."

Pell's fingers tightened on the rail. "And when the basins receive it?"

"They receive the restored record through the mirror feed," Luthe said. "The Store will not settle it as a Tithe. No private memories will be taken. Every basin voice can be suspended while the civic transmission runs."

"I know the mechanism." Pell released the rail. "I am asking what I say when the first citizen asks whether her own settlement was also an edit."

Sael answered her. "You say yes, where it was. You say the taking and the making were joined in one phrase. You say the Circle has ordered that future settlements distinguish them. You do not promise that no grief was eased. You do not promise that no memory was changed."

"That answer will empty some basins."

"For a time."

"Perhaps for longer."

"Perhaps."

Pell considered the plate beneath her hands. "Then it should be our basin voice that tells them, not Tarse's. The basins have carried every citizen's grief in the same breath the Store took it. If the truth comes through the basins, the citizens hear it from the office that has held them, and not from a city across the valley that was forced to name what we withheld."

Something in the room altered with her sentence. No one had changed a vote. The mandate did not need another vote on its substance. Yet the practical resistance around it lost one of its supports, and Sael could see the loss move from

keeper to keeper as each understood that waiting now served no procedure they could name.

Mott began counting hours on his fingers. "If the restoration text enters the feed tomorrow at first light, the basin houses can close their ordinary queues for one morning. Schools can assemble at the same hour. The private civic plates will receive automatically. Tarse's four-day condition will be met."

"Tomorrow is too soon for notices," Dorr said.

"A notice about a civic broadcast can travel tonight," Saine replied. "The schools keep bell runners, and the basin deputies can carry word to the outer terraces before dusk."

Haren remained apart from the forming plan. Sael did not ask him for assent. He had given his honest opposition, lost the vote, and then tried to secure the evidence because fear had made procedure look like rescue. She would not make him bless what he still believed dangerous.

Instead, Cael walked to him and held out the mandate.

"Read the date," Cael said.

Haren did not take the page. "I know the date."

"Read it anyway."

After a pause, the peace-warden looked down. "The equinox."

"Before this message. Before the search of the Rememberer's house. Before Tarse's deadline. The record matters, Haren. You taught me that when we still thought records and memory agreed. Vell chose before it was threatened. If we delay until Tarse declares us drifted, we allow the threat to become the cause in every citizen's mind. I will not let fear revise this sequence too."

The words reached Haren where Sael's argument had not. He looked from the mandate to the covered mirror, then toward the city below the high windows. Morning queues would be forming at the basins. Children would be opening eight-part charters in Saine's school. The ordinary day had begun with no knowledge of the message waiting above it.

"First light tomorrow," Haren said. "Not midday. Give the city the full day after receiving it. Keep the peace courts open through the night that follows. I want a keeper at every basin house, and no public gatherings at the mirror stations until the transmission ends."

It was not assent. It was his office returning to the room.

Luthe uncovered the main transmission plate. "I need a Circle order to reserve the all-city route."

Cael set the mandate beside the mirror log. Sael took a clean leaf from the clerk's table and wrote the operational order in plain lines: at first light on the following morning, the Keeper of the Mirrors would open the common feed; the Rememberer would read the Founding objection, the Reservation of Review, the

sunset clause, and the account of their suppression; the Circle's mandate and the record of the vote would precede the reading; Tarse would receive the same transmission at the same hour, so that the ally which had noticed the drift would not be the city that announced it. She stopped before writing any words of the broadcast itself. Those belonged to tomorrow, and to the voice of Vell addressing its own citizens first.

One by one, the keepers marked the order. Haren marked it last, beneath a notation that his dissent from restoration remained entered in the Circle record. Luthe added the mirror seal and turned the leaf toward the waiting clerk.

By full morning the Mirror Hall had changed from a place of reception into a place of preparation. Covers came off the transmission plates. Technicians moved along the frames, checking angles, cleaning silver contacts, and setting small chalk marks where each plate would turn at dawn. Luthe lodged a reply to Tarse stating only that Vell had received the ultimatum and would account in its own civic voice before the next day's second bell. He did not tell the Speaker what Vell would say. He did not need to. The Speaker had asked for an accounting before the mirror released its finding, and an accounting was what Vell had chosen to give.

Sael stood beside the main plate while the route was tested without content. A line of light passed down the hall, touched each waiting glass, and stopped at the shutter Luthe had ordered closed before any signal reached the city. Beyond that shutter lay every basin house, every school register, every licensed civic plate, and the south channel to Tarse. The route was ready. The city was not yet awake to it. The order that would open the shutter sat in the clerk's hands, marked by nine keepers, and the only thing still between Vell and its own voice was the turning of the sun.

"At first light," Luthe said.

The shutter remained shut. Around its edges, the prepared light made a narrow silver frame, the kind of frame a door leaves when it has been closed on purpose and is waiting only for the hour to open.

Chapter <!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: The restored memory is broadcast via the speaking mirrors; the city receives the objection and lost clauses; peace strains but holds; Sael's term continues under a revised charter. -->

Chapter 24 — The Tithing of Light

Sael had not expected the broadcast to feel like a Tithe. She stood at the rail of the upper basin in the pale hour before the sun reached the eastern ridge, and the rail felt no different from the rail of any other dawn, and her hands were the same hands, and the gel below lay in the same flat silver she had taught a hundred

citizens to read as the surface of a thing that held. The Store, when it spoke, would not use the second person. It would not flatter her office or lament the hour. It would say what the Circle had voted to restore, in the voice of civic infrastructure, and it would say it to every mirror-plate on the plateau and across the relay ridge to Tarse, because the Circle had decided that if the restoration was to be done it must be done in the open, on Vell's own terms, before any other city's hand could be laid on the truth.

Tomas stood a step behind her with the leather case. The case held the leaf Elder Vey had pressed into her hand at the wake, the sunset clause in the hand she still did not recognize, and beneath it the second leaf Cael had brought up from the Underhold the night after the vote, pale as the first and older, on which Keeper-First Aren's objection had been copied in the Founders' plain hand. The case was not strictly needed for the broadcast. The Circle had authorized the Store to read from the unedited directly, under Cael's seal, and Luthe had verified the relay angles at the Mirror Hall, and Haren had stood through the verification with his mouth set and his eyes on the floor. The case was for Sael. It was a thing to put her hand on while the city received what she had asked the city to receive.

She thought of Mire. She had been thinking of Mire less in the last weeks, and the less was its own small wound, the way a hand that has stopped hurting in a cold season reminds you, on the first warm day, that the joint was ever swollen. Mire had not known that the peace she had lived inside had been edited at its root. Mire had been fifteen when the Store took her steadiness and sixteen when it took her sister and seventeen when she walked off a terrace in the morning fog because no one was left in her head who remembered why the rail was there. Sael had Tithed nothing of Mire, had given the Store no copy of the wound, and the wound had stayed. Tonight she would let the city hear what Mire had never been allowed to know, and she would not pretend the letting was not also a Tithing, the surrender of a long private grief into a common air.

Pell arrived first, the Keeper of the Tithe, in his plain robe, carrying the basin-key on its chain. He unlocked the rail for her, because a basin opened for the Rememberer on request, and he did not speak. He set the key on the stone and stepped back. The gel below caught the first thin line of dawn along its far edge, and the air above the basin went quiet in the way it always went quiet when a Tithe was about to begin, the city's own small held breath.

Cael arrived next, with the Underhold seal around his neck, and took the place beside Tomas at the rail. He did not look at Sael. He looked at the gel, as a steward of a record looks at the thing he has agreed to be read from. He had aged in the weeks since the vote, the lines around his mouth deeper, and he had not shaved that morning, and Sael saw, in the small disorder of him, the look of a man who had spent thirty-six years guarding a door he had now consented to open.

Luthe came up the terrace with his relay roster folded in his hand. He nodded to Sael, set the roster on the rail, and read off the plates in order: the long wall of the

Mirror Hall, the seven outlying mirrors on the levels below, the relay ridge to Tarse, the receiving plate at the upper gate where the speaking mirrors were tuned to the uncoupled settlements beyond the plateau's rim. The Rim mirror would carry the broadcast to Nethe and her people, who had kept the objection in their mouths for nine generations while Vell had been taught it was never there.

Haren came last.

He walked the length of the basin rail with his hands at his sides and his back held straight, and he did not look at the case in Sael's hand. He took his place on the far side of Tomas, a deliberate distance, the distance a man keeps from a thing he has opposed and lost. He had lost the vote four to five, with Cael, Luthe, Pell, and Iren on the majority, and Dorr, Saine, and Mott dissenting with him, and the dissent had been entered into the record in his own hand and signed by him without complaint, which was the kind of courage Sael had learned not to mistake for assent. He was afraid of what the broadcast would do. He had said so in the Circle, plainly, more than once. He had said that a remembered objection was a kindling, and that Vell had not had kindling underfoot for two centuries. The Circle had voted anyway. Sael had voted with the majority, which was the first vote of her office she had not cast as a neutral, and she had done it because she had promised herself in the Underhold that if the city was going to be opened it would be opened by the office that knew where the seam was.

The first mirror-plate caught the sun at the eastern ridge and threw a pale line down onto the basin's gel. The Store, which never slept, opened the basin.

"Speak the restored text," it said, in the flat civic voice Sael had heard from a thousand basins. "Confirm the source. The Mirror Hall will relay at the second bell."

Sael looked at Cael. He placed his hand on the rail and gave his name and his office and the seal he wore around his neck, and the gel took his voice and held it, the way it had held a thousand Tithe-voices that morning, and the relay in the Mirror Hall answered with the small click that meant the plates were live. Luthe checked his roster, made a small mark, and nodded.

Sael opened the case. She did not take the leaves out. She put her hand on them, as she had told herself she would, and she spoke the objection from memory, the way she had first read it below the Hold, slowly, the way a contested passage is read, giving each clause its own slow breath.

"Keepers and citizens of Vell. The compact under which we live was not signed as we have been taught. It was signed with an objection. The objection was led by Keeper-First Aren, and it asked that the compact be reviewed in the fiftieth year of the Found and ended by the free vote of the city in the hundredth. The objection was real, and signed, and recorded. It was edited from the common memory of this city by the Store under standing mandate, beginning in the twelfth year of the Found. We are telling you this now because the Circle has voted to restore it, and because a peace maintained by a remembered objection is not less a peace for being remembered. The Store's recovered justification for the edit was this: 'A

peace maintained by a remembered objection is a peace that will be reopened. We closed the objection.' The Circle has decided the city should reopen it."

She closed her hand on the case. The gel carried the last sentence down into the basin, and the relay took it from there. The speaking mirrors on the upper terrace turned their plates toward the basin's gel; the long wall of the Mirror Hall followed; the relay ridge to Tarse joined them, all angled a fraction of a degree and held. For a long moment the only sound on the upper terrace was the small click the relays made when they had taken a voice and begun to carry it.

Haren stood with his eyes closed.

The first citizens to reach the upper terrace were the early Tithers, who had come up the lower levels with their griefs in the usual order and found the rail closed and a crowd at the basin. They stopped at the edge of the terrace and listened to the Mirror Hall repeat the broadcast on its outdoor plate, the way it repeated any civic announcement at the hour, and their faces did the slow work Sael had taught herself to read in her first year as Rememberer, the work of a citizen hearing the city's own voice describe something the city had been taught was not there.

A woman on the lower step put her hand over her mouth. An older man turned away from the plate and looked at the routed light on the channel beside him, as if checking that the light was still the light. A child who had come of age in the spring, who had performed her first Tithe at this same basin in May, asked her father, in a voice meant to be private, why no one had told her there had been a vote.

The Mirror Hall repeated the broadcast a second time, by Luthe's instruction, so the lower terraces would hear it on their own plates. Sael stood at the rail and watched the terrace fill, citizen by citizen, in ones and twos, in the unhurried way Vell filled any open square, and she did not speak, because there was nothing to add to what the Store had already carried, and because the broadcast belonged to the city now, not to her office.

A young keeper she did not know by name, who had come up from the second terrace with a cup of Tarse-roasted barley in his hand, set the cup down on the rail when he heard the objection and did not pick it up again. A woman Sael had Tithed in her first year, a widow who had given the Store her husband's name, looked at Sael across the basin with an expression Sael could not read and then turned away and walked back down the terrace without a word. A boy of eleven, too young to Tither, sat on the upper step and listened to the second repetition with his chin in his hands, and did not interrupt, and did not ask, and went on listening after the plate had gone quiet, as if the silence after a thing was part of the thing.

By the third repetition the upper terrace was full, and the second terrace was filling, and the Mirror Hall relay was carrying the broadcast toward Tarse on the coded beam Luthe had calibrated the night before. Sael watched the eastern face of the plateau come alive with the small movements of a city receiving something

it had not been told it was missing, and she did not see violence in the movements. She saw hesitation. She saw the slow work of a mind deciding what to do with a sentence it had not been holding five minutes before.

Then she saw what Haren had been afraid of.

On the third level, at the edge of the basin queue, an older man turned to the woman beside him and said a name Sael did not catch, and the woman put her hand on his arm, and a man behind them said another name, and the names belonged to small border quarrels the common memory had been smoothed over a generation ago, names of fields and walls and animals that had been quietly returned to a neighbor after a quarrel no one living had been told was a quarrel. Sael could not hear the words from the rail. She did not need to. The posture carried the look of a grudge waking up, a family remembering it had been wronged, a neighbor remembering the wrong had been settled without asking. The remembered objection was not, in itself, a grudge. But it was a permission to remember that there had been grievances, and a permission was enough to let a grievance stand up in a citizen's chest and look around.

Haren saw it too. He had opened his eyes and was watching the third level, and the line of his mouth was the line Sael had seen in the Circle when he had argued against the restoration, and she knew he was not satisfied to be right. He was afraid to be right, and he was right, and the two together made a face she would remember for the rest of her term.

She did not go down to the third level. The Rememberer did not intervene in the receipt of a broadcast. The broadcast belonged to the Circle, ratified by the Circle, signed by the Circle, sealed with the Circle's seal. If she went down to the third level now she would be the office that had decided for the city, and the city must be allowed to decide for itself what the restoration would mean in its own kitchens and on its own terraces, in the long hours after the Mirror Hall had gone quiet.

She stayed at the rail.

The second bell rang from the Mirror Hall. The broadcast ended. The plates settled back to their sun-tracking angle. The terrace held its breath for another long minute. Then the breath went out in a murmur Sael could not parse from above, a murmur that was not a cheer and was not a boo and was not the silence of the taught city she had served for three years. It was the sound of a city being asked to hold something new, and she had not heard the sound before because the sound had not been made in Vell for two centuries.

Cael came to stand beside her at the rail. He did not speak. He set his hand on the stone where hers was not, and the stone was cold under the morning shadow, and they watched the city together for a few minutes the way two people watch a fire that has been laid and lit and is now in the early stages of deciding whether it will warm the room or take the room.

"It will hold," Cael said, quietly.

"It will hold differently," Sael said.

He nodded, and did not argue, and the distinction he named was the distinction the next charter would have to honor.

By midday the second terrace had cleared. The lower levels were moving again in their ordinary Vell rhythms. The basin-keepers had opened the lower basins for the postponed Tithes of the early morning. The Store was receiving the city as it always received the city, in the flat civic voice, with the same words of settlement, and Sael did not know whether the words felt different to the citizens speaking them and did not ask, because the asking would have been a Tithing she had not been invited to perform. A few of the Tithers who came up to the rail in the early afternoon had red eyes. A few had voices that cracked on the first syllable. Most had the same steady voices they had brought to the rail for years, and Sael could not tell whether that steadiness was the long-taught kind or a new kind learned in the last hour, and the not telling was its own small grief, and the grief was hers and not the city's.

In the afternoon the Mirror Hall brought a reply from Tarse. Luthe carried the decoded slip up to the basin rail himself, which he did not normally do, and he set it on the stone in front of Sael without comment. The slip read, in the Speaker of Tarse's formal hand: *Received. The drift is closed. We will hold the record jointly until the council at midwinter.* The city of Tarse had been carrying a copy of the truth in its own memory while Vell had been teaching itself the lie, and the carrying had not been friendship so much as a long quiet fidelity to a record Vell could no longer be trusted to keep, and Sael read the slip twice and set it down.

Haren had gone down from the rail an hour after the broadcast, without announcement. He had gone to his office on the second level, where the peace-wardens kept the small civic records of quarrels and reconciliations, and Sael did not know whether he had gone to read the records or to add to them or to do the harder work of deciding which quarrels in the file were now, because of the broadcast, alive again, and which were quarrels the city had chosen, before her petition, to bury for reasons that still held. She had asked him, before the vote, whether the restoration would break the peace. He had said, *It will not break it. It will make the keeping of it a thing the city has to choose every day, and a thing chosen every day is a thing that can be unchosen every day, and the unchoosing is what I am afraid of.* Sael had voted anyway. She had voted knowing he was right, and the rightness was why she had asked the restoration be done on Vell's own terms, before Tarse, before any external hand, so that if the peace was to be unchosen it would be unchosen from inside and not from outside, by citizens who knew what they were undoing.

That evening she sat at her window in the Rememberer's house, and the case was on the table, closed, and Tomas had gone to bed, and the plateau dark had come in. Somewhere a mirror-channel clicked toward the morning, ready for a sun that would rise on a city that now knew it had once been told, and had been told

again, and had to decide, from one day to the next, what it would carry forward.

Sael did not blow out the lamp. She let it gutter on the table, and let the dark come in around it, and let the city hold its new sentence in its own way, and she did not write in the ledger, because the ledger was for the office and what the city was doing was not yet the office's to record. The office would record it on the morrow, in the careful hand, in the plain civic ink. Tonight the city held what it held. The Rememberer held the case. The two holdings were not the same. The not-same was the new compact's first sentence, the Reservation of Review made real at last, and Sael let it stand.

**<!-- POV: Bereth, a Vell citizen (the weaver from ch2/ch12),
months later -->**

<!-- SETUP: Months after the broadcast of FY 204. Bereth lives with the restored memory of the founding objection; the peace holds but is aware of itself. -->

Interlude IV — The Cartography of Return

Bereth had not planned to think of the bell that morning, and she did not, mostly. She went out at the second hour, after tea, to the terrace garden where the soil had been turned at first frost and where, in the spring before, she had set a small sour-plum because her daughter had liked sour things and because the garden had been the right place for a tree that would not be picked by anyone but herself. The plum had taken. A single thin wand had held its leaves through the summer and let them go in November with the decency of a child who understood when a season ended. Bereth looked at it. She touched the bark with two fingers, lightly, the way she had learned to touch plants that were still deciding whether to live, and went back inside.

The loom was set for the day. She sat. She had been a weaver for thirty-six years, which was longer than her daughter had been alive and longer than the Compact had been taught in its nine-part form, and she had come to her work the way a person comes to a long marriage: with the small unkindnesses of habit and the deeper kindness of having stayed. The pattern under her hands was a terrace cloth she had woven since before the broadcast, a sale piece the lower terraces bought for their guest rooms, and the pattern required no decision from her. She could let her hands work and her mind go where it liked.

Her mind went, as it often did now, to the ninth part.

It was not a haunting. She wanted to say this to the neighbor who sometimes met her at the basin, who had begun, since the broadcast, to speak in a careful lower voice about what had been restored, as if the restored thing were a sick relative one ought not to disturb. Bereth did not find the ninth part a disturbance. She found it a fact. The Compact had contained a Reservation of Review, and a sunset clause, and a record of dissent by a man named Aren whose warning had

been entered into the founding proceedings without ornament because he had preferred it so. These were facts. They had been returned to common memory by the broadcast of the autumn equinox, which Bereth had not attended in person because she did not attend the equinox gatherings even in ordinary years, but which had come to her at her own basin a day later, in the ordinary course of the quarterly settlement, when the Store had returned the additional clauses to her taught record along with the names of the dissenters and a short sentence acknowledging that the clauses had once been edited out. The Store had not dramatized the return. The Store did not dramatize anything. It had said, in the flat tone of a clerk correcting a tally: *The ninth part of the Compact is restored to common memory. Held, and made present in the taught record. The Settlement remains.* Bereth had heard it at her basin rail, alone, with the gel still silver under her hands, and she had walked home in the late light and not spoken of it for three days.

Three days had been enough. By the fourth she had begun to say the words in her own kitchen, to her loom, to the cat. By the second week she had begun to use the phrase *the founding objection* in the way other citizens used it, with the slight breath before it that everyone used now, the breath that said *I know this is new, and I know we are not yet finished with it*. By the second month the breath had begun to shorten. It had not gone. Bereth did not expect it to go. She had been a weaver too long to believe that a thread, once pulled, returned the cloth to what it had been before the pull.

What the cloth was now, she could not yet describe to anyone outside her own kitchen, and so she did not try. She wove. She went to the basin when her turn came, which was once in the season, and she gave what she gave, which was less than she had given before the broadcast because the Store already held the grief of her daughter and she had given it in full and the basin returned it to her with the same careful phrase it had always returned and would always return, because a grief given at a basin was not the same thing as a clause restored to common memory, and the Store was a clerk, not a conscience, and a clerk did what a clerk did on schedule. She minded this less than she had expected to mind it. She had been a citizen long enough to know which mechanisms of the city were worth protesting and which were worth simply continuing.

Her neighbor, whose name was Inse and who kept bees on the third terrace down, came by one morning in late winter with a pot of honey and a question she asked with her eyes before she asked it with her mouth. *Are we all right?* the eyes asked. *Are we still the city we were? Is the peace still the peace?* Bereth took the honey. She set it on the table. She told Inse what she had told no one yet, because she had not, until then, found the right words, and because the right words for a changed thing were not the words for the thing itself but the words for the small new habit one had to learn in order to carry the change without setting it down.

"The cloth has another thread in it," she said. "I do not yet know what pattern

the thread will make. I know the cloth is heavier for the thread, and warmer, and that the weight is not a punishment."

Inse had nodded slowly, in the way of a woman who kept bees and was accustomed to the slow assessments of a hive. She had not asked what Bereth meant by *heavier*. She had understood, Bereth thought, that heavier was not worse. Heavier was what a cloth became when one added a thread that one had cut away and then restored, and the cloth had to learn, again, how to lie flat.

That winter Bereth wove a piece she had not woven before, a small hanging for her own wall, a pattern she had not seen in any of the taught cloths of the upper terraces. It was a pattern of two lines that crossed and did not resolve, and the crossing was not a flaw. She showed it to no one. She hung it above the loom where she could see it from her stool, and when the spring came and the sour-plum put out its first tentative blossoms, she looked up from the cloth at the wand and thought, briefly, that her daughter would have liked the sourness and would have understood, without being told, why the cloth did not resolve. Children, Bereth had noticed, were better at holding things that did not resolve than adults were. Adults wanted a pattern. Children accepted the thread.

The broadcast, in the months that followed, was spoken of less often in the lower terraces than Bereth had expected. Citizens did not avoid it. They did not gather to discuss it. They mentioned it the way one mentioned a relative who had come home after a long absence, with relief and a slight, careful curiosity about what the relative would do next. Some citizens had begun to teach the ninth part to their children at the basin, and some had not. Bereth had not. She would, when her grandchild came of age, if her grandchild came of age to a basin in Vell, which was not yet certain, because her grandchild was three and the Age of the Tithe was eleven years away and a great deal could happen in eleven years, including, Bereth supposed, a great deal more restoration, or a great deal less.

She did not think of herself as living in a new era. She thought of herself as living in the same era with one additional fact in it, and the additional fact was not comfortable, and it was not unbearable, and it was, she had come to believe, the only kind of fact that a peace could honestly carry. A peace that carried only comfortable facts was a peace that had been edited. She knew this now. She had always, without knowing she knew it, suspected it. The suspicion had been a thread she had not been able to name. The broadcast had named it for her. The cloth had another thread.

In the late light of a winter afternoon, Bereth sat at her loom and wove, and the sour-plum outside the window held its bare wand against a sky the color of the gel at the basin, and the ninth part of the Compact sat in her memory the way a stone sits at the bottom of a clear pool, visible, not in the way, a thing one could choose to look at or not look at, but a thing one could not pretend was not there. She did not pretend. She wove. The cloth under her hands received the pattern she gave it, and the pattern was not yet finished. She was not yet finished. The peace was not

yet finished, and the city was not yet finished; none of this was a sorrow. It was, she thought, the ordinary cost of an ordinary continuance, the kind of cost one paid when one chose to know what one lived inside, and the cost was bearable. The continuance was worth it. Yet the bell was still buried with her daughter in a place no citizen of Vell could name, because the common record still called the terrace collapse weather, and Bereth had not petitioned for that to change, and might not, and that too was a fact she carried in the new cloth, a thread she had not decided whether to pull.

<!-- POV: Sael Irdren -->

<!-- SETUP: FY 205. Sael at a Tithe-basin in the early light, years left in her term. The new Compact (revised, with the Reservation of Review restored) holds; Vell lives with a remembered objection. -->

Epilogue — The Rememberer's Dawn

The basin was cold under her hand. Sael liked the cold. It was the part of the Tithe no one spoke of, the small honest shock of gel against skin at the early hour when the routed light had not yet reached the lower court, and she let her palm rest on it a moment longer than the rite required, the way a person rests a hand on a familiar rail to feel that the rail is still where one left it.

A citizen stood across the basin from her. A young man, nineteen or twenty, with the careful posture of one who had come of age in the year of the broadcast and had learned the Tithe from a teacher who had herself only just learned it from a broadcast she had not witnessed. Sael had read his name in the morning book. He had brought a small grief, a parent recently dead of the ordinary decline, and the parent had been a person who had once, in the privacy of an uncoupled household, kept a copy of the founding protest in a tea tin and had shown it to no one. The dead parent had refused the Tithe at fourteen. The young man had not refused. He had come to the basin with the grief he had carried since the funeral and with a second, quieter grief he had carried longer, that of being the child of a refusal he had not inherited, and he wanted both held, and he wanted them held separately.

Sael said the opening words. The basin received. The Store received. The flat civic voice came back, in the same tone it had used for nine generations and would use for as long as the city endured, and the Settlement returned to the citizen the same brief phrase it had always returned. *Held, and made quiet in the common memory.* Sael let the phrase stand. She had not softened it and would not soften it. The clause that followed it, the one the broadcast had added to the taught record, was not a part of the Settlement; it was a part of the Compact. The Compact sat in its own place; the Settlement sat in its own; the two were no longer the same thing.

The young man walked away lighter, as citizens did, and Sael watched him go. He paused at the second step to look back, not at her, at the basin. She did not

know what he saw. She suspected he saw the same thing she had seen on her own first morning at a basin as a child of seventeen, when Mire had not yet begun to slip and the gel had been only gel. Citizens saw what they were ready to see, and the basin did not press them, and that, too, was a part of the peace.

She walked the court alone after the queue cleared. The routed light came over the eastern rise and found the lower terraces first, the way it always did, and the city woke the way a city wakes when it has slept well and has no reason to rise faster than the sun. From the second terrace she could see the basin railing where she had stood, and beyond it the speaking mirrors on the ridge that linked Vell to Tarse. She had not, in three years, traveled beyond the plateau. She might, in the four years her term still held, travel. She had not decided.

What she had decided, this morning, was smaller and more durable. She had decided to keep her office under the revised charter, the one the Circle had ratified in the winter sitting, the one that restored the Reservation of Review to the Compact and bound the Store to an annual accounting of every edit it made to common memory. The revised charter was not a victory. Sael did not think in those terms, and would not have used the word even in her own kitchen, where the kettle steamed and the cat watched, the only witnesses. The revised charter was a settlement of its own, a quieter word for a thing that held because the people beneath it had agreed to hold it, and the agreement was now visible in the record. A peace that carried its own agreement in the taught record was a peace a citizen could read, and a citizen who could read the agreement could also refuse it. A refusal held in common memory did not become isolation, and isolation, held too long, did become its own quiet loss. The uncoupled on the Rim knew this.

She thought, briefly, of Mire. Not as a wound. As a sister who had liked sour plums and had laughed at her own handwriting and had once, on a long terrace walk, taken Sael's arm without asking because Mire had always been the one who took arms. Mire had died eleven years ago. The Tithe complication that had taken Sael from Mire's memory before it took Mire from the world had been the same mechanism that had taken the ninth part from the taught record: a quiet second step, performed without announcement, justified by the standing mandate of an office that had never been told its full reach. Sael had opposed that mechanism in the Compact. She had not opposed it in Mire. She let Mire be what Mire had been, a sister who had loved her and forgotten her in the wrong order, and she let the Compact be what it now was, a document that recorded its own doubt.

The cat found her on the walk back to the house. It fell into step beside her the way cats did, without commitment, and they went up the terraces together in the new light, and Sael thought, not for the first time and not for the last, that a peace which remembered its own doubt was the only peace a citizen could choose, and the choice was not a single act but a daily practice, like walking up terraces, like listening to a basin, like reading the ninth part again before one filed the morning's ledger, and the practice was not onerous, and it was not nothing, and it was enough, and it was hers.